

CJP faces heat as protesters left stranded after agitation

KHUSHI MEHROTRA
■ New Delhi

Even as the Cockroach Janata Party (CJP) declared victory and called off its month-long agitation at Jantar Mantar following Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan's resignation and the Government's acceptance of its key demands on Saturday, criticism has mounted over the fate of volunteers and protesters allegedly left behind after the movement ended.

By Monday evening, the protest site at Jantar Mantar had been completely cleared. The tents were gone, walls bearing graffiti and protest slogans had been repainted, and there was little to indicate that the venue had hosted one of the capital's longest-running student-led agitations. But even as the site returned to normal, concerns emerged over several protesters, volunteers and journalists who had travelled to Delhi for the agitation and were reportedly left stranded without money, food or accommodation.

Independent politician and author Meghnad, who had been a regular presence at the protest, returned to Jantar



As a few protests continued at Jantar Mantar on Monday, remnants of the month-long CJP agitation lay scattered near the site, two days after the protest ended

Mantar on Sunday despite the CJP leadership having vacated the site. According to posts shared on his social media accounts, he found several volunteers, protesters and local journalists unable to return home due to financial constraints. Meghnad said he personally helped some of them before appealing for support through an Instagram reel, following which several people came forward with monetary assistance. Those stranded were also provided temporary accommodation at the Indian Youth Congress office in Raisina Hill.

Meghnad also wrote on his social media pages that volunteer help desks had

been set up at New Delhi and Hazrat Nizamuddin railway stations to assist stranded protesters and volunteers. According to him, those carrying valid identity and travel documents were being helped with arrangements to return to their hometowns as efforts continued to support those left without resources after the protest concluded.

The developments have triggered criticism of the CJP on social media, with users accusing the organisation of abandoning those who had participated in the month-long movement. The criticism intensified after videos surfaced showing CJP chief spokesperson Sourav Das and Ashutosh Ranka cele-

brating what they described as the movement's victory with some volunteers in Delhi.

Several social media users also questioned the timing of the celebrations, pointing out that some protesters were allegedly still being picked up and questioned by state police over their involvement in the demonstrations.

Responding to the criticism, Das defended the celebratory videos in a post on X, saying they reflected the culture of a younger generation of activists. "It just goes to show that the Government and godi anchors simply do not understand the language of Gen Z and younger generations.

"We can sit on the road for as long as it takes. We can protest while dancing. We can organise while sipping cold coffee. We can fight for change without looking the way previous generations think a movement should look (no shade on anyone!).

"That's just how this generation is. Confident, creative, resilient, and impossible to stereotype. "The uncles and aunties can keep complaining. They'll just have to deal with us!"

Court grants bail to chef in Malviya Nagar fire case

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A Delhi court on Monday granted bail to the head chef arrested in connection with the fire at a Malviya Nagar hotel that claimed 23 lives last month, saying merely performing his routine duties in the kitchen could not, at this stage, be treated as criminal negligence.

The blaze erupted at the Flourish Stays Bed and Breakfast in Malviya Nagar's Hauz Rani area on June 3, following which head chef Keshar Negi was arrested over allegations of negligence.

Granting bail to Negi, who has been in judicial custody since June 6, Additional Sessions Judge Samar Vishal said in the order, "Operating kitchen appliances was an integral part of his employment as a chef and was the very duty for which he had been engaged. Performance of those routine duties cannot, without more, be treated as constituting culpable negligence or criminal liability."

The court directed Negi to furnish a personal bond of Rs 50,000 with one surety of the like amount and comply with conditions, including joining the investigation whenever



required, not influencing witnesses, and not leaving India without prior permission of the trial court.

Maintaining that the prosecution failed to demonstrate any compelling necessity for Negi's continued custody, the court said the interests of justice could be safeguarded by imposing appropriate bail conditions.

"Merely because the applicant was present in the kitchen and was performing his assigned duties cannot be equated with criminal negligence or with responsibility for the safety of the entire hotel," the judge said.

Negi was arrested along with hotel owner Lovkesh Bajaj and accountant Jay Mishra, in whose name the hotel's licence was issued.

The prosecution alleged that Negi was responsible for the day-to-day functioning of the kitchen and had switched on the electric oil fryer and other appliances shortly before the fire broke out. It also relied on a witness statement claiming that he had previously been cautioned to exercise care while operating kitchen equipment.

Opposing the bail plea, the prosecution argued that the investigation was at a crucial stage, with the forensic report on the cause of the fire still awaited. It also expressed apprehension that Negi could influence witnesses if released.

The court, however, noted that the prosecution itself had acknowledged that the

exact origin and cause of the fire were yet to be scientifically established.

It said there was no material to show that Negi, a salaried employee, was responsible for the building's structural safety, LPG installation, fire safety mechanisms, statutory licences or other safety infrastructure, which prima facie fell within the domain of the hotel management.

"The pendency of expert reports cannot, by itself, justify indefinite incarceration, particularly when the scientific determination of the cause of fire is to be undertaken by independent expert agencies and does not require the applicant's continued custodial detention," it said.

DDA to plant 1,81,700 trees and shrubs in Delhi Ridge, remove 16,240 invasive plants

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Development Authority is undertaking ecological restoration of approximately 120 hectares across four Ridge areas in Delhi under directions from Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu. DDA set a target of planting 1,81,700 indigenous trees and shrubs this season while removing around 16,240 invasive trees and shrubs to restore the original native forest ecosystem, as part of the 70 Lakh Plantation Mission launched on July 7.

The four Ridge areas covered are South Central Ridge, Central Ridge, Kamla Nehru Ridge, and Nanakpura Ridge. The programme envisions planting nearly 1,00,000 indigenous trees and 81,700 native shrubs across these areas during the current plantation season, which runs from the first week of July to mid-September 2026.

As of Monday, DDA has already planted 8,29,313 saplings across Delhi, comprising 35,570 trees and 7,93,743 shrubs. In the Ridge areas specifically, 27,062 saplings have been planted

so far, including 12,506 trees and 14,556 shrubs.

The indigenous species being planted include Bargad, Peepal, Neem, Sheesham, Arjun, Jamun, Dhak, Dhau, and Khejri among trees, alongside native shrubs including Harshringar, Karonda, Phalsa, Nigundi, and Curry Leaf. Naturally occurring native vegetation at the sites has been retained and protected rather than cleared.

What distinguishes this initiative from conventional plantation drives is its grid-based, multi-tier ecological model. Each plantation grid



comprises five native trees and four native shrubs planted at carefully determined spacing to ensure proper canopy development,

root growth, sunlight penetration, and resource utilisation. Designated Ficus clusters are incorporated at regular intervals to enhance

long-term ecological stability. The layout is designed to allow the plantation to gradually evolve into a self-sustaining native forest rather than requiring permanent maintenance.

The multi-tier model recreates the layered structure of natural forests through canopy trees, middle-storey vegetation, understory shrubs, and ground cover. As the plantation matures, it is expected to restore native habitats for birds, butterflies, pollinators, and other wildlife, improve soil fertility, reduce erosion, and enhance

groundwater recharge.

The LG had visited the Ridge in May 2026, reviewed its ecological condition, and directed DDA to undertake scientific restoration measures, specifically replacing invasive vegetation with native species, combined with sustained post-plantation maintenance. The restoration programme is being implemented in accordance with the approved Working Plan for the Delhi Ridge.

The environmental benefits extend beyond biodiversity. The restored Ridge is expected to enhance carbon

sequestration, filter airborne particulate matter, reduce dust pollution, moderate local temperatures, and mitigate the Urban Heat Island effect, which causes dense urban areas like Delhi to retain significantly more heat than surrounding areas.

DDA has partnered with Resident Welfare Associations, educational institutions, religious organisations, corporate institutions, and volunteer groups to involve citizens in the programme and build a sense of shared ownership toward Delhi's natural assets.

SMFG

Grihashakti

Najaf Abadi, Nagay Vishwak

Corporate Off.: 503 & 504, 5th Floor, G-Block, Inspire BKC, BKC Main Road, Bandra Kurla Complex, Bandra (E), Mumbai - 400051

Regd. Off.: Commerzone IT Park, Tower B, 1st Floor, No. 111, Mount Poonamallee Road, Porur, Chennai - 600116, TN

POSSESSION NOTICE FOR IMMOVABLE PROPERTY [Appendix IV] Rule 8(1)

WHEREAS the undersigned being the Authorized Officer of SMFG India Home Finance Co. Ltd. a Housing Finance Company (fully registered with National Housing Bank (Fully Owned by RBI)) (hereinafter referred to as "SMHFC") under Securitisation and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 (54 of 2002), and in exercise of the powers conferred under Section 13(12) read with Rule 3 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002 issued Demand Notice dated mentioned below under Section 13(2) of the said Act calling upon you being the borrowers (names mentioned below) to repay the amount mentioned in the said notice and interest thereon within 60 days from the date of receipt of the said notice. The borrowers mentioned herein below having failed to repay the amount, notice is hereby given to the borrowers mentioned herein below and to the public in general that the undersigned has **Taken Possession** of the property described herein below in exercise of powers conferred on me under sub-section (4) of Section 13 of the Act read with Rule 8 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002. The borrowers mentioned herein above in particular and the public in general are hereby cautioned not to deal with said property and any dealings with the property will be subject to the charge of "SMHFC" for an amount as mentioned herein under and interest thereon.

Sl. No.	Name of the Borrower(s) / Guarantor(s) LAN	Description of Secured Assets (Immovable Property)	Demand Notice Date & Amt.	Date of Possession
1	LAN :- 61083001177934 1. Sanjeev Kumar, S/o. Mani Chand 2. Priyanka Daksh W/o. Sanjeev Kumar	A Residential Plot, Which is The Western Part of Plot No. A-1, Measuring 90 Sq. Yards or 75.25 Sq.25 Sq. Mtrs. Consisting of Khassa No. 753 Situated At Triveni Enclave Revenue Vill. Khadauli Pargana Tehsil & Dist. Meerut. Boundaries - East :- Part of Plot A-1, West - Plot No. Plot No. 196; North :- Rasta 20 Ft Wide; South :- Plot No. 115.	16.02.2026 Rs. 4,00,957.31/- (Rs. Four Lakh Nine Hundred Fifty Seven & Paise Thirty One Only) along with interest as on 09.02.2026	24.07.2026
2	LAN :- 610839211302664 1. Arjun Deshraj, S/o. Deshraj 2. Manju, W/o. Arjun	A Residential Plot, Having An Area 165 Sq. Yards i. e. 137.95 Sq. Mtrs. Consisting of Khassa No. 463 Situated At Mohalla Adarsh Nagar, Old Ward No. 8, Garhmukteshwar Revenue Vill. Garh Bangar, Pargana & Tehsil Garhmukteshwar & Dist. Hapur. Boundaries - East :- Rasta 20 Ft Wide; West :- Plot of Other; North - Plot Others; South :- Rasta 28 Ft Wide.	16.04.2026 Rs. 39,64,257.30 (Rs. Thirty Nine Lakh Sixty Four Thousand Two Hundred Fifty Seven & Paise Thirty Only) along with interest as on 09.04.2026	24.07.2026

Place :- Meerut, Uttar Pradesh

Date :- 24.07.2026

Sd/-
Authorized Officer,
SMFG INDIA HOME FINANCE CO. LTD.

KENDRIYA VIDYALAYA NUH

Mewat Model School, Village Chilawali, Gram Panchayat Jaisinghpur, Indri Block, Nuh, Haryana 122107 Ph. No.: 01267-292298

WALK IN INTERVIEW

To prepare the list of names of the Balvatika Teachers on part-time contract basis for the academic session 2026-27, an interview will be organized on 07.08.2026 at Kendriya Vidyalaya Nuh, Haryana.

REGISTRATION TIME - Date: 07.08.2026, 08:00 am to 11:30 pm
Time for Interview : Date: 07.08.2026, 10:00 am to 01:30 pm
Note: For detailed qualification of post kindly visit <https://nuh.kvs.ac.in/>
It is mandatory to bring duly filled application form along with photocopies of all documents and original certificates (for verification) and colour photographs.
LINK AND QR CODE FOR APPLICATION FORM
<https://docs.google.com/document/d/1Nensf0DBtPPp5qLQG76qVhmLEQZ7Uzt>

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Public Notice

This is to inform the general public that (1) Mr. Satya Prakash (2) Mr. Sanjay Bansal are the Possessors of the Plot No. 22, area measuring 55 Sq. Yds (Out of 100 Sq. Yds), Out of Aranj Khewad No. 24/24, Khatamli no. 24, Mtr. No. 13, Kila no. 13, situated at Krishna Colony Waqa Majra Sahpur, Tehsil & Distt. Faridabad, Haryana-121003. They are in Possession through SPA, AFS dated 06.05.2026 SPA regd. no. 26/25/IV/3288 executed by Ms. Neeta Kumar in favour of (1) Mr. Satya Prakash (2) Mr. Sanjay Bansal in respect of Plot no. 22, area measuring 55 Sq. Yds (Out of 100 Sq. Yds), Out of Aranj Khewad No. 24/24, Khatamli no. 24, Mtr. No. 13, Kila no. 13.

OR

(1) Mr. Satya Prakash (2) Mr. Sanjay Bansal Intends to mortgage the said plot with SMFG India Home Finance Co. Ltd. Any objections or concerns regarding this transaction should be raised within a period of 7 days from the date of this public notice. Any objections submitted after the completion of this 7-days period will not be considered binding with respect to the said property or the interests of our client. If anyone wishes to raise an objection, please do so within the stipulated 7-days period by contacting Law Veritas: North (Advocates & Legal Consultants) at Office No. 11, 1st Floor, Building No. A-4/A, Sector-16, Noida, Uttar Pradesh-201303; Landline: +91012-04498711, e-mail: accounts@lvnorth.in

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Public Notice

Police seek death sentence for Tahir Hussain, 4 others in IB officer murder case

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Police on Monday sought the death sentence for former AAP councillor Tahir Hussain and four others convicted in the sensational murder case of IB officer Ankit Sharma, saying that "they fell to the level of being animals" while relentlessly assaulting the victim.

The submissions were made before Additional Sessions Judge Praveen Singh who was also informed that Sharma was abducted, relentlessly assaulted and then killed by convicted persons. The court reserved its order for July 31 after hearing arguments from both prosecution and defence counsels of all five convicts.

Special public prosecutor Madhukar Pandey submitted

that Sharma was brutally killed and was not shown any mercy by the convicts, so they should not be given any leniency.

"Those who are asking for mercy today should have shown mercy themselves. No mercy was shown from anyone's side. No one even took Ankit to the hospital. They are asking for mercy after committing such a brutal murder," Pandey said. They kept torturing him even after he died, he said.

"Ankit Sharma was abducted and relentlessly assaulted before he was killed. A total of 51 wounds were found on his body; 18 of those were inflicted with sharp weapons. The nature of the weapons used shows the intent and diabolical nature of the crime. They fell to the level of being animals. Even after the victim

died, they continued the assault," he said. Pandey also asserted that the nature of the crime was heinous and brutal, and the convicts should be handed the death sentence.

"This was a cold-blooded murder. These people turned into butchers during the crime. There was not even a single cloth except underwear on Sharma's body. These people should be kept behind bars, (and) given the death sentence," he said.

"The manner of this killing is not to be seen in isolation, but with the 53 people killed in the riots. So, the context also became relevant, the context in which the riots took place," he added. It was also submitted that the deceased never provoked anyone, but the convicts themselves got involved in the murder.



"My humble submission is that the commission of this offence, and the conduct of the convicts, was such that no leniency should be shown to the convicts. There was no provocation in this case. They deliberately got involved in a cold-blooded murder. In this case, the balance of sentencing policy should be shifted towards the death sentence,"

Pandey said.

"Those who did not show mercy to people during the riots should not be entitled to seek mercy," he added.

Representing Hussain, advocates Rajiv Mohan and Tara Narula opposed the state's contention and argued that no specific role had been attributed to their client and it should also be considered

that out of the 11 accused, six were acquitted in the case.

"Every convicted person should not be given the death sentence. Aggravating circumstances should be considered first and then the mitigating circumstances. Of conviction, out of the 11 accused, six have been acquitted," advocate Mohan said.

He contended that the death penalty is only given in the rarest of rare cases, and in this case, the judgement only mentions the presence of a mob at the crime scene, but not about the specific role of the convicts.

"The punishment of death cannot be determined merely based on the injuries sustained. His (Hussain) conduct was good in jail during custody. The court had recorded the statements

of 91 witnesses, after which only five out of the 11 accused were convicted by the court," he said.

Hussain's counsel also said that throughout the trial, no evidence of criminal conspiracy (under IPC Section 120B) was presented before the court. "Police themselves were unable to control the violent mob, and in such a situation, a single individual cannot be held responsible for the murder. He should be given a chance to reform," Mohan argued.

Advocate Narula contended that Hussain is the sole breadwinner of his family and has a wife and three children. "All three (children) were minors when he surrendered. Though his application was rejected in the Rouse Avenue court due to

non-jurisdiction of the court, it should be considered that he came out to surrender. His guidance must be required as his daughter grows up," she argued.

On July 13, the court convicted Hussain and four others for the murder of Sharma, who was attacked by a mob during the 2020 Delhi riots. His body was later found in a drain.

Hussain was convicted under IPC sections 302 (murder), 365 (kidnapping or abducting with intent secretly and wrongfully to confine a person), 147 (rioting), 148 (rioting armed with a deadly weapon), 153A (promoting enmity) and 188 (disobedience to an order duly promulgated by a public servant), read with Section 149 (unlawful assembly).

Police begin crackdown on posts linked to CJP protest targeting PM

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Police began issuing notices to social media accounts directing them to remove "abusive" and "illegal" posts related to the recent Cockroach Janata Party (CJP) protest at Jantar Mantar. Scrutiny of 2,873 people present at and around the CJP protest at the Jantar Mantar has revealed that over 980 of them have previous criminal records, including cases of murder, attempt to murder, robbery, rape, kidnapping, crimes against women, illegal firearms and narcotics. The action extends to content targeting senior political leaders, including Prime Minister Narendra Modi, police sources said on Monday.



cases registered under the Narcotic Drugs and Psychotropic Substances (NDPS) Act, They further said 61 of these individuals have been involved in rape cases, 25 in cases related to outraging modesty of women or molestation, while six have been booked under the Protection of Children from Sexual Offences (POCSO) Act.

According to police sources, dedicated teams are identifying social media accounts that uploaded abusive content, misinformation, deepfakes or material that could attract action under the Information Technology (IT) Act and other applicable laws. Notices are being issued asking users to delete such posts, while social media platforms are also being approached to take action in accordance with the law.

"Our teams are monitoring every single video properly, and we are issuing notices to social media handles involved

in posting fake, deepfake and illegal content," sources said.

The police's Social Media Monitoring Team has been maintaining round-the-clock surveillance of online platforms since the protests began, officials said, adding that the exercise will continue as investigators analyse digital evidence and identify more accounts allegedly involved in circulating misleading or unlawful content.

During the monitoring exercise, Delhi Police also identified over 480 social media handles allegedly linked to Pakistan that were actively circulating fake narratives, rumours and AI-generated videos related to the demonstrations.

"These Pakistan-related handles are the same accounts which were active during Operation Sindoor. Teams are also investigating the IP addresses of these handles," the officer said.

The police recently debunked a viral AI-generat-

ed video claiming that Deputy Commissioner of Police Sumit Jha had resigned over the student protests, calling it "completely fake" and releasing the officer's original footage.

The online crackdown comes amid criticism from several BJP leaders and social media users over the use of abusive language against Prime Minister Narendra Modi and the Union Government during the protests. They have argued that while demonstrations are a constitutional right, public discourse should maintain respect for constitutional offices.

Meanwhile, several content creators whose videos on the CJP protest had garnered millions of views have claimed that their posts were taken down by Meta and X in recent days, coinciding with the police action.

Separately, *The Pioneer* has learnt that the Delhi Police is yet to quash the FIRs registered following the violence on July 20, in which 118 security personnel and more than 80 protesters were injured.

The cases remain under investigation. Additionally, the CJP's demand list included no legal action against protestors who had gathered in Jantar Mantar. However, no written confirmation from the Central Government has been received.

Security tightened as CJP warns of fresh protests over FIRs

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Heightened security deployment will remain in force across New Delhi and Central Delhi districts to maintain law and order as the Cockroach Janata Party (CJP) warned of fresh protests if FIRs registered against demonstrators are not withdrawn.

Responding to the development, a senior police officer said adequate deployment of Delhi Police personnel and paramilitary forces would remain around Jantar Mantar and other sensitive locations in New Delhi and Central Delhi to ensure law and order is maintained.

"Force will be deployed to monitor the current situation and maintain law and order in and around the Jantar Mantar area. However, Jantar Mantar is a designated protest site and security always remains high there," the officer said.



Police are keeping a close watch on the situation and have strengthened security arrangements as a precautionary measure to prevent untoward incidents, the officer said.

Addressing a press conference here, CJP national spokesperson Ashutosh Ranka said the issue of withdrawal of FIRs against protesters was discussed during the third round of talks with the Centre before the 36-day protest at the Jantar Mantar was called off.

"In the third round of talks, we had agreed that all

FIRs filed against protesters and organisers across the country would be withdrawn and no new FIR would be filed against any organiser and protester in future," he said.

Ranka said if the written

agreement was not received by Tuesday and protesters and organisers arrested in connection with the agitation were not released, the outfit would be "forced to protest again".

Govt proposes doubling grants for large Kanwar camps to ₹15 lakh



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Government has proposed significantly enhancing financial assistance for Kanwar Samitis across all camp categories. Chief Minister Rekha Gupta announced on Sunday that the largest camps spread over more than 20,000 square feet and operating for 6 to 12 days set to receive up to ₹15 lakh, up from the current ₹11 lakh. The proposal will be presented before the Delhi Cabinet for approval on Tuesday.

The number of Kanwar camps in Delhi has grown from 170 in 2024 to 308 in 2025. The Government has cited rising pilgrim numbers, inflation, and increasing operational costs as the reasons for the proposed enhancement across all categories.

The revised grant structure covers five size categories. For camps of more than 20,000 square feet, the grant for 6 to 12 days of operation rises from ₹11 lakh to ₹15 lakh, and for 3 to 5 days from ₹6 lakh to ₹9 lakh. For camps between 15,001 and 20,000 square feet, assistance for 3 to 5 days goes from ₹4 lakh to ₹8 lakh, and for 6 to 12 days from ₹7 lakh to ₹9 lakh. For camps between 10,001 and 15,000 square feet, the grant rises from ₹4 lakh to ₹6 lakh for 3

to 5 days and from ₹7 lakh to ₹8 lakh for 6 to 12 days. Camps between 5,001 and 10,000 square feet will receive ₹3 lakh instead of ₹2.50 lakh for 3 to 5 days and ₹5 lakh instead of ₹4 lakh for 6 to 12 days. The smallest camps up to 5,000 square feet will get ₹2 lakh instead of ₹1.50 lakh for 3 to 5 days and ₹3 lakh instead of ₹2 lakh for 6 to 12 days.

Free electricity of up to 1,200 units will continue for all Kanwar Samitis. BSes and TPDDL will ensure timely connections and complete all formalities before the Yatra begins. Any consumption beyond 1,200 units will be borne by the respective Samiti.

On grant disbursement, both the advance instalment and the final instalment will be released directly by the concerned District Magistrate's office, removing the requirement for separate Finance Department approval through Revenue Headquarters for each individual case. The grant will be released through Direct Benefit Transfer in two equal instalments: 50 per cent in advance and 50 per cent after the Yatra concludes, subject to utilisation verification and prescribed conditions. SDMs and Tehsildars will inspect camps before and after the Yatra, with geo-tagged photographs used to ensure transparency.



DU colleges gear up to welcome freshers

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

While the University of Delhi's undergraduate admission process is still underway, its colleges are gearing up to welcome a fresh batch of students with orientation programmes expected to held across campuses Tuesday.

Most colleges have planned department-wise orientation sessions on Tuesday, followed by common induction programmes later this week, with more students expected to join by then through the ongoing second round of admissions. Kirori Mal College Principal Dinesh Khattar said department-wise orientation sessions will begin 9.30 am Tuesday, with around 1,500 newly-admitted students expected to attend.

"We expect nearly 1,500 students for the department-wise orientation. A common orientation programme will be held on August 1 at 5 pm, which the Lt Governor is expected to attend," Khattar said.

He said 28 students from the previous batch of the Four-Year Undergraduate Programme (FYUP) would also be felicitated during the event for publishing their research, including 10 papers indexed in Scopus journals.

Ramjas College Principal Ajay Kumar Arora said department-wise orientation sessions will begin from 9 am on Tuesday in different slots,

while the college's common induction programme, titled 'Deeksharambh 2026', will be organised Friday.

"We expect around 700 to 800 students to attend. The college has a full intake capacity of around 1,500 to 1,600 students, and admissions are still underway," he said.

At Miranda House, the induction programme 'Deeksharambh 2026' began July 24 and will continue till July 28, to familiarise newly-admitted students with the college environment before regular classes begin.

College officials said more than 350 students and their parents participated on the opening day of the programme, while the principal will address students during the main orientation scheduled for Tuesday. Meanwhile, Shaheed Bhagat Singh College Principal Arun Kumar Attree said both department-wise and common orientation programmes will be held on Tuesday at the college's open-air auditorium.

"The morning session will begin 10.30 am, while the common orientation will be held at 4 pm. We expect around 850 to 900 students. The sanctioned intake is around 1,150, but admissions are still in progress as several students are getting upgraded and new names are being added," he said.

Second round of undergraduate admissions under the CSAS (Common Seat Allocation System) is underway at University of Delhi.



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IN FOCUS



Youngsters enjoy a bicycle ride amid rain in New Delhi PANKAJ KUMAR

CJP warns of fresh agitation over FIRs, detentions

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) on Monday warned that it will launch another agitation if all FIRs against student protestors are not withdrawn and all the detained are not released immediately. Issuing this threat, the CJP said it was awaiting the Government's promised written agreement on the withdrawal of criminal cases against protesters and organisers, and warned that it would be forced to resume its agitation if the assurance was not received by Tuesday.

The warning marks the biggest escalation in tensions between the two-month-old outfit and the Centre since the CJP called off its 49-day agitation following the resignation of Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan.

Addressing a press conference, alongwith Rajya Sabha MP Kapil Sibal, CJP spokespersons Ashutosh Ranka and Saurav Das on Monday raised concerns over the alleged



Rajya Sabha MP Kapil Sibal, CJP spokespersons Saurav Das and Ashutosh Ranka during a press conference on the aftermath of the student protests over the NEET paper leak in New Delhi PTI

detention and arrest of protesters and announced measures to provide legal support and preserve evidence from the student-led agitation. "In the third round of talks, we had agreed that all FIRs

filed against protesters and organisers across the country would be withdrawn and no new FIR would be filed against any organiser and protester in future," Ranka said. He said the CJP had submitted

a draft agreement to Union ministers J P Nadda and Jitendra Singh, and it was agreed that the Government would share a written agreement by Tuesday after legal consultations.

"We are waiting for the Government to share the written agreement. We hope a senior Cabinet minister will honour the agreement and FIRs will be withdrawn, no protester or organiser would be harassed, and no cases would be filed in future," he said.

Ranka said if the written agreement was not received by Tuesday and protesters and organisers arrested in connection with the agitation were not released, the outfit would be "forced to protest again".

Ranka said the issue was discussed during the third round of talks with the Government before the 36-day protest at Jantar Mantar was called off on Friday.

"We demand that all the FIRs against the protestors be immediately withdrawn, students be released and no future FIRs be filed

(in line with our agreement) by Delhi police / Central investigative agencies / Police in BJP-allied states, FAILING WHICH WE WILL BE FORCED TO SIT ON PROTEST AGAIN," Ranka wrote on social media.

CJP spokespersons said they had remained in touch with Sibal and sought his legal guidance, particularly over concerns that protesters could face action after the withdrawal of the 36-day agitation. "From day one, legal and medical assistance has been provided to all the students, and coordination with lawyers has been ensured so that they receive support across the country," Das said.

At a joint press conference, CJP spokespersons also introduced "Saakshi", a website aimed at helping protesters and witnesses preserve photos and videos from demonstrations as evidence. The platform allows users to upload original protest footage and generates a cryptographic fingerprint for each file to create a tamper-evident record.

Delhi LG directs MCD to adopt Indore model for waste management

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu on Monday directed the Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) to explore adopting the Indore Municipal Corporation's waste management model on a pilot basis in one civic zone, while reviewing the Capital's preparedness on sanitation, waterlogging, vector-borne diseases and air pollution.

Chairing a high-level review meeting with the MCD Commissioner, additional commissioners and zonal deputy commissioners, the



Delhi Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu

LG reviewed the status of solid waste management, garbage disposal, desilting of drains, waterlogging prevention and measures to curb dengue and malaria during the monsoon season.

On the issue of legacy waste, the LG appreciated the progress made in clearing Delhi's dumpsites but stressed that fresh waste reaching these sites must be scientifically processed simultaneously to prevent further accumulation. He directed officials to establish robust monitoring mechanisms to ensure that daily waste processing keeps pace with the daily inflow.

Expressing concern over the city's waste management practices, the LG noted that nearly half of Delhi's waste is still not segregated at source and around 50 per cent of the waste generated each day continues to be dumped at landfill sites. Referring to the success of Indore's waste management system, he asked officials to examine the feasibility of implementing the Indore Municipal Corporation model as a pilot project in one MCD zone.

The meeting also reviewed traffic congestion caused by toll plazas, the implementation of the PM-UDAY scheme

and measures to tackle vector-borne diseases. Looking ahead to winter, the LG directed officials to prepare a comprehensive action plan to curb air pollution, with a focus on resurfacing roads across the Capital. He also ordered a dedicated road safety audit of MCD-maintained roads to identify and address potential hazards.

Concluding the meeting, the LG said every MCD officer must remain vigilant, proactive and accountable in delivering civic services, adding that a cleaner, safer and more resilient Delhi can only be achieved through timely execution and a strong sense of responsibility.

AISF lodge complaint against Kerala political observer over remarks on Delhi student protest

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Thiruvananthapuram

The pro-CPD student outfit AISF on Monday lodged a police complaint against right-wing political observer TG Mohandas, alleging that his remarks on the recent student agitation in Delhi over NEET question paper leak, amounted to inciting violence and warranted criminal action against him.

In a complaint submitted to the State Police Chief, the All India Students' Federation (AISF) alleged that Mohandas had called for student protesters to be "shot dead", amounting to an appeal for violence and mass killing.

They alleged that the objectionable remarks were made on a YouTube channel while speaking about the students' protest over alleged NEET irregularities. Meanwhile, former chief minister Pinarayi Vijayan also flayed Mohandoss for his remarks and demanded action against him. AISF alleged that such remarks could not be treated as an expression of political opinion, but amounted to a direct challenge to constitutional values, the rule of law and the democratic right to peaceful protest.

According to the complaint, publicly advocating the use of State force to open fire on protesting students, with the possibility of deaths and grievous injuries, was an extremely dangerous statement that promoted violence, undermined the value of human life



TG Mohandas

and had the potential to create fear and social unrest.

It further alleged that, since the remarks were circulated through digital media, they could spread rapidly, encourage violent thinking and promote lawlessness if left unchecked.

The complaint urged police to conduct a scientific examination of the complete video and audio recordings, verify the authenticity and content of the remarks, and investigate. It also sought the registration of a criminal case against Mohandas under all applicable legal provisions and called for an investigation about the YouTube channel that carried the remarks, the source of the video, digital records and its circulation across social media platforms.

In a separate statement, the AISF state executive alleged that Mohandas' remarks reflected an ideology that rejected constitutional values, democratic rights and the principles of Kerala's social reform movement.

19-year-old dies by suicide in Maharashtra over low NEET score

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Ahilyanagar

A 19-year-old girl allegedly died by suicide in Maharashtra's Ahilyanagar district, with a note recovered from her house indicating she was distressed due to low marks in the June 21 NEET examination, a police official said on Monday.

Ankita Sangale, a resident of Jalalpur village in Karjat tehsil, allegedly hanged herself in her house on July 25, he said.

She had recently completed Class 12 and had appeared for the National Eligibility-cum-Entrance Test (NEET) on June 21, the official said.

"We recovered a suicide note from her house. In the note, she stated she was depressed after securing low marks in the NEET examination and was taking the extreme step because of that," the official said.

An accidental death report (ADR) was registered at Karjat police station, and further investigation is underway, he added. The May 3 NEET-UG exam was cancelled after a paper leak, following which a re-examination was held on June 21. The results of the re-exam were declared on July 16, with more than 11.21 lakh students qualifying.



More officers inducted into team probing Tripura DGP's death

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Agartala

Seven more officials have been inducted into the team probing the death of former Tripura DGP Anurag Dhankar, an official order issued by West Tripura SP Namit Pathak said on Monday.

The move comes amid demands by the CPI(M) and the Congress for a judicial probe into Dhankar's death. Dhankar, who had led the CBI probe into the alleged ₹13,000-crore Punjab National Bank fraud involving diamondaire Nirav Modi and the reinvestigation into the 1984 anti-Sikh riots, was found hanging in the washroom attached to his chamber at the state police headquarters here on July 20.

"In the interest of ensuring a thorough, coordinated and expeditious investigation of the case, the probe team headed by Pathak has been reconstituted by adding seven more officials," the order said.

It said a daily briefing would be



Anurag Dhankar

held to review the progress of the investigation, discuss case developments, assign tasks and formulate the strategy for further investigation.

"A daily progress report containing the investigation carried out, evidence collected, technical analysis undertaken and further action proposed shall be submitted to the West Tripura SP by all officers concerned," it said.

Earlier in the day, a CPI(M) legislature party delegation met Governor Indrasena Reddy Nallu and sought his intervention for a High Court-monitored probe into Dhankar's death.

"Like us, people across the country find it hard to believe that an officer like Dhankar, who successfully led the CBI in several high-profile cases, died by suicide by hanging in his office chamber, the most secure place in the state. His body was found in the washroom attached to his chamber in full uniform, with his cap lying on the floor," CPI(M) state secretary Jitendra Chaudhury told reporters.

He claimed that Dhankar had received the ceremonial guard of honour at the police headquarters, a weekly ritual, barely an hour before the incident and showed no signs of stress or tension.

"The officer who was entrusted with the security of 44 lakh people in Tripura would end his life in this manner? There are reasonable

Priyank Kharge directs Karnataka DGP to curb illegal sand mining across State

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Bengaluru

Karnataka Home Minister Priyank Kharge has directed the state DGP to completely curb illegal mining, storage, and transportation of sand across the State, his office said on Monday.

Based on this direction, the Director General of Police (DGP) has issued a comprehensive circular to all Police Commissioners, Inspector Generals of Police, Deputy Inspector Generals of Police, and Superintendents of Police to ensure strict enforcement with regard to sand mining, storage and sales, officials said on Monday.

According to a statement from the minister's office, illegal sand mining not only causes severe environmental damage but also adversely affects law and order and results in significant loss of Government revenue.

The Government has adopted a policy of zero tolerance towards



such illegal activities, and the circular has been issued to ensure strict and uniform enforcement across the state, it said.

"Illegal sand mining and transportation are not merely the plundering of the state's natural resources; they are serious offences that pose a challenge to law and order and the larger public interest. The Government will not tolerate any illegal activity. Clear directions have been issued to the Police Department to enforce the law strictly and take firm legal action against the offenders," Kharge said.

The circular directs the District and Taluk-level task forces already constituted to function more effectively, it said.

"It clearly states that the responsibility of identifying areas where illegal sand mining is taking place, maintaining constant surveillance, preventing illegal transportation and storage, and initiating legal action rests with

the concerned police officers," the statement said.

The statement said that police officers have also been instructed to coordinate closely with the Departments of Mines and Geology, Revenue, and Forest to prevent illegal transportation of sand, particularly along interstate routes and border areas.

They have also been directed to ensure that investigation and enforcement centres function effectively and quickly to bring any shortage of essential infrastructure to the notice of the concerned department.

"No one is above the law. Stringent legal action will be taken against those involved in the illegal sand trade. Likewise, officers found guilty of dereliction of duty will face strict disciplinary action. Protecting the state's natural resources and ensuring that the rule of law is upheld remain the Government's highest priorities," Kharge said.

It said that every police unit has been instructed to gather intelligence on illegal sand mining activities within its jurisdiction, conduct surprise raids wherever necessary, and invoke the provisions of the Goonda Act against habitual offenders involved in the illegal sand trade. The circular further directs that every monthly crime review meeting should include a station-wise review of cases relating to illegal sand mining, transportation, and storage, with appropriate instructions issued to subordinate officers.

District and Taluk-level Task Force meetings are also to be held regularly to strengthen inter-departmental coordination and effectively curb these illegal activities, it said. The circular warns that if any police unit fails to prevent illegal sand mining and transportation within its jurisdiction, appropriate disciplinary action will be initiated against the officers concerned.

FROM PAGE - 1

In the 2024-25 financial year, the trust earned about ₹327 crore, mostly from donations. Early figures for 2025-26 show voluntary contributions between ₹98 and ₹150 crore, plus significant interest from a fund of over ₹1,800 crore, mainly in fixed deposits. Construction and operations have used up thousands of crores since 2020.

Bihar cop suspended for firing AK-47 at Siwan...

However, other reports said three protesters were shot and treated at a hospital in Patna, including a 15-year-old boy who was hit in the neck. Their conditions were later described as stable. Police also reported that some officers,

including the SP, were injured by stone-pelting. Across the State, the bandh led to dozens of FIRs, hundreds of arrests (about 400-450), and damage to public property.

Madras HC junks Vijay's Karur job order

It noted that the exercise of executive power must be within the Constitutional limits.

Meanwhile, official sources indicated that the Government is considering approaching the Supreme Court to challenge the High Court order.

Also, the court cited instances of loss of lives in mishaps at firework units and also due to motor accidents. In such cases, the kin of victims are pro-

vided ex-gratia and not jobs on compassionate grounds. While the Advocate General Vijay Narayan argued that the appointments were a policy decision, the petitioners contended that there was a Government Order in force that needed to be complied with for providing jobs on compassionate grounds. Also, the court said the order providing Government jobs to kin of stampede victims will open "floodgates" for others to seek similar employment.

On July 10, Chief Minister Vijay distributed appointment orders to 31 persons who are relatives of those who died in the stampede on September 27, 2025 at Karur. In a rally held by TVK, which was addressed by party chief Vijay, a stampede broke out and 41 people were killed and over 60 were injured.

SC orders forensic auditor in Ram temple...

Hidden cameras in the counting room reportedly recorded staff concealing cash in clothing, pockets, and shoes. Standard procedures were violated: personnel were not frisked, CCTV footage was kept for only 45 days instead of 180, and Ramashankar Yadav, a former driver of then-general secretary Champat Rai, held keys to several donation boxes.

On June 13, the State Government set up a three-member SIT led by Lucknow Divisional Commissioner Vijay Vishwas Pant, along with IGP Kiran S and a special secretary from the finance department.

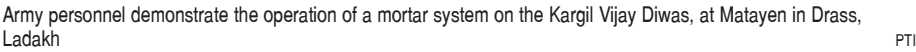
Their first report, given on June 23, found theft

in about 70 cases and led to an FIR on June 25 against eight people involved in counting: Avinash Shukla, Anukalp Mishra, Lavkush Mishra, Manish Kumar Yadav, Karunesh Pandey, Ramashankar Mishra, Subhash Srivastava, and Tinnu Yadav.

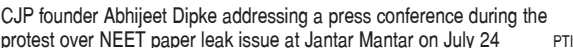
All were arrested, and nearly ₹80 lakh in cash, foreign currency, and jewellery were recovered. Six of the accused got their jobs through recommendations from trust officials.

Champat Rai and trustee Anil Mishra resigned for moral reasons. Many petitions were filed with the Supreme Court seeking a CBI-led or court-monitored investigation, a forensic audit, and reforms to protect the trust's property. The court did not hold urgent hearings during the vacation, but from mid-July it requested an IPS-led investigation free of political influence.

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Drass/Jammu



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi

**ASHOKE RAJ** ■ New Delhi

Inauguration of

by

Hon'ble Union Minister of Civil Aviation

 **Sri Guru Ram Dass Jee International Airport, Amritsar**



CBC 03401/13/0002/2627



States Focus

ED arrests ex-chairman of CGSPC Taman Singh



LORD JAGANNATH'S ANNUAL RATH YATRA CONCLUDES

The annual Rath Yatra of Lord Jagannath and his siblings ended here on Monday in a ritual called “*Niladri Bije*” when the deities returned to the 12th-century shrine after spending 12 days outside.

The Niladri Bije ritual marks the culmination of the annual Rath Yatra which started on July 16 when Lord Balabhadra, Devi Subhadra and Lord Jagannath boarded chariots to travel to their birthplace at Shree Gundicha Temple, 2.6 kilometres from the main shrine.

The idols, which remained seated on their respective chariots since the Bahuda Yatra or the return car festival on July 24, were taken inside the temple's sanctum sanctorum through a ceremonial procession one by one and placed on the sacred platform inside the shrine.

(PTI)

FORMER ODISHA MINISTER SUSANT SINGH PASSES AWAY

Former Odisha minister Susant Singh died while undergoing treatment at a private hospital in Bhubaneswar early on Monday, his family said.

Singh was 53 and had been suffering from a liver-related ailment for a long time, they said.

A prominent leader from western Odisha, Singh represented the Bhatil Assembly constituency for three consecutive terms after winning the elections in 2009, 2014 and 2019 on a BJD ticket. He, however, lost the 2024 assembly polls to the BJP's Irais Acharya.

Singh served as the Labour and Employment Minister and later as the Rural Development Minister in the Naveen Patnaik Government.

(PTI)



PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ New Delhi

The Raipur office of the Enforcement Directorate (ED) arrested Taman Singh Sonwani, the former Chairman of the Chhattisgarh Public Service Commission (CGPSC), on Sunday. He was arrested under the Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA), 2002, due to allegations of corruption, leaked question papers, and irregularities in the 2020 and 2021 CGPSC State Service Examinations.

Sonwani, who is a retired IAS officer and former CGPSC Chairman, appeared before the Special Court (PMLA) in Raipur. The court placed him in ED custody for seven days, until July 30, 2026, for further questioning. This is the first time the Enforcement Directorate is looking into the money-laundering part of a case that state agencies and the Central Bureau of Investigation

have already examined.

The ED started its investigation after the Economic Offences Wing and Anti-Corruption Bureau in Raipur filed a First Information Report. In 2024, the CBI also opened a case. The CBI began its probe after the Bharatiya Janata Party took office in Chhattisgarh in November 2023, following complaints about irregularities during the previous Congress government. The CBI arrested Sonwani in November 2024, and he remains in judicial custody for related cases.

The ED claims that while Sonwani was CGPSC Chairman, he worked with other officials and private individuals to leak confidential question papers and influence the selection process in return for illegal payments. According to the agency, this resulted in his relatives and other favoured candidates being appointed to senior positions like Deputy Collector and Deputy



Superintendent of Police.

Investigators found that in 2021, the CGPSC recruitment rules changed to remove the word 'nephew' from the definition of 'family.' Authorities believe this change made it possible for Sonwani's relatives to be selected without breaking conflict-of-interest rules.

The ED says illegal money was col-

lected in both cash and bank transfers. Investigators found that about 745 lakh was sent from Bajrang Power Limited, linked to industrialist Shравan Kumar Goyal, as Corporate Social Responsibility donations to a Rural Development Committee run by Sonwani's family. This money was supposedly for a college that did not exist. Authorities say this payment was made so

Goyal's son and daughter-in-law could be appointed as Deputy Collectors. The CBI had earlier explained that question papers were taken to Sonwani's home, copied, resealed, and then passed on through intermediaries before the exams.

The CBI's investigation culminated in a final chargesheet naming about 29 people, including CGPSC officials, coaching centre operators, industrialists, and well-connected candidates. Several recruitment exams held during Sonwani's time as Chairman are being reviewed due to claims that many top candidates were related to officials or other influential figures.

The ED officials are likely to question Sonwani again to trace the flow of funds, identify additional beneficiaries, and recover illegal funds. The investigation is ongoing as agencies try to uncover the full extent of the alleged conspiracy.

MP fails to return forest land despite SC order

UMESH NIGAM
■ Bhopal

More than a year after the Supreme Court directed Madhya Pradesh to hand over forest land that had been illegally allotted to private individuals, institutions and the Revenue Department, the State government has failed to fully implement the order, with thousands of hectares still awaiting transfer to the Forest Department.

The Supreme Court, in its May 15, 2025 order, had directed that all forest land recorded as protected forests but under the control of the Revenue Department or allotted to private entities should be vacated and transferred to the Forest Department within one year. Following the verdict, the Centre's Empowered Committee also instructed the state to ensure compliance, and the then Additional Chief Secretary (Forest) issued directions to all divisional commissioners, collectors and forest officials to



identify such land and complete the transfer.

However, despite the deadline having passed, the process remains incomplete. According to official information, nearly 51,463.84 hectares of forest land were found to have been allotted to private individuals and institutions. Of

this, only about 39,361.06 hectares have so far been denotified or otherwise processed for transfer, while a substantial area remains outside the Forest Department's control, raising concerns over compliance with the apex court's order.

The report also points to

alleged contradictions in official actions. A letter issued by the Principal Chief Conservator of Forests (PCCF) on February 4, 2025 reportedly stated that 153.57 hectares of protected forest land in village Yaranagar, Budhni tehsil of Sehore district, had already been transferred to the Revenue Department through a 1973 notification. However, despite this, no fresh notification has been issued to restore the land to the Forest Department, even though portions of it were allotted in December 2024 to an industrial project. The report alleges that the PCCF's communication runs contrary to the Supreme Court's directions, which require all such forest land to remain under the Forest Department.

The delay in implementing the Supreme Court's order has raised questions over administrative inaction and the state's compliance with judicial directives on the protection and management of forest land.

Jharkhand Government protecting officers involved in treasury scam: BJP

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Ranchi

The Jharkhand BJP on Monday accused the JMM-led alliance Government of protecting officers allegedly involved in “illegal withdrawal” of money from district treasuries in the State.

The saffron party also asserted that the progress of the investigation into the matter has been tardy.

“The State's finance minister himself admitted that ₹10,000 crore is unaccounted for in the treasury. This is not a small amount. The minister claimed that the scam occurred over the last seven or eight years, but did not disclose how it happened,” State BJP spokesperson Pratul Shahdeo told reporters.



He alleged that action is being taken only against the “small players”, while senior officers “are being protected” in the investigation. “The special investigation team (SIT), which was constituted to probe into the scam, includes officers during whose tenure as SPs the treasury scam took place. No fair or impartial probe can be expected in such a scenario,” Shahdeo asserted.

Mizoram seeks disaster status for African swine fever outbreak

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Mizoram Minister of State for Disaster Management and Rehabilitation Prof Lalnilawma met senior leadership of the National Disaster Management Authority in New Delhi on Sunday. The aim of the meeting was to review the State's disaster risk reduction priorities, requesting that African Swine Fever (ASF) be notified as a disaster to enable financial assistance for farmers affected by the outbreak, while also discussing progress on earthquake and landslide mitigation proposals.

The meeting focused on Mizoram's vulnerability to earthquakes, landslides, forest fires, and other natural hazards. Discussions reviewed the status of proposals submitted under the National Earthquake Risk Mitigation Programme and the National Landslide Risk Mitigation Programme, along with mitigation projects the state has put forward for consideration.

On African Swine Fever, Lalnilawma told NDMA that the outbreak has caused significant economic losses in the state and requested that the disease be formally notified as a disaster. Such a notification would allow the state to access disaster relief funds and other financial assistance mechanisms to support affected livestock owners and farmers. ASF has devast-



tated pig populations across several northeastern States in recent years, causing severe economic damage to communities where pig farming is a primary livelihood.

The meeting also covered the strengthening of the State Disaster Management Authority's institutional capacity, expansion of community-based disaster preparedness through the Aapda Mitra programme, and the promotion of greater regional coordination among the northeastern states on disaster preparedness matters.

NDMA emphasised the importance of risk-informed land-use planning,

resilient infrastructure, enforcement of building by-laws, and community awareness as essential tools for reducing disaster risk. The authority also encouraged Mizoram to continue strengthening school safety measures, including school disaster management plans and regular preparedness activities.

NDMA reaffirmed its commitment to extending technical guidance and institutional support to the Government of Mizoram for implementing disaster risk reduction initiatives.

Mizoram's geographic and geological profile makes it one of India's

more disaster-prone states. It falls in Seismic Zone V, the highest risk category for earthquakes in India. The state's hilly terrain and heavy monsoon rainfall make it acutely vulnerable to landslides, which have caused deaths, displacement, and infrastructure damage repeatedly in recent years. Forest fires are an additional seasonal hazard. The combination of these risks, set against limited financial and institutional capacity, makes central government support and the kind of technical engagement reflected in Sunday's meeting particularly important for the State.

The Aapda Mitra programme, which the meeting discussed expanding, trains community volunteers in first response to natural disasters. It is designed to reduce the dependence of vulnerable communities on state and central response machinery during the critical first hours and days after a disaster, when professional rescue teams may not yet have reached affected areas.

The request to notify ASF of a disaster is part of a broader national debate about whether animal disease outbreaks that cause large-scale economic damage should be formally classified under the disaster relief framework, which would give affected states access to the State Disaster Response Fund and the National Disaster Response Fund for compensation and recovery support.

Return to West Bengal, plenty jobs now, says CM Suvendu Adhikari

SAUGAR SENGUPTA
■ Kolkata

Bengal Chief Minister Suvendu Adhikari on Monday appealed to the migrant workers to return to the State, assuring them of “ample job opportunities” in the changed “double engine” scenario.

The Chief Minister, who was reportedly flying off to Delhi for a meeting with 20 NCPI MPs who had earlier broken away from the Trinamool Congress, said, “I appeal to all the migrant workers to return to Bengal as there will be ample job opportunities because we are passing through an ‘Amrit Kaal of development (an era of endless development).”

Adhikari earlier announced a compensation of ₹5 lakh each for the kin of those 11 Bengali workers who died in the tunnel collapse in Sikkim. Besides, ₹4 lakh was to come from the Sikkim government, ₹5 lakh from NHPC, ₹5 lakh from the construction company where the workers were employed, and ₹2 lakh from the Prime Minister's National Relief Fund.

The Chief Minister said that an ice-cream factory was coming up in North Bengal — alongside the one in South Bengal — and soon a number of closed tea gardens would open up, restoring and creating new job opportunities. He said that the State was encouraging Makhana cultivation in Malda district besides providing special impetus to pineapple, maize and premium Tulai



West Bengal Chief Minister Suvendu Adhikari at the Jalpesh Temple during the Shrabani Mela in Jalpaiguri district on Monday

PTI

Panji rice production in the North Bengal area. The Chief Minister had a few days ago inaugurated an extended section of Shyam Steel, which would invest ₹15,000 crore for the purpose.

Meanwhile, in a parallel development, the State Government had given directions to all the District Magistrates concerned to hasten up the Kolkata-Varanasi expressway project, which had hit a roadblock during the previous TMC Government.

According to sources, State Chief Secretary Manoj Kumar Agarwal had instructed the respective DMs of six districts through which the expressway would pass to take necessary steps to facilitate work. The road is to pass through six districts of Kolkata, Howrah, Hooghly, West Midnapore, Bankura and Purulia, cutting short the travel time to about 8 hours from the present 12 hours.

Pradhan gets hero’s welcome at Parliament

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Dharmendra Pradhan, who resigned as Education Minister last week following students' protests over the NEET row, got a hero's welcome on Monday when he arrived at the Parliament House and said, “I am a street fighter. Not an AC-room activist.”

Several BJP and NDA MPs welcomed him as he got off his car and shouted slogans like “Dharmendra Pradhan zindabad.” There were scenes of jubilation as the MPs closed in around him, with one MP putting a traditional cap on the ex- Minister's head and draping a shawl around his shoulders.

Opposition MPs at the same time shouted slogans like ‘*Chor Chor, Paper Chor*’ and hit out at the ruling dis-



Former Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan being greeted during the Monsoon session of Parliament in New Delhi on Monday

PTI

pensation for felicitating Pradhan.

“It happens,” Congress MP Jairam Ramesh told Pradhan, who resigned on Saturday. “Nothing happened,” the MP shot back, adding, “I am a streetfighter, not an AC-room activist.”

Pradhan appeared smiling as his colleagues welcomed

him. One BJP MP remarked that it was perhaps the first time a Union minister had resigned without facing any personal allegation.

The brief exchange between Ramesh and Pradhan was seen by BJP leaders as a signal that he remains politically confident despite stepping down from

the Cabinet and is ready to take on his next assignment.

Speculation suggests that the BJP MP might be assigned a role within the party organisation or tasked with leading the BJP's campaign for the upcoming Assembly elections in five States.

His supporters believe he has “sacrificed” his post in the national interest, a move expected to further strengthen his image among the public and in his parliamentary constituency, Sambalpur.

“I am pained to see the events of the past 10 days. This is not a matter of personal prestige for me,” Pradhan said in a statement posted on social media on Saturday.

“India's youth power is the real strength of this nation. My resolve is that we will not let the country's youth get trapped in a vicious cycle of confusion,” he added.

Kargil heroes’ valour unparalleled in history: Fadnavis

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

Maharashtra Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis on Monday said the courage displayed by Indian soldiers during the Kargil War under extremely adverse conditions is unparalleled in the history of warfare.

A society which forgets its brave has a present but no future, Maharashtra Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis said as he hailed the sacrifice of the soldiers who laid down their lives in the Kargil War.

Speaking at the Kargil Vijay Diwas event here, Fadnavis said it was one of the important wars of the country, in which Indian forces displayed incomparable valour.



Despite the enemy occupying strategic high-altitude positions, the Indian armed

forces displayed exceptional coordination and bravery, recapturing every post and securing a historic victory for India, Fadnavis said.

The courage shown by Indian soldiers in the face of heavy gunfire, bombing and extremely difficult terrain remains unmatched, he asserted.

“When enemies were at a

height, the outposts were captured back. Very young officials, be it Captain Saurabh Kalia, Captain Vikram Batra, Captain Manoj Kumar Pandey, laid down their lives in the war. There were many who were not even 25 but fought valiantly. History will never forget them,” Fadnavis said.

“A society which forgets

its brave has a present but no future,” he said.

He said Indian soldiers do not fight for money, but for the dignity and honour of the motherland.

Therefore, it is the responsibility of every citizen to ensure that the families of martyrs feel the entire nation stands with them, Fadnavis said.

The CM said after assuming office in 2014, his Government decided to substantially enhance financial assistance for the families of martyred soldiers.

Assistance, which had initially stood at ₹3,00,000, was increased in phases, and from 2017 onwards the Government implemented the decision to provide Rs 1 crore to the family of every soldier from Maharashtra who is martyred in the line of duty, he said.

TMC’s Abhishek urges LS speaker to decide on rebel MPs’ disqualification

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Trinamool Congress leader Abhishek Banerjee on Monday submitted two letters to Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla, urging him to expedite a decision on the party's pending petitions for disqualification of its 20 rebel MPs and revoke changes made to the seating arrangements of its parliamentarians.

Banerjee met Birla at around 11.15 am in the Speaker's chamber, with the meeting lasting about 20 minutes, sources said.

According to sources, the Speaker did not give a clear response on the issue against the rebel MPs.

In his first letter, Banerjee said the 20 disqualification petitions, filed on June 19 under the Tenth Schedule to the Constitution and the Members of Lok Sabha (Disqualification on Ground of Defection) Rules, 1985, had



TMC MP Abhishek Banerjee during the Monsoon session of Parliament in New Delhi on Monday

remained pending for over five weeks without notices being issued, hearings being scheduled or any procedural directions being passed.

"More than five weeks have elapsed since the filing of the petitions. To date, no notices have been issued, no hearings have been scheduled, and no procedural directions appear to have been passed. Such continued inaction is a

matter of grave concern," Banerjee said in the letter.

He said the petitions concerned 20 MPs elected on the TMC symbol who had aligned themselves with the Nationalist Citizens Party of India (NCPI), "an unrecognised political formation with no representation in Parliament or any state legislature". "An unduly prolonged pendency of disqualification

proceedings frustrates the constitutional objective of the Tenth Schedule, permits the continuance of an uncertainty that the Constitution seeks to avoid, and risks rendering the safeguards embodied in the anti-defection law ineffective," he said.

He also said the urgency had increased after the Parliamentary Affairs Ministry invited the MPs facing disqualification petitions to the all-party meeting on July 19 as a separate group, saying that the continued uncertainty over their status had the potential to undermine both the Tenth Schedule and the integrity of parliamentary proceedings.

In a separate letter, Banerjee objected to the Lok Sabha Secretariat's July 18 circular changing the division and seat numbers of 28 TMC MPs. He said another circular issued the same day continued to recognise the TMC as a single parliamentary party of 28 MPs with him as its leader.

BJP holds twin rallies in Kolkata against violence during Left-backed NEET protest

SAUGAR SENGUPTA ■ Kolkata

The political slugfest intensified as BJP leadership addressed the 'Cockroach' unrest, with twin counter-rallies organised in various parts of Kolkata on Monday.

Thousands of people backed by the BJP descended on the streets to take part in two massively attended rallies seeking a boycott of the Cockroach Janata Party and the Communists and action against "anti-national forces".

Bengal Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari had on Saturday given a call for hosting a counter Tiranga Yatra — "with double the number of participants against anti-national elements — staged by the Left students' wings in Kolkata that ended up in chaos, leading to a brief skirmish between police and the protesters. While the first one started at Sealdah Station and ended up at Esplanade, the second one started at Gol



BJP supporters participate in a 'Tiranga' rally in response to protest against the violent clashes, police baton charges, and subsequent arrests of 11 individuals that took place during protest at Esplanade on Kolkata

Park in South Kolkata to terminate near Jadavpur University. The BJP came to the rally without flags.

Many participants marched with symbolic anti-cockroach pesticide bottles of several companies, claiming they would spray them on cockroaches to get rid of them, while others carried posters of lizards to teach the cockroaches a lesson.

The counter-rallies were a

"nationalist answer to the raising of anti-national slogans and attack on police and media men", BJP leader and MLA Sajal Ghosh said.

State Minister Agnimitra Paul, who was among senior leaders leading the rally, said, "It is a message from the nationalist masses to Prime Minister Narendra Modi that people of Bengal are with him. No anti-national activity or hooliganism will

be tolerated in Bengal." Bengal Industries Minister Tapas Roy said, "This Tiranga Rally is not a party event but one that has been called by the Chief Minister to underscore the nationalistic values of Bengal. We are on the streets to register our protests against the elements who are stoking anti-India sentiments inside India ... there are some people trying to exploit question paper leaks for political purposes, forgetting completely the fact that question papers were leaked 53 times during Congress rule and 7 times when Mamata Banerjee was in power."

Left leaders like Md Salim promptly hit back, challenging the BJP to "prove who raised anti-national slogans from the rally." Meanwhile, Kolkata Police on Monday arrested two more persons taking the total number of arrests to 16 linked to the Friday's protests over the NEET examination paper leak.

Rahul-lead Opposition protests over NEET paper leak row

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

Opposition MPs, including Congress leaders Rahul Gandhi and Priyanka Gandhi Vadra, protested in the Parliament House complex on Monday over alleged "police brutality" against student protesters during the agitation on the NEET paper leak issue and demanded Home Minister Amit Shah's apology.

Carrying placards and a large banner, several MPs protested in front of the steps of the Makar Dwar of Parliament. They raised slogans, demanding answers from the home minister over alleged police excesses against protesting students.

Besides Rahul Gandhi and Priyanka Gandhi, Samajwadi Party chief Akhilesh Yadav, TMC's Mahua Moitra and JMM's Mahua Maji, among others, participated in the protest.

Later, DMK MPs held a protest separately demanding a ban on the National Eligibility-cum-Entrance Test (NEET), which is conducted for admission to medical courses.

The Congress-led opposition is set to keep the pressure on the Government in Parliament over the issue, demanding action against those responsible for the assault on students and an apology from Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Shah.

Leader of the Opposition in the Lok



Lok Sabha LoP Rahul Gandhi meets Mohammad Irfan, who went viral for reciting the Preamble of the Constitution during the recent student protest at the Jantar Mantar, in New Delhi

Sabha Rahul Gandhi has written to Shah, seeking accountability for what he called "barbaric assault" on peacefully protesting students and asking the minister whether he approved the use of "lethal force", including pellet guns.

In his letter, Gandhi said peaceful protest is crucial to any democracy and that it is the Government's

responsibility to protect protesters and resolve their grievances through dialogue.

"Such brutal violence destroys every norm, and has outraged the country. Youth and students, the future of our country, are demanding answers and accountability. Their voice will be heard," the former Congress chief has said.

YOUTH IS INDIA'S GREATEST STRENGTH: RAHUL

New Delhi: Congress leader Rahul Gandhi on Monday met Mohammad Irfan, who went viral for reciting the Preamble of the Constitution during the recent student protest at the Jantar Mantar, and said his perspective on the country demonstrates that India's greatest strength lies in its youth.

Posting pictures with Irfan, Gandhi said in a post on Instagram, "I met Irfan - a young man from a Delhi neighbourhood whose mindset transcends his circumstances." "His understanding of the Constitution, his perspective on the country, and his eagerness to learn demonstrate that India's greatest strength lies in its youth," the Leader of Opposition in Lok Sabha said in his post in Hindi.

Millions of young people like Irfan represent the country's true hope - inquisitive, sensitive and conscious of their rights and duties, Gandhi added. During the protest against the NEET paper leak at Delhi's Jantar Mantar, Irfan became the centre of attention on social media because of his emotive and grounded statements. Coming from a slum settlement, Irfan raised important issues such as the struggles of working-class. (PNS)

Petrol bomb hurled at Sangrur BJP office; party alleges jungle raj under AAP rule

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Chandigarh

A petrol bomb was allegedly hurled by unidentified persons at the BJP office in Punjab's Sangrur district, an incident which drew sharp reactions from the party, which alleged that the growing audacity of criminals has become the "hallmark" of AAP rule.

Police said no one was hurt in the incident which occurred late Sunday night, adding that efforts are on to trace the culprits.

Upon receiving information, a team of senior police officials reached the BJP office at Uppli Road. Following inspection of the site, it appeared that an ignited petrol-filled bottle was thrown towards the building from the outer wall, an official said. "Petrol was filled in a beer bottle and it was thrown from the outer cordon of the building.

A burn mark was found on the wall. We will lodge an FIR in the matter and take strict



Sangrur SP Davinder Atri

action against those behind this incident," Sangrur Superintendent of Police Davinder Atri said.

A forensic team has been called to collect samples, police said, adding that CCTV footage of nearby areas is being scanned to trace those who threw the petrol bomb.

Several police teams have been formed to crack the case, they said.

Local BJP leader Randeep Singh Deol said a staff member of the party office reported the incident. "Attack on the BJP office shows the inefficiency of the AAP Government. Earlier, there

was an attack on the party office in Chandigarh. It is quite unfortunate," Deol said.

Punjab BJP chief Kewal Singh Dhillion condemned the incident and lashed out at the AAP Government over law and order.

"The attacks on BJP offices in Punjab, the targeting of BJP leaders, and the growing audacity of criminals have become the hallmark of the 'jungle raj' under Bhagwant Mann and Arvind Kejriwal. Every attempt to silence the voice of the opposition through violence will fail. The people of Punjab are demanding answers: Is the rule of law prevailing in the state, or has it given way to lawlessness and gangsterism," asked Dhillion.

Former Union minister Navneet Singh Bittu said the news of the "explosion" at the Sangrur BJP office is extremely unfortunate and deeply concerning. "In this difficult time, we stand strongly with each of our workers and the area's residents," Bittu said.

16 Maoists to surrender in Ranchi

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Ranchi

As many as 16 Maoists, including Santosh alias Basudev Da alias Dilip, who was carrying a bounty of ₹15 lakh on his head, will surrender before police here on Tuesday, a senior official said on Monday.

Of the 16 Maoists, six carry a total bounty of ₹39 lakh. They include a regional committee member, one zonal committee member, two sub-zonal committee members and two area committee members, according to data provided by the Jharkhand police headquarters. Several women members are also part of the group.

The surrender of Santosh, a regional committee member of the CPI Maoist, is seen as a big achievement, as he is wanted in 128 cases in police stations of different districts and was carrying a bounty of ₹15 lakh, the police said.

CPI (Maoist) zonal committee member Chandan Lohra, who was wanted in 78 cases and carries a bounty of ₹10 lakh, will also surrender on the occasion. The Maoists will also surrender six INSAS rifles, two AK-47 and one each HK-33, US Carbine and M-16 rifles, besides 38 magazines and 1,562 cartridges.



Other prominent members who will lay down arms include sub-zonal committee members Anil Turi alias Ujjwal and Sukhlal Birjayan alias Akela, both carrying rewards of ₹5 lakh each, area committee members Sudesh Honhaga alias Sonaram Honhaga and Risiv, both carrying bounties of ₹2 lakh each, and zonal committee member Santosh Manjhi alias Jagabandhu.

GDA demolishes illegal Colony being developed in enforcement Zone-02

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Ghaziabad

In compliance with the directions of the Vice-Chairman, Ghaziabad Development Authority (GDA), and as part of the ongoing action against illegal constructions and unauthorised colonies, demolition action was carried out under the leadership of the In-Charge, Enforcement Zone-02 and Chetan Yadav.

At the site located at Shahpur Road, Radha Garden, Muradnagar, unauthorised plotting had been carried out on approximately 4,000 square metres of land by constructing masonry structures and laying soil on the road. No valid approval or land records were produced



at the site. Accordingly, demolition action was taken against the unauthorised

development. The road, boundary wall, site office and other structures con-

structed by the coloniser as part of the illegal colony were demolished. During the demolition operation, the coloniser/builder strongly resisted the action.

However, the situation was brought under control with the assistance of the Authority's police force, and the demolition operation continued. The demolition action was carried out in the presence of the assistant engineer, junior engineer, all staff of Enforcement Zone-02, the authority's police force and the authority's enforcement squad.

The campaign against illegal constructions and unauthorised colonies will continue, and further demolition and sealing actions will also be carried out in the coming months.

Gujarat unveils shipbuilding and repair policy 2026

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Gandhinagar

Gujarat Chief Minister Bhupendra Patel on Monday launched the Gujarat Shipbuilding and Ship Repair Policy 2026, aimed at transforming the state into a leading national and global centre for shipbuilding and maritime manufacturing.

With Gujarat having India's longest coastline of around 2,340 km, the policy seeks to leverage the state's port infrastructure, industrial ecosystem and maritime heritage. It focuses on modern infrastructure, advanced technology, sustainable development and investor-friendly measures.

The policy is aligned with the Centre's Shipbuilding Financial Assistance Scheme 2025, Maritime Vision 2047 and the broader vision of an Atmanirbhar Bharat outlined by Prime Minister Narendra Modi. A key feature of the policy is the proposed development of Integrated Mega Shipbuilding Parks (IMSPs). The Centre has approved a mega greenfield shipbuilding cluster at Kuchhadi in Porbandar district.

To support the industrial ecosystem, common marine and land-based infrastructure is worth approximately ₹3,300 crore is proposed.



Gujarat CM Bhupendra Patel

As Assam flood situation improves, power restoration continues

TONY DAS ■ Guwahati

The death toll in this year's floods in Assam climbed to 68 with two more fatalities, while over 5.24 lakh people remained affected across five districts despite an overall improvement in the situation, officials said on Monday.

The two deaths were reported on Sunday from Charaideo district, which also remained the worst-affected with nearly 1.9 lakh people reeling under water, they said.

Among the other affected districts were Golaghat, Jorhat, Nagaon and Sivasagar, officials said.

Altogether 354 relief camps and aid distribution centres were operating in four districts, taking care of 37,724 displaced people, they said.

Multiple agencies, including the Army, NDRF, SDRF, Fire & Emergency Service and the police, were engaged in the rescue and relief operations, they added.

Embankments, roads, bridges



and other infrastructure suffered damage in various districts of the state. Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma said that power restoration

work was on in a phased manner. "As Assam steadily recovers from the floods, power restoration efforts continue across affected districts,"

Sarma said in a social media post on Sunday. He said following the precautionary suspension of electricity supply during the floods, Power Department teams have been carrying out comprehensive safety inspections while restoring power in a phased manner across Sivasagar, Jorhat, Charaideo, Dhubri, Bongaigaon and other affected areas.

"We remain committed to restoring essential services at the earliest and ensuring every affected community returns to normalcy," he added. The chief minister said post-flood rehabilitation will be taken up swiftly, with schools and all damaged infrastructure being fully repaired and restored in due course.

He also said that food grains, including rice bags, are being dispatched continuously to affected areas, medical needs are being actively managed by doctor teams and essential items are being air-dropped where necessary.

Editor's
TAKE

A digital fix for a crisis of trust

Restoring trust in examination system demands a secure and tamper-proof architecture — and who better than Nandan Nilekani to help build it?

The students' protests have pushed the Government to seek a permanent fix for the exam leak menace. Surely, there are no band-aid fixes to rely upon. There has to be a technologically driven solution which is state-of-the-art and has checks and balances which are beyond tampering. The appointment of Nandan Nilekani to help redesign India's examination system is indeed the right step. Over the past few years, paper leaks have become an alarming feature of competitive examinations across the country. The Government's decision signals a welcome shift in approach. Instead of relying solely on stricter laws and punitive action after the damage is done, it is looking towards technology-led systemic reform.

That is precisely where Nilekani's expertise becomes invaluable. Few individuals have shaped India's digital transformation as profoundly as Nandan Nilekani. As the architect behind Aadhaar, he demonstrated that technology can successfully manage systems involving over a billion people while ensuring security, scalability and transparency.

The examination ecosystem demands precisely such an integrated approach. Today's examination process remains fragmented. Different agencies follow different protocols for question paper preparation, encryption, printing, transportation and distribution. Physical handling at multiple stages creates opportunities for leaks. Simply increasing police surveillance or imposing harsher penalties cannot eliminate vulnerabilities built into the system. What India requires is a complete redesign. Question papers should be generated within secure digital environments using end-to-end encryption and zero-trust architecture. Multi-factor authentication must govern every stage of access. Secure digital transmission should replace large-scale physical movement of question papers wherever feasible, while blockchain-based audit trails can create tamper-proof records of every access and modification. Equally important is a unified national examination technology framework with clearly defined cybersecurity standards applicable across all testing agencies. Technology alone, however, cannot guarantee integrity. Institutional accountability must accompany digital reform. Independent security audits, regular penetration testing, certified personnel, strict vendor compliance and transparent grievance redressal mechanisms should become mandatory. Every breach must trigger not only a criminal investigation but also a thorough review of systemic failures. The urgency cannot be overstated. Every paper leak represents not merely an administrative lapse but the theft of countless dreams. Students invest years of effort, families spend substantial savings on coaching and preparation, and careers often hinge on a single examination.

When that examination is compromised, faith in meritocracy itself begins to erode. In a young nation where millions aspire to upward mobility through education, such erosion carries serious social and political consequences. The credibility of India's education system demands nothing less than a robust and foolproof exam system.

The CJP and the new face of youth dissent

The Cockroach Janata Party (CJP), born out of outrage over alleged examination paper leaks and fuelled by a derogatory remark about unemployed youth, transformed public anger into a nationwide campaign for accountability



KALYANI SHANKAR

Since its inception in May, the Cockroach Janata Party (CJP) has emerged as a notable movement, capturing the attention of many individuals and opposition groups. It has become a key voice of dissent among India's youth, challenging the government on various issues.

The CJP has gained momentum and inspired many people, highlighting its importance in Indian politics. It stands out as one of the most prominent youth movements in India, representing public protests against the government.

The protests, called the "cockroach" protests, began in response to claims about leaks in important entrance exams for medical colleges and government jobs. Initially focused on these specific exams, the movement soon expanded into broader agitation. Now, it includes not just the students directly affected but also professionals, parents, and everyday citizens who share frustrations about economic and social challenges in the country.

The name of the movement stems from a comment made by the Chief Justice of India, who compared unemployed youth to cockroaches. The CJP took this insult and turned it into a rallying cry for young people. Activist Sonam Wangchuk joined the protests, branding himself as an "honorary cockroach". He even went on a 26-day hunger strike in New Delhi to peacefully raise awareness. In a video from his hospital bed, he said he received a written assurance that the government would address accountability in the exam system and that no legal action would be taken against the young people participating in the protests.

The movement is calling for the resignation of Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan, as well as demanding reforms in the exam system to prevent future leaks. They are also seeking compensation for students affected by these issues, highlighting their desire for real change. Prime Minister Modi has announced that special courts will be established to deal with those responsible for exam paper leaks, which is his first official response to the controversy. He emphasised on social media that the well-being of the youth is a top priority.

The CJP was founded by Abhijeet Dipke, who was motivated to act after hearing the Chief Justice's insulting remarks about unem-



played youth. He humorously posed the question on social media, "What if all cockroaches came together?"

Public protests have intensified as more allegations of exam leaks have come to light. These exams are crucial for job opportunities and social mobility in India, and any threat to their integrity could lead to significant delays and stress for students who fear losing precious study time.

The CJP's independence from traditional political parties fosters trust and pride in grassroots efforts, inspiring hope that youth can create meaningful change through social media and community actions.

The protests reveal a growing public mistrust in major institutions, such as schools, politicians, the judicial system, and the media. People are demanding urgent systemic changes to restore confidence in these entities, emphasising the need for collective action and responsibility.

What began as online satire has transformed into a robust expression of youth frustration. Following a police crackdown that injured many demonstrators, public outcry increased. Political opponents have echoed the movement's demands during parliamentary sessions.

Some Bollywood celebrities, who faced criticism for staying silent on these protests, spoke out in support of the students' collective action, praising their bravery without directly criticising the government. This includes Aamir Khan, Priyanka Chopra,

and Salman Khan. While Prime Minister Modi hasn't directly addressed the protests, his acknowledgement of the exam leak issue indicates awareness of the movement's concerns, and the CJP's continued call for Minister Pradhan's resignation underscores its ongoing activism and importance in Indian politics.

A protester pointed out that Modi appeared under pressure, highlighting the need for him to take decisive action, including removing his education minister. Opposition leaders, including Rahul Gandhi and his sister Priyanka, held a protest outside Modi's residence, as their party showed in videos. Other leaders like Mamata Banerjee and Kejriwal were also critical of the government.

After Wangchuk concluded his hunger strike, Dipke expressed gratitude for Wangchuk's inspiring leadership.

The climax came when Pradhan resigned on Saturday. The CJP was shouting, "We have won." Their crowd at Jantar Mantar was dispersed quickly.

Can the government do more to pacify the demonstrators? Is this the right action at the wrong time? The movement has no ties to political parties and no specific ideology. This was an advantage for the CJP. The government needs to handle this carefully because even some BJP members are concerned about NEET. We will need to watch how this situation develops in the coming months.

SOME BOLLYWOOD CELEBRITIES, WHO FACED CRITICISM FOR STAYING SILENT ON THESE PROTESTS, SPOKE OUT IN SUPPORT OF THE STUDENTS' COLLECTIVE ACTION, PRAISING THEIR BRAVERY WITHOUT DIRECTLY CRITICISING THE GOVERNMENT

The writer is a popular columnist

The triangle that holds us together



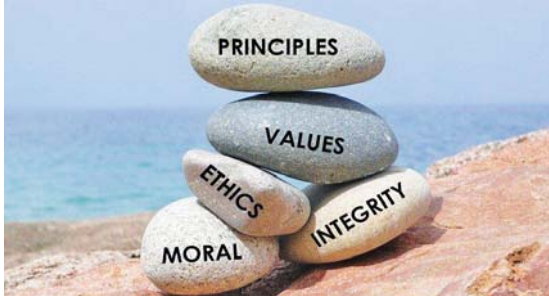
RACHNA LAKHPATRI

2ND OPINION

We spend a great deal of time talking about people. Their behaviour, their intentions, their failures and their choices. Entire conversations, sometimes entire careers, are built around decoding why people do what they do. And yet, for all that analysis, we keep arriving at the same impasses in workplaces, families, friendships and public life.

Perhaps because we are asking the wrong question. The real conversation isn't about people in isolation. It is about the space between them, the invisible architecture that either holds relationships together or quietly dismantles them. That architecture has three pillars: relationships, truth and ethics. And the moment any one of them weakens, everything built on top of it begins to tilt.

Consider how often we have watched this play out. A



team that works beautifully together, bound by warmth and years of shared history, but where a crucial truth was never spoken. The silence feels protective at first.

Then it festers. By the time it surfaces, the relationship that was meant to be protected has already been hollowed out. The truth, delayed, does more damage than it would have if it had simply been said. Or consider the opposite scenario. Someone who speaks truth like a blunt instrument, proud of their honesty, indifferent to the wreckage it leaves behind. Technically accurate. Ethically questionable. Relationally destructive. Truth without care is not virtue. It is just candour dressed up as courage.

Then there is ethics, perhaps the most misunderstood of the three. Ethics, in practice, is not a rulebook. It is a calibration. It asks: what is the right thing to do, given who is involved, what is at stake and what it will cost?

Ethics without relationship is cold and often unjust. Ethics without truth is a performance. But ethics grounded in both, in genuine regard for the other person and in honest assessment of the situation, is the closest thing we have to wisdom.

The trouble is that most of us were never taught to hold all three at once. We were taught to be loyal, which sometimes meant staying quiet. Or to be honest, which sometimes meant being unkind. Or to be principled, which sometimes meant being rigid. Each virtue, taught in isolation, contains the seed of its own distortion. What life actually requires is the ability to move between them, to know when a relationship needs the protection of a difficult truth, when truth needs the tempering of ethical consideration, and when ethics must take precedence even if it strains the relationship. None of the three can be permanently sacrificed for the other two without something essential being lost.

This is not a comfortable thought. Balance rarely is. It demands attention, judgement and the willingness to sit with complexity rather than reach for the nearest easy answer. But the alternative, choosing one and abandoning the rest, is precisely how most of our messes get made. The triangle holds, or it doesn't. And that depends entirely on whether we are willing to tend to all three sides.

The writer is a freelancer and writes on development, social and gender issue

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DENGUE VACCINE ROLLOUT MUST PRIORITISE SAFETY AND TRUST

The Central Drugs Standard Control Organisation's approval of Qdenga as India's first dengue vaccine has come as a beacon of hope in a country that shoulders one of the world's highest dengue burdens. Manufactured by Japanese firm Takeda Pharmaceutical Company, the vaccine is pre-qualified by the World Health Organisation and has already received regulatory approval in several countries. However, its introduction also raises concerns that must be carefully addressed.

Qdenga's Phase 3 trial data has raised questions about its performance among children who have not previously had a dengue infection. In such cases, concerns have been expressed about protection against different dengue virus serotypes, particularly DENV-3. These issues underline the need for careful assessment, transparent

communication and continued monitoring as the vaccine is introduced.

A comprehensive and successful inoculation drive requires public confidence. Vaccine hesitancy can be addressed only when people receive clear, credible and scientifically supported information about a vaccine's benefits and potential risks. Authorities must ensure that safety data, eligibility criteria and possible concerns are communicated transparently.

The approval of a dengue vaccine is undoubtedly an important development for India, but public health authorities must proceed with caution. In a matter involving health and lives, there should be no room for complacency.

TUSHAR ANAND | SONAGIRI

Please send your letter to the info@dailypioneer.com. In not more than 250 words. We appreciate your feedback.

UNFPA report on lives, choices and future

Family life is under strain across the world. People are marrying later than previous generations, but these shifts should not be mistaken for a rejection of family as an institution.

The United Nations Population Fund (UNFPA), in its *State of World Population 2025* report, *The Real Fertility Crisis*, highlights significant shifts in fertility, ageing and reproductive autonomy. India remains the world's most populous country and enjoys a demographic advantage, with 68 per cent of its population in the working-age group of 15-64 years. However, reproductive choices are increasingly shaped by financial constraints, housing difficulties, job insecurity, childcare costs, health concerns and social pressures. Many young adults now view marriage and parenthood as commitments carrying considerable financial and emotional risks.

The report rightly stresses reproductive rights rather than population control and calls for better access to contraceptives, maternal and infertility care, and safe abortion. India's relatively young population remains an advantage, but this demographic window will not remain open indefinitely. If millions postpone marriage or parenthood because of uncertain livelihoods, the social, economic and demographic consequences could be serious.

YASH PAL RALHAN | JALANDHAR

Real accountability lies in systemic reform

Apropos, "A Turning Point for Education Reform", *The Pioneer*, July 27. The resignation of a minister over departmental lapses is entirely justified when clear negligence or systemic apathy is at fault. However, applying this standard to the NEET paper leak and the resignation of Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan is unconvincing.

When the breach surfaced, the Ministry and the Government acted swiftly to launch investigations, hand over cases to central agencies and initiate reforms. In a vast nation with deep structural challenges, expecting absolutely zero lapses across every public system is unrealistic. What remains non-negotiable is immediate, decisive corrective action - fixing the breach and restoring systemic integrity.

If forced resignations over every administrative failure become the norm, continuous political turnover will only lead to administrative chaos and public hopelessness. Furthermore, transforming every departmental lapse into a mandatory resignation demand allows Opposition parties to exploit serious issues for political spectacle and instability. True governance is not served by symbolic sacrifices, but by prompt accountability and relentless structural reform when systems fall short

N SADHASIVA REDDY | JNANABHARATHI

Fair exams need strict oversight

The decision to form a task force could initiate much-needed education reforms and bring positive outcomes for students. Prime Minister Narendra Modi has announced that the Government has set up a high-powered task force on examination reforms under the leadership of Infosys co-founder Nandan Nilekani. Other members include former ISRO Chairman S Somanath, former Intelligence Bureau Director Tapan Deka, IIT Madras Director V Kamakoti, former Education Secretary Anita Karwal and logistics expert Amrit Lal Meena.

The decision comes amid students' protests over alleged examination irregularities and the NEET paper leak. The Government is taking several steps to safeguard the future of students and restore confidence in the examination system.

However, announcements alone will not be enough. Examination irregularities can have a serious impact not only on students but also on their parents, who invest considerable time, money and effort in their children's education and preparation. Therefore, a strict mechanism, effective supervision and greater transparency are required to prevent such incidents. The task force must ensure that its recommendations translate into meaningful reforms and a fair, secure examination system.

DIMPLE WADHAWAN | KANPUR NAGAR

The road to Viksit Bharat must not be paved with blood

Road safety is not simply a legal obligation — it is a moral duty, a constitutional commitment and a collective national responsibility. Every life saved is not merely a statistic avoided; it is a family protected, a future preserved and a nation made stronger



ABHINAV NARAYAN JHA



ABHAY KUMAR

Every road crash leaves behind more than twisted metal and shattered glass — it leaves grieving parents, orphaned children, unfinished dreams and irreversible loss. Yet, despite technological advancement, stricter laws and expanding highways, road accidents continue to claim hundreds of lives every day. India is not merely facing a transport crisis; it is confronting a public health emergency, a governance challenge and a collective failure of civic responsibility.

The latest *Road Accidents in India 2024 Report*, released by the Ministry of Road Transport and Highways (MoRTH), paints a disturbing picture. India witnessed approximately 4.8 lakh road accidents, leading to over 1.77 lakh deaths and more than 4.6 lakh injuries during the year. On average, 485 people lose their lives every day, while nearly 1,300 people are injured daily on Indian roads. These figures place India among the countries with the highest number of road fatalities globally. Overspeeding alone accounted for over 70 per cent of all road deaths, while hit-and-run cases contributed to nearly one-fifth of all fatalities. Non-use of helmets resulted in over 54,000 deaths, whereas failure to wear seat belts caused more than 14,000 fatalities. Nearly 10 per cent of accidents involved drivers without a valid driving licence or holding only a learner's licence, exposing glaring gaps in enforcement and licensing. These statistics are not merely numbers—they represent human lives that could have been saved through better planning, stricter enforcement and greater public awareness.

The crisis is equally alarming from a global perspective. According to the World Health Organization (WHO), nearly 1.19 million people die annually due to road traffic crashes across the world, while 20-50 million people suffer non-fatal injuries, many resulting in permanent disabilities. Road traffic injuries remain the leading cause of death among children and young adults aged 5-29 years. Alarming, 92 per cent of global road fatalities occur in low- and middle-income countries, despite these nations possessing only around 60 per cent of the world's vehicles. More than half of all victims are vulnerable road users, including pedestrians, cyclists and motorcyclists. Recognising this growing challenge, the United Nations declared 2021-2030 as the Second Decade of Action for Road Safety, setting an ambitious target of reducing global road deaths and injuries by 50 per cent before 2030. Achieving this objective demands stronger political commitment, scientific road engineering, efficient emergency response systems and behavioural transformation among road users.

In India, road safety has received increasing legislative attention. The Motor Vehicles (Amendment) Act, 2019, significantly enhanced penalties for dangerous driving, drunken driving, juvenile driving, overloading, driving without a licence and violations relating to helmets and seat belts. More recently, the introduction of Section 106(2) of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, 2023 (BNS), has further strengthened accountability in serious hit-and-run cases. The provision prescribes enhanced punishment where a driver, after causing death by negligent driving, escapes the scene without informing the police or other competent authorities. The legislative intent is clear—to discourage offenders from abandoning accident victims and to reinforce the legal duty to report accidents promptly. However, the effectiveness of Section 106(2) should not be measured solely by the severity of punishment. Criminal law is essentially reactive; it intervenes after lives have already been lost. The true success of road safety lies not in convictions but in prevention. Fear of punishment cannot replace disciplined driving, safe infrastructure and effective enforcement.

India has nevertheless undertaken several commendable policy initiatives in recent years. The Ministry of Road Transport and Highways has accelerated the identification and rectification of accident-prone "black spots", promoted Intelligent Traffic Management Systems, strengthened vehicle safety standards through mandatory crash tests, encouraged electronic enforcement of traffic violations and implemented the Electronic Detailed Accident Report (e-DAR) for faster insurance settlements and better accident analysis. The Government



ROAD SAFETY IS NOT THE RESPONSIBILITY OF THE GOVERNMENT ALONE. IT DEMANDS SHARED ACCOUNTABILITY AMONG LEGISLATORS, ENGINEERS, URBAN PLANNERS, POLICE AUTHORITIES, HOSPITALS, VEHICLE MANUFACTURERS, INSURERS, EDUCATIONAL INSTITUTIONS AND CITIZENS. EVERY STAKEHOLDER HAS A ROLE IN PREVENTING AVOIDABLE DEATHS. INDIA'S ASPIRATION TO BECOME A DEVELOPED NATION BY 2047 CANNOT BE REALISED IF HUNDREDS OF CITIZENS CONTINUE TO DIE ON ITS ROADS EVERY SINGLE DAY

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has also institutionalised Good Samaritan Guidelines, protecting citizens who voluntarily assist accident victims from unnecessary legal harassment, thereby encouraging timely medical intervention during the critical "golden hour".

Recent policy discussions indicate that repeat traffic offenders may soon be required to undergo fresh driving tests while renewing their licences. Simultaneously, reforms are being considered to enable Motor Accident Claims Tribunals (MACTs) to grant interim compensation to crash victims and their families without waiting for prolonged litigation. These reforms reflect a welcome shift from merely punishing offenders towards protecting victims and improving compliance. Yet, legislation alone cannot overcome decades of unsafe road behaviour. India's road safety problem is deeply rooted in human conduct. Overspeeding, distracted driving caused by mobile phone usage, driving under the influence of alcohol or drugs, fatigue among commercial drivers, lane indiscipline, signal jumping and disregard for pedestrian rights continue to account for the overwhelming majority of crashes. Every traffic violation is a conscious choice that endangers not only the driver but every innocent road user.

Infrastructure also requires urgent attention. National Highways constitute only a small proportion of India's total road network, yet they account for a disproportionately high share of fatalities because of excessive speeds and inadequate safety measures. Many urban roads lack proper footpaths, pedestrian crossings, cycling infrastructure, street lighting, traffic-calming measures and scientifically designed intersections. Rural roads frequently suffer from poor signage, inadequate markings and delayed emergency response services. Road engineering must shift from facilitating faster movement to ensuring safer mobility for all. Road safety is equally an economic issue. Every fatal accident imposes enormous costs through medical expenditure, productivity losses, insurance claims, litigation and long-term social support for affected families. The economic burden runs into billions of rupees annually, making road safety not merely a welfare concern but a developmental necessity. Education and awareness must therefore become central pillars of national policy. Road safety should be introduced as a compulsory component of school and university curricula. Driver training should prioritise defensive driving, hazard perception and emergency response rather than merely passing licensing examinations. Public campaigns should focus on changing attitudes rather than simply enforcing penalties.

Technology also offers immense opportunities. Artificial Intelligence-powered surveillance cameras, automated speed enforcement, connected vehicle technologies, intelligent transport systems, GPS-based emergency response and real-time traffic analytics can significantly reduce accidents when integrated with efficient governance. Data-driven policing must replace sporadic enforcement drives.

Road safety is not the responsibility of the Government alone. It demands shared accountability among authorities, institutions and citizens. India's aspiration to become a developed nation by 2047 cannot be realised if hundreds continue to die on its roads every day. A nation's success is measured not merely by its highways but by the safety of those who travel.

The Constitution guarantees every citizen the Right to Life under Article 21. That right must not end at a pedestrian crossing, a highway intersection or a village road. Laws like Section 106(2) of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita are important milestones in strengthening accountability, but they must be accompanied by safer infrastructure, evidence-based policymaking, efficient trauma care, responsible driving and a culture that values human life above speed and convenience.

Road safety is not simply a legal obligation—it is a moral duty, a constitutional commitment and a collective national responsibility. Every life saved is not merely a statistic avoided; it is a family protected, a future preserved and a nation made stronger.

What dropping 'Indo' reveals about Washington's China bet



ABHISHEK PRATAP SINGH



KAUSTUBH TRIPATHI

maritime order across the Indian and Pacific Oceans. This was necessitated by growing maritime posturing and assertiveness from China, and the need to protect freedom of navigation and international law in the ocean.

The dropping of the word "Indo" by the Trump administration has become a subject of discussion in strategic circles. While Sergio Gor, the Ambassador of the US to India, clarified that a mere change on paper does not change the sum and substance of US-India relations, the reality does not seem to be as straightforward and simple.

In the first instance, placing the word "Indo" in 2018 carried strategic weight and political signalling. It established India's centrality in the American regional and maritime strategy in the Indo-Pacific region. Reversing the same may well imply that the US is more likely to execute its Pacific strategy on its own, without letting a major power like India play any significant role.

This change in nomenclature also needs to be seen in the context of the May 2026 Beijing Summit and by closely reading the US National Security Strategy (NSS) documents of 2017, 2022 and 2025. The NSS 2017 document, during Donald Trump's first presidency, described China as a "revisionist" power and America's "strategic competitor". The document further went on to state that the US was entering "a new era of strategic competition" as the "revisionist" powers — China and Russia — were challenging American interests. It was in this context that the US renamed its Pacific Command the Indo-Pacific Command. Further, the NSS 2022, released during Biden's presidency, elevated the cautionary tone as far as China was concerned. It described China as a central, generational threat to America and its interests. China was described as a power having both the intent and capabilities to reshape the global order. NSS 2022 placed the Indo-Pacific at the centre of strategy, explicitly defining China as America's most consequential competitor.

However, the NSS 2025, released during Trump's second term, saw a break from the tone and substance of how China was described earlier by American policymakers. There was no reference to China as being a "strategic competitor"; rather, it defined China as a "near peer", reflecting the evolving perception among US strategic elites of China as an economic competitor and less of a strategic threat to American influence globally. This relative softening in the tone of a National Security Strategy document points not towards mere tactical manoeuvres, but towards the larger realisation in Washington that 'managed coexistence' with Beijing is a relatively preferable policy option.

Adding to these developments, May 2026 saw Trump and Xi meeting in Beijing. The outcome seemed more transactional. America and China both emphasised "strategic stability", implying managed competition through bilateral bargaining. While the US was focusing on practical deals in the spheres of trade and commerce, China, however, while not disagreeing with it, was intending political bargains in the context of Taiwan. Where Washington emphasised utility and outcomes, Beijing had its focus on status, hierarchy and influence. Largely, it can be inferred that the two great powers are trying to come to terms with each other; however, there are structural asymmetries also at play, inhibiting a win-win solution for both parties. The meeting reflects a simulation of a G2 condominium, where the US and China are perhaps shifting their strategic gears in order to manage the new global order in a coordinated and competitive manner.

When we read together both the evolution of language in NSS documents and the Beijing Summit outcomes, the nomenclature change does not come as a surprise, but rather as a deliberate and gradual outcome. It further suggests that Washington is steadily inching away from its strategy of managing Indian and Pacific Oceans' affairs with India as its principal anchor. For India, any understanding of balancing between the US and China in managing the global order is not an acceptable diplomatic position. The fact that India did de-hyphenate its border issues and trade matters with China gives the impression that Indian strategic elites had kept room to manoeuvre for this day. India not only kept trade going with China but also positively participated in multilateral platforms like the SCO and BRICS. It consistently refused to reframe its China policy in a containment vocabulary. New Delhi was sure of the fact that a non-resident power cannot dictate the terms of how a territorial neighbour is to be managed. The question which now looms is: if not within the American regional framework, how will India manage its most consequential neighbour? For now, India will surely need a restructuring of its China policy in accordance with its own regional and global ambitions and its comprehensive national power, where its own economic leverage and its bilateral partnerships in the Indian and Pacific Oceans will become the pillars of its regional outlook. Finally, how New Delhi employs strategic autonomy, given the increased possibility of the G2s reaching an understanding and thus limiting India's strategic horizon, will be something to wait and watch.



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Beyond IT parks: Uttar Pradesh's blueprint for the AI age



RAMESH SHARMA

In the new geopolitics of technology, digital infrastructure is no longer a byproduct of economic growth; it is the prerequisite. As artificial intelligence reshapes global supply chains, the demand for high-performance computing and GPU-driven data centres has triggered a quiet, intense competition among Indian states. Within this landscape, Uttar Pradesh has executed a striking, well-calibrated move that deserves close examination.

The recent approval of the UP Data Centre Policy 2026 by the Yogi Adityanath cabinet is a significant departure from traditional sub-national industrial planning. The previous 2021 framework was a necessary proof of concept, successfully mobilising nearly ₹21,000 crore in investments and securing 644 MW of committed capacity. However, the 2026 policy operates on an entirely different magnitude. By targeting 2 GW of additional capacity and eyeing private investments upwards of ₹4.9 trillion, the Chief Minister is no longer merely inviting IT ser-

vices; he is attempting to build the physical architecture of the AI economy.

What makes this blueprint stand out is its refusal to treat data centres as isolated real estate ventures. The parallel push for deep-tech ecosystems, specifically the PRAGATI project in Noida and the dual U Hubs, signals a sophisticated understanding of vertical integration. A data centre is only as valuable as the compute ecosystem surrounding it. By carving out 75 acres for PRAGATI (Park for Robotics, AI, GPU Clusters and Advanced Technical Innovation) and earmarking ₹100 crore for specialised hubs focusing on quantum computing and semiconductor design, the policy creates immediate, localised demand for the very infrastructure it seeks to build. The directive to ensure these hubs facilitate the commercialisation of research, rather than just academic inquiry, reveals a pragmatic approach to innovation.

Perhaps the most structurally significant



aspect of this policy is its geographical imagination. Historically, UP's tech ambitions have been heavily NCR-centric, constrained by the land-power-water trilemma that inevitably plagues dense urban clusters. The 2026 framework actively mitigates this by offering targeted incentives for Bundelkhand and Purvanchal. This is not merely a developmental concession;

coherence. The seamless alignment of the Data Centre Policy with broader IT policy revisions, and the simultaneous focus on future-skilling in AI, machine learning and cybersecurity, suggests a centralised political will that has moved beyond piecemeal governance. The introduction of bespoke mechanisms like the "AI Compute Booster" and mandates for 50 per

cent renewable energy adoption by 2030 indicate that the state's leadership is acutely aware that global capital requires both cutting-edge infrastructure and environmental compliance.

The ability to translate macroeconomic intent into a navigable bureaucratic framework — simplifying land acquisition and regulatory approvals for players like the Adani Group, Hiranandani Group and Nxtra by Airtel — is a rare administrative feat. It reflects a strategic foresight that recognises GPU (Graphics Processing Unit) infrastructure cannot be shoehorned into generic IT policies.

For a state chasing a \$1-trillion economy, the transition from an agrarian and traditional manufacturing base to a digital-first economy cannot be rhetorical. It must be anchored in tangible, capital-intensive assets. Uttar Pradesh's latest policy architecture does not just aim to capture 8 to 9 per cent of India's total data centre capacity; it aims to dictate the terms of how that capacity is built. If the execution matches the blueprint, India's digital map may soon have a very prominent new landmark in the north.

Planning and executing a vision of this scale requires more than capital subsidies; it demands administrative

coherence. The seamless alignment of the Data Centre Policy with broader IT policy revisions, and the simultaneous focus on future-skilling in AI, machine learning and cybersecurity, suggests a centralised political will that has moved beyond piecemeal governance. The introduction of bespoke mechanisms like the "AI Compute Booster" and mandates for 50 per

cent renewable energy adoption by 2030 indicate that the state's leadership is acutely aware that global capital requires both cutting-edge infrastructure and environmental compliance.

The writer is a Delhi-based journalist with over three decades of experience in print, TV and digital journalism



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**SC junks review plea against
verdict on loss of SC status**

The Supreme Court has dismissed a plea seeking a review of the apex court judgement which held that a person from a Scheduled Caste community converting to a religion other than Hinduism, Sikhism or Buddhism loses the SC status from the moment of conversion.

A bench of Justices Prashant Kumar Mishra and Manmohan dismissed the petition against the March 24 verdict, saying there is no error apparent on the record. "Application seeking oral hearing of the review petition is rejected. We have gone through the review petition and perused the judgment dated March 24, 2026, which has been sought to be reviewed. "There is no error apparent on the record. The Review Petition is, accordingly, dismissed," the top court said in its July 15 order passed on the review petition.

On March 24, in a significant decision, the top court held that a Scheduled Caste community person converting to a religion other than Hinduism, Sikhism or Buddhism loses the SC status from the moment of conversion regardless of birth. It upheld an order of the Andhra Pradesh High Court which said that a person belonging to a Scheduled Caste community loses his Scheduled Caste status "immediately and completely" upon conversion to Christianity.

The top court had said under Clause (1) of Article 342 of the Constitution, the President of India promulgated the Constitution (Scheduled Tribes) Order of 1950, identifying the tribes and tribal communities recognised as "Scheduled Tribes" for different states and Union Territories (UTs). (PTI)



Thane court acquits man in rape case after woman turns hostile

A Thane court has acquitted a 22-year-old man accused of raping and blackmailing a woman as she turned hostile and admitted to an out-of-court compromise.

Special court judge Dr Anita S Newase, in the judgment on July 21, noted that the prosecution failed to establish the guilt of the accused beyond reasonable doubt. The prosecution alleged that the accused, a resident of Mira Road in Maharashtra's Thane city, offered a spiked drink to the victim at her residence, rendered her unconscious, and forcibly established physical relations with her between August 2015 and January 2016. He also filmed the act on his mobile phone and repeatedly blackmailed her, threatening to make the video public if she reported the matter, it said.

Following a complaint on March 26, 2016, the police registered a case against the accused under Sections 376 (rape), 328 (causing hurt by means of poison/intoxicant) and 506 (criminal intimidation) of the Indian Penal Code.

During the trial, the prosecution examined two witnesses - the victim and the investigation officer.

However, the victim turned hostile and resiled from her initial statements. She testified that 11 years had passed since the incident and she could not recall the specifics.

The court noted that while the law permits conviction based solely on a victim's testimony, if credible, the absence of supporting evidence in this case left no ground for conviction. The victim has not given any evidence supportive of the prosecution, and consequently, she was "declared hostile", it observed. The court also said the victim denied the fact that the accused gave her an intoxicating substance and forcibly had physical relations with her.

"On the contrary, the victim admitted that an out-of-court compromise has taken place between her and the accused, and she has no grievance against the accused. Upon the admission of this crucial fact, suspicion has arisen regarding the alleged incident," it said.

"Although the prosecution examined the investigation officer, who is a formal witness, holding the accused guilty solely on the basis of the testimony of a formal witness, when the principal facts are not proved by the victim, would not be justified," the court said. (PTI)



SC seeks Govt's reply on Kapil Sibal's plea on interpretation of anti-defection law

The Supreme Court on Monday agreed to hear a plea filed by independent Rajya Sabha MP and senior advocate Kapil Sibal seeking reconsideration of the interpretation of the Tenth Schedule of the Constitution that allows MLAs and MPs to avoid disqualification under the anti-defection law by claiming a merger with another political party.

A bench of Justices PS Narasimha and Alok Aradhe, which issued a notice to the Centre, observed that there are several issues involved which are required to be taken by Parliament. Sibal said that this issue has "huge repercussions on our polity" as a minority party can become majority, while a majority can become a minority, due to the provision. The bench said that the Tenth Schedule, meant for the



SIR: Revision of electoral rolls a matter of concern



Large-scale deletions of voters from electoral rolls is a matter of great concern. The cumbersome procedure for submission of enumeration forms and non-acceptance by BLOs, if voters' or their parents' names do not appear in the electoral rolls of 2002 amounts to harassment. Either to go through it, or lose voting right is the succinct and clear-cut message. Subjecting existing voters to SIR rigmarole, is anachronistic to the laws on rolls revision. More so, in the light of Constitution Bench verdict in Anoop Bernwals case by the Apex Court which categorically held that all voters on the electoral roll have "right to vote" in the constituency where their names are entered u/s 62(1) 1951 Act.

They can be denied their rights only if anyone become disqualified, after registration u/s 16(2) 1950 Act, on incurring any disqualification. If the competent authority finds someone not a Citizen of India action can be initiated but not to indulge in this kind of indirect device. The Apex Court even want to observe that right to vote may not be statutory right but constitutional right. A perusal of ECI records would establish that the SIR proceeds on a misconceived presumption of similarity between, "Special Revision of an intensive nature" in 2002/2003 with present SIR. Both are diagonally opposite to each other

in their methodology. Even in 2002/2003 "House to House" verification was conducted. Why now first mapping of 2002 rolls and then submission of enumeration form, with parental history. In 2001, the "Revision of Electoral Rolls of Intensive nature", was with reference to 01.01. 2002, as qualifying date. In first phase, 20 States/UTs were to be covered, whereas remaining States/UTs were in 2nd phase, in 2003.

House to House verification was only to be undertaken. How can both be equated? The prime objective was "intensive revision" of electoral rolls. Second objective, perhaps more important, to synchronise electoral rolls with "Electors Photo Identity Card (EPIC)" Programme, started in 1994. In May 2001, the scheme was revised and detailed guidelines issued. The Electoral Cards was to be for multi-purpose and uniformity of identification. During "Special Revision of Intensive nature" all eligible persons, attaining the requisite age on the qualifying date, were to be included as per law.

They were to submit application in FORM- 6, a statutory PERMA in vogue. This has not been amended so far, but as reported by media- "EC changes Form 6 has been voters without amendment to rules" . Commencing preparation of rolls at the behest of Constituent Assembly, after house-to-house enquiry, the Parliament enacted RPACT- 1950 and framed Rules. Latest amendment was in 2022, when "Registration of Electors Rules" (RER) were amended providing for "Forms for lodging claims and objections and for correction of electoral rolls", effective from 1 August, 2022 but neither SIR nor enumeration forms were part of these Rules. SIR treats 01.01.2003,



qualifying date, as probative evidence for eligibility, which can't be sustain, in the teeth of Election Law (Amendment) Act-2021, when a person becomes eligible for registration as a voter on attaining 18 years of age, on any of four qualifying dates i.e 1st January, 1st April, 1st July & 1st October every year.

An irrational and illogical move. The qualifying date in 1950 was 1st March, changed to 1st January in 1958 and later to 1st April only for 1989, latest amendment came in 2021 when four dates, were prescribed. The SIR is inherently erroneous. Clearly even ECI records are a testimony against SIR, as they reveal a duly verified voters list of 96.88 Crores, across the Country, after house-to-house verification by Booth Level Officers (BLOs). An exercise undertaken pursuant to ECI order dated 29.05.2023, ahead of General Election 2024, to conduct "Intensive Special Summary Revision-2024", in exercise of powers under Article 324 read with Section 21 of RPACT 1950.

Simultaneously, names of 1,65,76,654 voters were deleted as

part of comprehensive cleanup. The breakup of deleted voters included, 67,82,642 as dead; 75,11,128 having permanently shifted/ absentees, 22,05,68 found to be duplicates. This too was for Transparency, Purity, Health and Inclusivity of the electoral rolls, as the main objective of current SIR and was completed on 08.02.2024, in close proximity of Bihar SIR order dated 24.06.2024. Gujrat violence created an extraordinary situation to prepare electoral rolls, as people were shifted to relief camps. The villages were emptied and the assembly constituencies were partially/wholly abundant neither identifiable nor the voters were available.

The State Govt wanted elections to be held immediately, as Assembly was dissolved. The officials of ECI visited Gujrat and found situation not conducive to hold elections, and declined to hold elections before November/December, 2002, after a thorough verification and revision of electoral rolls. The ground realities incapacitated ECI to hold elections, despite under an obligation. Accurate and proper rolls were

essentially required and without actual and updated rolls it was not possible. The Apex Court while answering the Presidential reference referred to situation that may be created by "act of God" like earthquakes, floods and such like other situations, the ECI has to act appropriately.

Gujrat violence was certainly not an act of God but man made. Nonetheless, the situation was beyond the control of ECI, since unless the rolls were prepared and revised based on the available data and door to door enquiries to establish accurate rolls, the elections were impossible. An extraordinary situation for ECI to meet. Unlike Gujrat demographic change due to rapid urbanisation and migration of voters, shifting from place to place is a common phenomenon for decades.

It doesn't create an extra ordinary situation but since a person can't be Ordinary Residence at two places necessary deletions can be done during regular revision but it doesn't warrant SIR. It is a duty assigned to BLOs and equally Party BLAs to update the rolls. if this is the criteria every year SIR would be required. Harassing millions of millions Indian citizens on rolls, according to ECI's own figures of 2024 data 96.88 Crores is rather atrocious, more so when determination of citizenship is not within their domain.

The Apex Court has laid down that for existing voters on electoral rolls, there is a presumption of validity of citizenship. ECI can rebut it and the onus is on them but not by SIR methodology. The only way is disqualified u/s 16(1) of 1950 Act. It is expected that the Constitutional body will proceed as per law.

The author is a senior advocate and former president, Delhi High Court Bar Association and former chairman, Bar Council of Delhi

Will see what Nilekani-led task force suggests on online NEET exam, says SC

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Monday said it will see what the Nandan Nilekani-led high-powered task force formed by the Government suggests on the online conduct of the NEET examination.

A bench of Justices PS Narasimha and Alok Aradhe said some out-of-the-box suggestions are needed especially when transition is made from the physical mode to the online conduct of the NEET examination.

"We need some additional safeguards with respect to cyber security, database protection," it said. The bench was hearing a plea filed by RJD MP Sudhakar Singh fol-



lowing the cancellation of the NEET-UG held on May 3 over alleged paper leak and the announcement of re-NEET.

Solicitor General Tushar Mehta, appearing for the Centre, informed the bench that the Union Government has taken a very serious view and a high-level committee has been constituted.

He said an announcement was made by the prime minister himself and the high-level committee is headed by Nandan Nilekani, who is an expert in the field of technology. Mehta said besides Nilekani, other members of the task force are former chairman of ISRO S Somanath, former director of

the Intelligence Bureau, Tapan Deka, director of IIT Chennai, V Kamakoti, former education secretary Anita Karwal, and logistics expert Amrit Lal Meena.

The bench said it is listing the plea filed by RJD MP Sudhakar Singh on next Monday, August 3. On June 1, the top court refused to accept for urgent hearing the plea filed by Singh for conduct of the NEET-UG 2026 re-test on June 21 in computer-based test mode.

On May 12, the National Testing Agency (NTA) cancelled the NEET-UG held on May 3 for medical admissions amid allegations of paper leak. The CBI is currently investigating the matter and the retest was held on June 21.

Plea against Internet shutdown around Jantar Mantar withdrawn from Delhi HC

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Legal services organisation Software Freedom Law Centre, India, on Monday withdrew from the Delhi High Court its PIL against the suspension of mobile internet services in parts of central Delhi, with services restored following the withdrawal of the CJP's stir.

"The counsel for the petitioner says he has instructions to withdraw the petition. The petition is dismissed as withdrawn," said a bench of Chief Justice DK Upadhyaya and Justice Tejas Karia.

In its petition, Software Freedom Law Centre, India (SFLC.In), sought quashing of orders issued by the Union

Ministry of Home Affairs on July 17, 20, 22 and 23 to shut down mobile internet services in parts of central Delhi.

The Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) had been protesting in the heart of Delhi at Jantar Mantar since June 20 to seek accountability from the Government over the NEET paper leak and the resignation of Dharmendra Pradhan as Union education minister.

The over-a-month-long agitation was called off after Pradhan stepped down on Saturday and other demands of the CJP were accepted by the Government. Soon after, internet services were restored in central Delhi.

SLFC in said in its petition that the temporary suspension



of telecommunication services, including mobile internet services, was "one of the most extraordinary coercive powers conferred upon the Executive" as it interfered with the exercise of freedoms guaranteed under Articles 19(1)(a)

(free speech), 19(1)(b) (peaceful assembly), 19(1)(g) (right to practice any trade or profession) and 21 (right to life and liberty) of the Constitution.

Terming the suspension orders "illegal, arbitrary and unconstitutional", the peti-

tioner said they neither disclosed any public emergency nor provided reasons to demonstrate why a blanket suspension of mobile internet services was necessary or proportionate to any alleged threat.

The plea underscored that the authorities invoked Section 20(2)(b) of the Telecom Act read with the Suspension Rules, 2024, to record that the suspension was necessary "in the interest of public safety and averting public emergency" but failed to consider "less restrictive alternatives" before imposing a blanket suspension of mobile internet services.

It further alleged that the suspension orders did not disclose an "apparent indepen-

dent application of mind" and "reflect a mechanical exercise of statutory power inconsistent with the requirements of administrative law".

"The present challenge arises from the Impugned Orders issued by the Ministry of Home Affairs directing suspension of all mobile internet technologies within a radius of approximately 1.5 kilometres from Jantar Mantar, New Delhi," the plea said.

"The repeated issuance of six separate suspension orders over a span of seven days further underscores the necessity of examining whether each exercise of statutory power was independently undertaken in accordance with Section 20(2)(b)," it said.

NGT restrains operation of brick kiln, stone crusher in Assam's Nalbari

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Guwahati

The National Green Tribunal (NGT) has barred a brick manufacturing unit and a stone crusher in Assam's Nalbari district from operating until they obtain all mandatory statutory clearances and comply with environmental norms.

The order was passed recently by a Bench of the NGT's Eastern Zone in Kolkata comprising Justice Arun Kumar Tyagi, judicial member, and expert member Ishwar Singh.

The tribunal directed that the JPIS Brick Manufacturing



Unit and the PASA Stone Crusher Unit at Chengnoi in Nalbari district shall remain non-operational unless they secure all required statutory permissions, including a valid Consent to Operate (CTO) from the Assam State Pollution Control Board

(ASPCB), and comply with the environmental guidelines issued by the Central Pollution Control Board (CPCB) and the ASPCB.

The matter reached the tribunal after complainants alleged that the proposed brick kiln and stone crusher were being set up near the Pagladiya riverbed in violation of environmental norms, posing a threat to the river ecosystem, local biodiversity, public health and elephant movement in the area. After examining reports submitted by a joint committee, the ASPCB and the district administration, the tribunal noted that neither

unit was operational at the time of inspection.

It also observed that the Consent to Establish earlier granted to the JPIS Brick Manufacturing Unit had already been withdrawn by the state pollution control board.

The tribunal directed the ASPCB to verify whether both units comply with the applicable siting criteria, environmental guidelines and conditions attached to statutory consents.

It said the Board should grant or continue the CTO only if the units fully satisfy all legal and environmental requirements.

India’s chip plan finally says the word ‘Chemicals’

The least photogenic part of semiconductor manufacturing has made it into national policy at last. Whether it survives contact with reality is another matter



NISHANT SAHDEV

There is a rule inside a chip factory that visitors always find strange. Do not drink the water.

It is the purest water on the premises, purer than anything sold in a bottle, and that is exactly the problem. A fab runs on ultrapure water, stripped of salts, metals, dissolved gases, bacteria and organic residue until almost nothing is left. Engineers measure how empty it is by electrical resistivity, and the number they want is 18.2 megaohm-centimetres, which is a technical way of saying there is nothing in it capable of carrying a charge. Water in that state is chemically ravenous. It pulls ions out of steel piping, out of glass, out of the lining of your gut. A large plant swallows millions of litres of it a day and must manufacture every litre on site, because the stuff begins spoiling the moment it stops moving.

I offer this because the semicon industry is almost always photographed from one angle: the cleanroom, the white suits, the wafer catching the light. The water tells you what the building actually is. It is a chemical plant that happens to produce computers, and chemistry, not silicon, is where India’s chip ambition will be decided.

Which brings me to a phrase in the Cabinet approval for Semicon 2.0, issued on 15 July, that almost no newspaper quoted. Past the paragraphs about fabs and packaging units and design startups, under the second of the programme’s six pillars, the Government commits to supporting the domestic manufacture and research of semicon equipment, specialty chemicals, industrial gases and critical materials. Four years into a national semicon mission, that is the first time the unglamorous half of this industry has been written into Indian policy with any seriousness. It deserved more attention than it got. It is the part of the mission most likely to fail without anyone noticing until the fix has become expensive.

Three hundred steps, mostly wet

The process itself is a long chemical sequence. A light-sensitive polymer, the photoresist, is spun across the wafer in a film a few hundred nanometres thick. Light prints a pattern into it. A developer dissolves away the parts that were exposed.

Reactive gases eat the pattern down into the layer beneath. Metals and insulators arrive as vapour and condense into place. Abrasive slurries grind the surface flat to within a few atoms. Acids and solvents clean up after every one of these steps, and ultrapure water rinses away the acids. Then it happens again, and again, several hundred times over. The point worth holding on to is that machines are bought once and chemicals are bought forever. A fab that loses its supply of a single etch gas does not slow down. It stops, in days.

What three bottles did to Seoul

Korea learned this in the summer of 2019, when Japan placed three material categories under export licensing: photoresists, high-purity hydrogen fluoride, and fluorinated polyimide. Korean chipmakers were, and are, among the most advanced manufacturers on earth. It made no difference. Executives spent that year flying to Tokyo hunting alternate supply, and Seoul has been pouring money into domestic materials capacity ever since. Nobody had restricted a fab or a machine. Three bottles were enough.

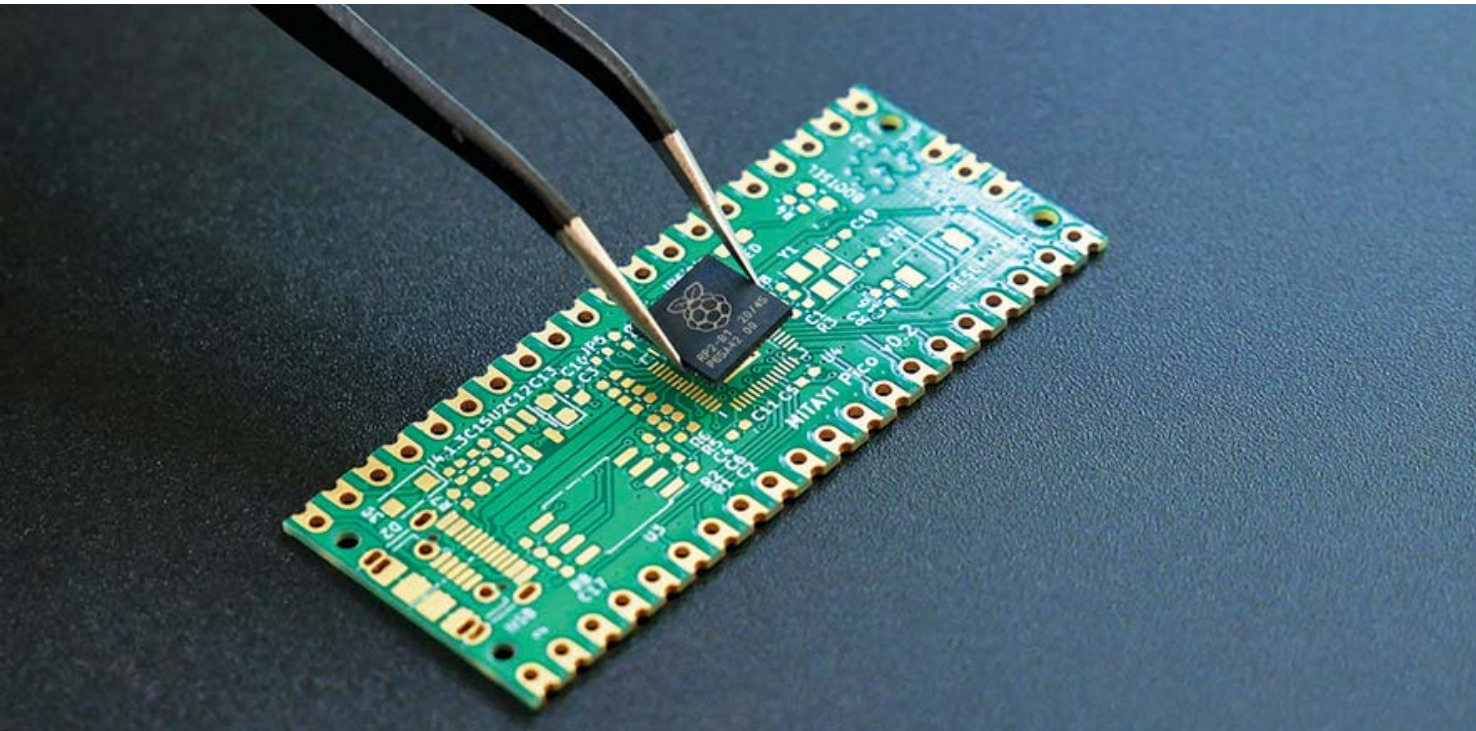
India is currently building the kind of exposure Korea spent the last seven years trying to unwind. We have the world’s sixth-largest chemical industry and a real depth of skill in complex organic synthesis, which is why Indian firms already

that end up inside advanced photoresists made elsewhere. What we do not have is electronic grade. Domestic production of finished photoresists, of high-purity hydrogen peroxide, of ultrapure water systems, ranges from negligible to nonexistent. For the specialty gases used in etching and deposition, along with high-purity hydrogen and helium, India imports well over half of what it consumes by value. Every fab we approve deepens that, unless something moves upstream at the same time.

So the second pillar is the right instinct. The difficulty is that a chemicals ecosystem cannot be built the way a fab is built, and a subsidy line written on fab logic will not produce one.

A millionfold tighter

Start with purity, because the gap is not what most people assume. Indian pharmaceutical manufacturing is world-class, and it controls impurities at parts per million. Several semicon inputs must be



controlled at parts per trillion. That is a millionfold tightening, and it is not the same job done harder. One part per trillion is roughly one second out of thirty-two thousand years.

At that level your contamination is no longer coming from your process; it is coming from the valve, the drum lining, the tanker, the person who opened it.

Which leads to a problem that costs almost nothing to solve and has gone unsolved anyway. Nobody can sell a purity they cannot prove. Certification at trace levels needs metrology, the measurement infrastructure that turns a claim into a document a customer will accept, and India has barely any of it for electronic materials. An Indian supplier today ships samples abroad for verification, waits months, pays for the privilege, and in the process hands a foreign laboratory a fairly detailed picture of what it can make. A national trace-analysis facility, anchored in our standards institutions and open to any Indian firm, would cost a rounding error against ₹1,27,500 crore. It is the single highest-leverage thing this

programme could fund in its first year.

The two years nobody pays for

Then there is the money’s timing, which is where I suspect this pillar will actually break. A fab does not buy your chemical because you built a plant. It buys after qualification, meaning twelve to twenty-four months of sample runs, contamination testing and yield comparison, because one bad batch can scrap wafers worth several million dollars.

Production-linked incentives pay on output. Qualification is precisely the stretch when there is no output, only cost, and a customer who is entitled to say no at the end of it. That is the window in which an Indian supplier dies, and it is the window our incentive design does not cover. Paying against milestones instead, when samples are accepted, when a fab audit is cleared, when a trial batch passes, would cost a fraction of what we hand a single fab and would decide whether any of this becomes an industry.

There is a related fix that requires no money at all. Any fab drawing public support could be required to run a minimum number of qualification trials with Indian suppliers each year and to report the results. Not an obligation to buy,

which would be bad policy and worse engineering. An obligation to test. At the moment Indian firms cannot even get through the door to fail, and failing usefully is how a supplier eventually passes.

The API film, a third time

None of this is exotic. It is the same argument India has had before, in pharmaceuticals, where we mastered the difficult chemistry, exported the intermediate, and let someone else own the finished product and the margin that came with it. The chip industry offers a chance not to run that film a third time, and the window is open for about as long as the current fabs take to reach volume.

The image that will tell us whether Semicon 2.0 worked is not the cleanroom. It is a tanker of electronic-grade hydrogen peroxide pulling up to a fab gate at three in the morning with its certificate in order, having driven there from Ankleshwar rather than sailed from Yokohama. We are not close to that yet. We have, at least, finally written down that we want it.

The author is a physicist at the University of North Carolina at Chapel Hill and a columnist on AI, infrastructure and global systems

AI agents reshaping higher education as teaching partners

The rise of AI agents is redefining learning, bridging classrooms with real-world practice



RAJESH SETH

As universities across India prepare to welcome a new batch of MBA and BBA students in July and early August, the familiar rhythm of a new academic session is about to begin. Classrooms will fill up, new courses will start, and faculty will once again focus on delivering concepts, frameworks, and case studies. Yet, this year feels slightly different. Not because the syllabus has changed dramatically, but because the environment in which students learn has changed. Artificial intelligence is no longer just a tool that students occasionally use. It is quietly becoming a constant presence — one that is beginning to influence how learning actually happens.

For the past few years, much of the discussion around AI in education has focused on tools: chatbots, content generators, and ‘assignment helpers’. The concern has largely been about misuse: students using AI to write assignments or complete tasks. A recent case reported in the media, involving a professor at Brown University, highlighted how students performed significantly better in take-home exams than in in-class assessments, raising concerns about the role of AI. While these concerns are valid, they may be missing the bigger picture.

Emergence of AI agents

We are now seeing the emergence of something more significant: AI agents. Unlike earlier tools, AI agents are not just systems that respond to questions. They can guide students, suggest next steps, interact in a more continuous manner, and adapt to individual needs. In simple terms, they behave more like a digital assistant that works alongside the student or teacher, rather than a tool that is used occasionally. This shift has important implications for higher education, especially for professional courses like MBA and BBA, where the goal is not just knowledge, but application.

One of the most promising roles AI agents can play is in personalised learning. Every classroom has students with different levels of understanding, different speeds of learning, and different interests. Traditionally, it has been difficult for a faculty member to address all these variations within limited time. AI agents can help bridge this gap by providing additional explanations, practice

questions, and feedback tailored to individual students. But this is not the most important change.

Bringing the ‘Real World’ into the classroom

From my own experience of four decades in industry, I believe the real value of AI agents lies elsewhere: in their ability to bring the real world into the classroom.

An AI agent can independently identify and curate the most relevant real-world industry examples across a wide range of subjects, often supplementing them with videos, case studies, and up-to-date insights. In contrast, a faculty member attempting the same task would require significant time and may still struggle to match the breadth, recency, and precision of examples that AI can provide. As a result, AI agents can significantly enhance the quality and relevance of learning materials when used effectively. One of the persistent gaps in management education is the difference between what is taught and what actually happens in organisations. Textbooks and academic frameworks are necessary, but they often simplify reality. Faculty members with purely academic backgrounds may not always have the latest exposure to how businesses are evolving on the ground.

Transformative role of AI agents

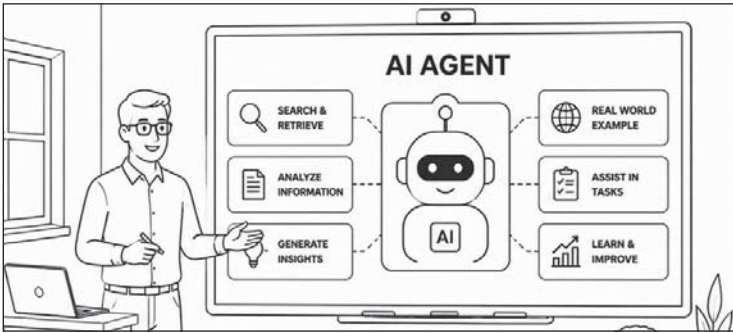
This is where AI agents can play a transformative role.

Imagine a classroom discussion on inventory management. Traditionally, students would learn models such as EOQ, safety stock, and demand forecasting. They might study a few case studies, often dated or simplified. Now, imagine an AI agent that can supplement this discussion by providing current examples: how a large FMCG company is managing distribution challenges, how a cement manufacturer is dealing with demand fluctuations, or how a steel company is optimising supply chains in a volatile market. This kind of dynamic, real-time input can make learning far more meaningful.

Students are not just understanding concepts; they are seeing how those concepts are being applied, adapted, and sometimes even ignored in real-world situations. This exposure is extremely valuable, especially for students who have little or no prior work experience.

Bridge between academia and industry

In that sense, AI agents can act as a bridge between academia and indus-



try. Another area where AI agents can support learning is in continuous feedback. In a typical classroom, feedback is limited: assignments are graded, exams are conducted, and occasional comments are provided. AI systems, however, can offer more frequent and immediate feedback, helping students understand where they are going wrong and how they can improve.

AI agents will also enable continuous, personalised learning beyond the classroom, adapting content, pace, and feedback to individual student needs. By integrating real-time data and contextual insights, they can support faculty in identifying learning gaps early, fostering deeper engagement, and ultimately improving academic outcomes and student success.

At the same time, AI agents can assist faculty members in routine but time-consuming tasks such as grading, preparing teaching material, and designing assessments. This is already beginning to happen in many parts of the world, where AI is being used to evaluate written responses and generate customised learning content. If used thoughtfully, this can free up faculty time for more important activities, mentoring students, facilitating discussions, and bringing in their own insights and experiences.

Not a replacement for teachers

However, it is important to be clear about one thing: AI agents are not a replacement for teachers.

Teaching, especially in higher education, is not just about delivering content. It involves judgement, context, values, and human interaction. AI can support these processes, but it cannot fully replicate them. In fact, the role of the teacher may become even more important to guide students on how to use AI effec-

tively, how to question its outputs, and how to apply learning in real-life situations. There are also legitimate concerns that need to be addressed. Over-reliance on AI can weaken critical thinking if students start accepting answers without questioning them. Issues of data privacy, accuracy, and bias also need careful attention. Institutions will need to develop clear guidelines on how AI should be used in teaching and assessment.

But these challenges should not lead us to resist the technology altogether. Every major shift in education, from the introduction of calculators to the use of the internet, has raised similar concerns. Over time, institutions have adapted, and teaching methods have evolved. AI agents represent the next phase of this evolution.

Key is to integrate AI meaningfully

The key question for educators is not whether AI should be used, but how it should be integrated meaningfully. As the new academic session begins, this may be a good time for institutions and faculty members to reflect on this shift. Instead of viewing AI only as a risk to be managed, it can be seen as an opportunity to enhance learning, especially by making it more connected to the realities of the business world.

If used well, AI agents can help move management education closer to its ultimate objective: preparing students not just to pass examinations, but to understand and navigate the complexities of real organisations.

The transition from tools to teaching partners has already begun. The institutions that recognise this early, and adapt thoughtfully, are likely to create more engaging and relevant learning experiences for their students. The real promise of AI agents lies in their ability to bring the world into the classroom, and prepare students for the world they will step into.

The author is an alumnus of IIM Ahmedabad and Professor of Practice at IILM University, Gurugram with an interest in AI, Technology and Strategy

AI is reweaving the future of fashion



ROHIT YADAV

Throughout the ages, fashion has mirrored the spirit of its times. The Industrial Revolution mechanized textile production, and e-commerce revolutionized how consumers shop. Today, a new transformation is underway, one far more profound than digitising storefronts. Artificial Intelligence (AI) is redefining fashion itself, changing how clothes are designed, how trends are forecast, how inventories are managed, and even how consumers perceive style. Creativity is no longer dependent on human intuition alone. It is increasingly complemented by algorithms that analyse millions of data points in real time.

India, one of the fastest growing retail markets, is undergoing this shift firsthand. Reliance Retail’s AZORTE, a technology first fashion format, uses AI powered body scanning and smart trial rooms to recommend fit and style in real time, offering a glimpse of the future. Globally, Stitch Fix has built an entire business model on this idea, combining client style surveys with machine learning models and human stylists to curate personalised shipments for millions of shoppers. Together, such examples show that technology is becoming as integral to fashion as fabric and craftsmanship. These innovations promise convenience and personalisation, yet raise an important question: can fashion remain a medium of human expression when algorithms increasingly influence what we wear?

The answer lies not in opposing AI, but in understanding its role as an enabler rather than a replacement for human creativity.

One of AI’s most transformative contributions is its ability to predict trends before they turn mainstream. Conventionally, forecasting relied on designers’ interpretations, market research, and seasonal observation. Today, AI systems scan social media conversations, online searches, purchase histories, influencer content, and customer reviews to spot



emerging trends

rapidly and accurately. Instead of reacting to demand after it materialises, brands can anticipate it months in advance. Zara built its famed fast fashion model on exactly this logic: point of sale and RFID data feed directly into its design and production teams, letting new styles reach stores within weeks rather than seasons. AI is now extending that same rapid feedback loop to retailers who are trying to build similar infrastructure.

This precision reduces the risk of overproduction and unsold inventory, a problem that has long plagued the industry. AI powered demand forecasting is therefore more than a business edge, it is a genuine move towards sustainability. Producing what consumers are likely to buy is far more responsible than manufacturing vast quantities on uncertain assumptions.

Beyond forecasting, AI is turning the shopping experience into something deeply personal. Every customer leaves behind a digital footprint: browsing patterns, purchases, preferred colours, body measurements, and time spent viewing products. Myntra’s My Stylist feature illustrates this well, using computer vision and neural network models trained on its catalogue to recommend complete outfits from a customer’s browsing history, past purchases, and even photos of their own wardrobe. Physical stores are beginning to mirror this data driven approach. Smart fitting rooms use sensors to recommend fits

based on height and skin tone, and can project different colour options without customers leaving the trial area. Digital mirrors and interactive displays now blur the line between online and offline retail.

AI is also reshaping one of fashion’s least visible but most critical functions: supply chain management. The industry runs on a complex web of designers, manufacturers, suppliers, logistics providers, and retailers, where a delay at any stage can mean empty shelves or excess inventory. AI improves this coordination by forecasting regional demand, optimising inventory allocation, cutting transportation inefficiencies, and enabling

faster replenishment. This matters especially for India, whose supply chains span diverse geographies and uneven infrastructure. Better inventory planning reduces stock outs and warehousing costs while cutting the transportation and overproduction that undermine sustainability.

Perhaps AI’s most fascinating application lies in the creative process itself. Generative AI can now produce multiple design concepts within minutes, built around chosen themes, colours, fabrics, or consumer preferences. Coach used exactly this approach when it trained a custom Adobe Firefly model on its own design archive, letting teams generate digital handbag concepts and test silhouettes before a single physical sample was cut. The digital fashion house The Fabricant goes further still, using generative image models to design entire garments and collections that exist only as data, letting designers iterate through hundreds of variations before committing to a final look. In both cases, designers use AI generated options as a starting point, refining them through human judgment rather than accepting them wholesale.

Please read the complete article online at dailypioneer.com

The author is Assistant Professor, School of Business Management, Narsee Monjee Institute of Management Studies, Mumbai

FROM THE WORLD

CANADA

Indian woman shot dead

A 26-year-old Indian-origin woman was shot dead in a suspected targeted attack in Canada's Toronto city, police said. A 37-year-old man, also of Indian descent, was arrested on charges of her murder, they said.

The shooting took place on Friday morning at the Humberwood Boulevard and Rexdale Boulevard intersection, the Toronto Police Service said in a statement on Saturday.

The victim was identified as Navneet Kaur, while the accused, arrested by the Ontario Provincial Police, was identified as Sharnjeet Singh of Brampton.

(PTI)

NEPAL

One killed in violence

One person was killed and several others, including security personnel, were injured in a communal clash in Nepal's Sunsari district, bordering India, prompting authorities to impose indefinite restrictive orders in parts of the area from Monday.

According to the District Administration Office, Sunsari, the prohibitory orders took effect from 7:00 am and cover five market areas in the district, located in the Koshi province. The restrictions will remain in force until further notice.

(PTI)

US-Iran tensions ease as mediators push for talks

SAMY MAGDY/ ELENA BECATOROS
■ Cairo

Mediators have achieved progress in efforts to get the United States and Iran back to negotiations and avert an all-out war in the West Asia, two regional officials said on Monday, with a pause in attacks coming after a period of rapidly escalating tensions.

The comments came after neither the US nor Iran reported carrying out any attacks for three straight days—a respite after about two weeks of sustained bombardments that had led to increasing fears of a return to all-out war.

The two regional officials, who spoke on condition of anonymity to discuss the sensitive regional talks, said mediators led by Qatar and Pakistan were working to bridge the gap between



Washington and Tehran to return to an interim ceasefire deal that had been largely undermined by recent exchanges of fire.

The US has paused attacks after

targeting Iranian coastal areas and infrastructure in a nearly two-week escalation sparked by Iran's firing at ships trying to transit the Strait of Hormuz, a crucial water-

way for global oil shipments. The Pentagon did not respond to questions. US President Donald Trump is “giving talks some space. He’s giving it a little bit of room,” Mike Waltz, the US ambassador to the United Nations, told *Fox News*.

“We’ve had both Oman and Iran, and a number of our other negotiators, engaged at every level, from the most senior levels all the way down to the technical level over the past few weeks, and particularly in the past few days.”

Waltz dismissed the idea that the US stockpile of interceptors crucial in defending against Iranian attacks is running low, but experts have questioned how long both the US and Iran can afford to keep up attacks.

Since the US has halted attacks for the past two nights, Iran has as well, its army spokesperson told

Iran's state TV on Sunday. Tehran in recent days has counterattacked against countries in the region hosting US military forces, killing at least three service members at a base in Jordan and one in Iraq.

One of the regional officials who spoke to AP Monday described the progress made in mediation efforts as “significant”.

He said mediators were working with Iran and Oman on a mechanism for managing vessels' transit through the Strait of Hormuz, which was the trigger for the latest round of strikes and counterstrikes between Iran and the US. Iran's Foreign Ministry spokesperson, Esmail Baghaei, said during a news conference in Tehran Monday that mediators were conveying messages but that no direct negotiations were being held with the US. “Mediators may convey mes-

sages to us from the American side regarding ongoing developments in the region. But at present, we have no negotiations with the American side,” Baghaei said.

He said several rounds of talks had already been held between Iran and Oman, which lies on the other side of the Strait of Hormuz, on Friday and Saturday on how to manage ship traffic through the waterway. “The objective is for Iran and Oman, as the two coastal states, to develop mechanisms to ensure safe navigation through the Strait of Hormuz while respecting the sovereign rights and sovereignty of both coastal states, as well as Iran's security and national interests” Baghaei said.

However, he stressed that “the situation in the Strait of Hormuz has not changed” and that the waterway remains closed. (AP)

Bangladesh: Charges filed against Hasina, 40 others in crimes against humanity case

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Dhaka

Bangladesh's International Crimes Tribunal (ICT) prosecution on Monday filed formal charges against deposed prime minister Sheikh Hasina and 40 others in a crimes against humanity case related to a police crackdown on a rally in Dhaka in 2013.

Several people were killed allegedly during police action on Islamist group Hefazat-e-Islam's protest rally in May 2013, when Hasina's Awami League was in power.

The charges were submitted to the registrar of the ICT on Monday.

The tribunal “has taken into contingency charges against her (Hasina) and 40 others over the killings at (capital's) Shapla Chattar



during the Hefazat-e-Islam protest rally,” chief prosecutor Aminul Islam told reporters. The tribunal also issued arrest warrants for the fugitives, including the then army chief, other politicians and security officials.

Nine of the high-profile accused, including former ministers, senior police offi-

cers and journalists, are in jail to face the trial, according to the prosecution.

Hasina, 78, was sentenced to death by the same tribunal in November last year after a trial in absentia for a superior role in taming a student-led protest which toppled her Awami League Government in 2024.

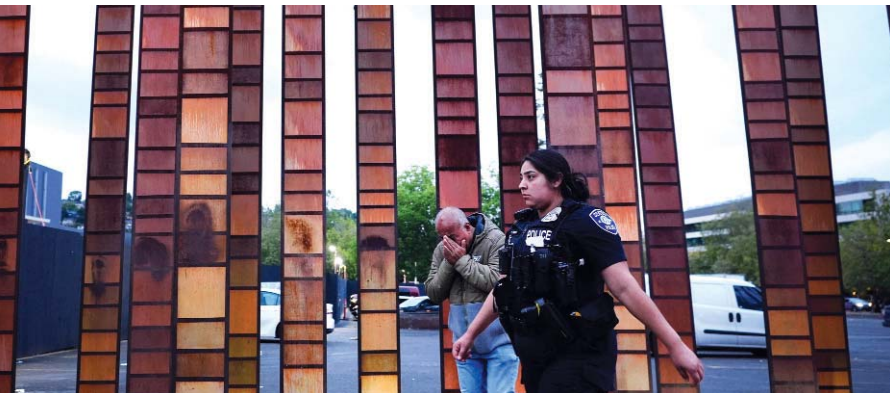
US police hunt second suspect in mass shooting

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Seattle

Police searched for a second suspect Monday after gunfire erupted at a crowded food festival beneath Seattle's Space Needle, leaving three people dead and four others wounded, including a toddler. Another suspect was earlier arrested.

Investigators believe the two suspects were shooting at each other Sunday and, although one remained on the loose, Assistant Seattle Police Chief Tyrone Davis told a news conference Sunday night that there was no ongoing threat to the public. Police did not have a description of the out-standing suspect, he said.

“We're still trying to figure this out,” Davis said. Police did not immediately respond to phone and email messages early Monday. Two people



An unidentified man is led into the scene of a shooting by police after they responded to the shooting at Seattle Centre

died at the scene and a third died at a hospital. They were described as two men, ages 19 and 44, and a 56-year-old woman.

The four wounded, including a 2-year-old boy, were hospitalised and in stable condition early Monday, police said. The rest of the

wounded were adults. Davis couldn't say if any of the victims were involved in the confrontation.

The gunfire erupted around 6 pm. Sunday in the waning hours of the Bite of Seattle, an annual three-day festival that draws hundreds of food and retail vendors

and performers.

Dozens of officers were providing security at the event and some saw one of the suspects firing, Davis said. One suspect surrendered at the scene, but the other fled. Law enforcement searched the grounds to no avail.

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APPENDIX- IV-A [SEE PROVISO TO RULE 8(6) & 9(1) SALE NOTICE FOR SALE OF IMMOVABLE PROPERTIES							
E-Auction Sale Notice for sale of Immovable Assets under the Securitization and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 read with proviso to Rule 8(6) & 9(1) of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002.							
Notice is hereby given to the public in general and in particular to the borrower(s) and guarantor(s) that the below described immovable property mortgaged / charged to the Central Bank of India (secured creditor), the constructive/ physical Possession of which have been taken by the authorized officer of Central Bank of India(Secured creditors), will be sold on "As is where is", "As is what is" and "whatever there is" basis on date 14.08.2026 for recovery of dues to the Central Bank of India from below mention Borrower(s) and Guarantor(s). The Reserve Price and Earnest money deposit (EMD) is displayed against the details of respective properties.							
E-AUCTION SCHEDULED TO BE HELD ON 14.08.2026 (15 DAY'S NOTICE)							
S. No.	Name of Branch	Authorised Officer / B.M.	Name of the Account	Description of Property & Owner Name	Demand Notice Date & Amount Dues (In Rupees)	Date & Type of Possession	In Rupees Reserve Price EMD Bid Increase
1.	Akshardham New Delhi	Mr. R. S. Mishra Mobile: 8800013551	PUJA ENTERPRISES	Shop No.318 Part of Old Office No 10, 11, 12 on Third Floor Property R-22 Out of Khasra No.473 Building Khaneja Complex Shakarpur Village Madawali Fazalpur Delhi-110092. Area 45 Sq Ft Owner : Dinesh Kumar Yadav	25.02.2020 Rs.54.84 Lakh + Other Charges Applicable Deductions/ Repayments	10.02.2023 (Physical)	₹ 2,80,000.00 ₹ 28,000.00 ₹ 10,000.00
2.	Akshardham New Delhi	Mr. R. S. Mishra Mobile: 8800013551	PUJA ENTERPRISES	Shop No.317 Part of Old Office No 10, 11, 12 on Third Floor property R-22 Out of Khasra No.473 Building Khaneja Complex Shakarpur Village Madawali Fazalpur Delhi-110092. Area 180 Sq Ft Owner : Dinesh Kumar Yadav	25.02.2020 Rs.54.84 Lakh + Other Charges Applicable Deductions/ Repayments	10.02.2023 (Physical)	₹ 11,00,000.00 ₹ 1,10,000.00 ₹ 15,000.00
3.	Angel's Public School New Delhi	Mr. Rajesh Yadav Mobile: 8349135200	ANJU DEVI	Prop No-1/801 (Plot No.- 72/74), Third Floor (With Roof Rights) Situated In The Area Of Village-Chandrawali Alias Shahdara In The Abadi Of Opp. Rehman Building West Rohtash Nagar, Illaqa Shahadra, Dethi-110032. Area : 369 Sq Ft Owner: Anju Devi W/o. Mr. Varun Jain	16.11.2024 Rs.15.87 Lakh + Other Charges Applicable Deductions/ Repayments	21.07.2025 (Physical)	₹ 17,80,000.00 ₹ 1,78,000.00 ₹ 15,000.00
4.	Bhagirath Palace Delhi	Mr. Sandeep Kumar Mobile: 9999463960	DHARMENDRA	Shop No. C-30, Ground Floor, Block-B, Brij Vihar, Sector-8, Ghaziabad. Area 12.34 Sq M Owner: Dharmendra Kumar	01.08.2019 Rs.7.76 Lakh + Other Charges Applicable Deductions/ Repayments	15.05.2025 (Physical)	₹ 12,90,000.00 ₹ 1,20,000.00 ₹ 10,000.00
5.	Ghaziabad	Mr. Bhawani Deen Mobile: 9999467102	VIJAY RANJAN THOMAS	Built Up Freehold Residential Property Bearing No. RZ-37 (Old No. 37) Second Floor, Back Side Portion, Without Roof /Terrace Rights, Built on Land Area 50 Sq Yards Or 41.80 Sq Mtr And Super Area 450 Sq Ft., Total Plot Area 100 Sq Yard Out of Khasra No.35, Situated in the Area of Village Bindapur, Delhi, Now Residential Colony is Known as Subhash Park Uttam Nagar Extn II New Delhi -110059. Area 50 Sqyd Owner: Vijay Ranjan Thomas	11.11.2024 Rs.7.46 Lakh + Other Charges Applicable Deductions/ Repayments	29.04.2026 (Physical)	₹ 18,00,000.00 ₹ 1,80,000.00 ₹ 15,000.00
6.	LRPG College Ghaziabad	Ms. Ekta Kapoor Mob: 8800013520	AARTI KAPOOR	Flat No. 304 Mig First Floor Right Hand Back Side Without Roof Rights, Situated At Plot No. B-11/15, Dlf Ankur Vihar, Hadbast Village-Sadullabad, Pargana & Tehsil Loni Distt. Ghaziabad Uttar Pradesh. Area-55.74 Sq Mtr Owner: Aarti Kapoor W/O Nitin Kapoor	22.11.2023 Rs.22.43 Lakh + Other Charges Applicable Deductions/ Repayments	02.12.2025 (Physical)	₹ 19,20,000.00 ₹ 1,92,000.00 ₹ 15,000.00
7.	LRPG College Ghaziabad	Ms. Ekta Kapoor Mob: 8800013520	KUMAR GAURAV	Flat No FF-4, First Floor, Without Roof Rights Right Hand Back Side S.L.F. Ved Vihar, Plot No. E-16,Village Sadullabad,Pargana,Tehsil Loni District Ghaziabad (U.P.) 201002 Area - 37.16 Sq Mtr Owner: Kumar Gaurav	30.01.2025 Rs.13.71 Lakh + Other Charges Applicable Deductions/ Repayments	13.03.2026 (Physical)	₹ 10,00,000.00 ₹ 1,20,000.00 ₹ 10,000.00
8.	Patel Nagar Ghaziabad	Mr. Vinod Meena Mob: 9694707646	HARENDRA KUMAR	Ground Floor Without Roof Right Plot No. C-28 Khasra No. 1541 Keshav Kunj, Hadbast Gram, Raseaipur, Pargana-Dasna Tesil & District Ghaziabad Uttar Pradesh. Area -667.36 Sq Ft Owner: Mr.Harendra Kumar	09.08.2023 Rs.15.33 Lakh + Other Charges Applicable Deductions/ Repayments	04.06.2025 (Physical)	₹ 15,00,000.00 ₹ 1,50,000.00 ₹ 15,000.00
9.	Patel Nagar Ghaziabad	Mr. Vinod Meena Mob: 9694707646	MR. ABHAY SHARMA	Flat Bearing No. G-01, Ground Floor Without Roof Rights, Plot No. 46, Out Of Khasra No.- 1586, Krishna Enclave, Vill- Harsaon, Tehsil and District Ghaziabad Uttar Pradesh. Area- 57.00 Sq Mtr Owner: Abhay Sharma	02.07.2019 Rs.14.38 Lakh + Other Charges Applicable Deductions/ Repayments	09.01.2026 (Physical)	₹ 11,50,000.00 ₹ 1,15,000.00 ₹ 10,000.00
E-AUCTION DATE: 14.08.2026, TIME: 12:00 NOON TO 04:00 PM WITH AUTO EXTENSION OF 10 MINUTES Last Date & Time of Submission of EMD and Documents (Online) On or Before: 14.08.2026 Upto 03:30 PM. Bidder will register on website: https://BAANKNET.com and upload KYC documents and after verification of KYC documents by the service provider, EMD to be deposited in BAANKNET EMD wallet through NEFT/RTGS/Transfer / Generation of challan from (https://BAANKNET.com). The auction will be conducted through common landing platform BAANKNET.com Portal (https://BAANKNET.com). E-auction will be held "As is where is", "As is what is" and "whatever there is" basis. (All other charges/ dues to the property will be borne by the purchaser). For detailed terms and conditions please refer to the link provided in www.centralbank.bank.in Secured Creditor or auction platform (https://BAANKNET.com). Helpdesk: (+91) 8291220220, E-mail: support.BAANKNET@psballiance.com STATUTORY 15 DAY'S SALE NOTICE UNDER RULE 8(6) & 9(1) OF THE SARFAESI ACT, 2002 Borrowers/Guarantors/ Mortgageors are hereby notified to pay the sum as mentioned above along with upto date interest and ancillary expenses before the date of e-auction, failing which the property will be auctioned/sold and balance dues, if any, will be recovered with interest and cost.							
DATE: 27.07.2026 PLACE: DELHI							
Authorised Officer, CENTRAL BANK OF INDIA, RO Delhi (North), Delhi							
..... to be continued							

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Coal India profit rises to ₹8,852 crore in Q1

State-owned CIL on Monday reported a 0.6 per cent increase in consolidated net profit to ₹8,852.11 crore in the June quarter, aided by higher revenues. The company had posted a consolidated net profit of ₹8,797.05 crore in the year-ago period, Coal India Ltd (CIL) said in a filing to the BSE. The consolidated revenue from operations during the first quarter rose 8 per cent to ₹46,254.80 crore over ₹42,919.20 crore in the corresponding quarter of the previous fiscal year. Total expenses of the coal behemoth rose to ₹36,816.23 crore over ₹32,903.19 crore in the year-ago period. The company's board had declared interim dividend of ₹5.50 per equity share for 2026-27. In a presentation, the company said it produced 169.63 million tonnes of coal during the quarter as against 183.32 million tonnes (MT) in the year-ago period. The coal offtake rose to 197.86 MT from 190.96 MT a year earlier. The closing coal stock of CIL as on June 30, 2026 was 101.35 MT, CIL said, adding that the "increase of inventory with respect to 30th June 2025 was 2.41 MT." Coal India accounts for over 80 per cent of domestic coal production. (PTI)

India's top 7 cities face retail space crunch: Anarock

Fresh supply of retail spaces in shopping malls fell 57 per cent to 0.9 million sq ft during January-June across seven major cities due to delays in construction activities, according to Anarock. The new supply of retail spaces stood at 2.8 million sq ft in the year-ago period. The seven major cities are – Mumbai, Delhi-NCR, Bengaluru, Pune, Hyderabad, Chennai and Kolkata. Real estate consultant Anarock reported that gross leasing of retail spaces in malls stood at about 4.1 million sq ft in the first half of the 2026 calendar year, a 24 per cent decline from the corresponding period of the preceding year. The consultant attributed the lower supply of retail spaces in malls to various reasons, including land availability, rising land cost, higher capex commitment compared to housing projects and the delay in government approvals. Anuj Kejriwal, CEO - Retail & CEO – Europe, Middle East & Africa at Anarock Group, said, "The supply problem is cumulative and escalating - data of India's top seven cities over the past 16 years shows a persistent mismatch between Grade A retail supply and leasing demand." While new mall completions fluctuated sharply on a year-on-year basis, he noted that the leasing demand has steadily absorbed available Grade A space, pushing vacancy rates lower. "We now have a chronically supply-constrained market where retailers' biggest challenge is not drawing shoppers but finding the right spaces to serve them in," Kejriwal said. On the demand-supply scenario of the past three calendar years, Anarock said the top seven cities added 5.3 million sq ft of new Grade A retail supply in 2023 against gross leasing of 6.5 million sq ft. During 2024, new supply fell sharply to just 1.1 million sq ft, while leasing stayed at 6.5 million sq ft. While new mall supply recovered partially in 2025 with 5.2 million sq ft of new completions, leasing surged to a record 13 million sq ft, the consultant said. "The shortage of Grade A mall space is not simply a function of developers failing to respond to demand. Building a successful large-format retail asset is considerably more complex than delivering other forms of real estate," Anarock observed. The consultant noted that the development of a Grade A mall requires a large and contiguous land parcel in a strategically located catchment. (PTI)

The Pioneer

NEW DELHI | TUESDAY | JULY 28, 2026

Markets snap five-day losing streak; Sensex jumps 776 pts

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

Stock markets snapped the five-day losing streak on Monday, with the benchmark Sensex jumping by 776 points following a sharp decline in crude oil prices amid easing tensions in West Asia. The 30-share BSE Sensex jumped 776.01 points, or 1.02 per cent, to settle at 76,835.78. During the day, it soared 841.74 points, or 1.10 per cent, to 76,901.51. The 50-share NSE Nifty surged 228.50 points, or 0.96 per cent, to end at 23,995.95, ending its five-day losing trend. Among Sensex firms, Eternal jumped the most by 5.70 per cent. InterGlobe Aviation, Infosys, Bajaj Finance, Asian Paints and Mahindra & Mahindra were also among the gainers. HDFC Bank, Power Grid and Axis Bank were the lag-

Company	%
ETERNAL	5.63
IndiGo	4.94
Infosys	3.66
Bajaj Finance	3.05
Asian Paints	2.87

Company	%
HDFC Bank	-0.41
Axis Bank	-0.05

gards. Brent crude, the global oil benchmark, tanked 9.40 per cent to \$87.64 per barrel. "A pause in strikes in West Asia has eased concerns over rising import costs and infla-

tion, triggering a relief rally in markets. The sharp correction in crude oil prices, along with a decline in long-term bond yields, has also raised hopes of a durable resolution, supported by signs of long unwinding," Vinod Nair, Head of Research, Geojit Investments Limited, said. Foreign Institutional Investors (FIIs) offloaded equities worth ₹3,892.77 crore on Friday, according to exchange data. In Asian markets, South Korea's KOSPI, Japan's Nikkei 225 index, Shanghai's SSE Composite index and Hong Kong's Hang Seng index ended higher. Markets in Europe were trading higher. US markets ended mostly higher. On Friday, the Sensex declined 331.62 points, or 0.43 per cent, to settle at 76,059.77. The Nifty dipped 102.15 points, or 0.43 per cent, to end at 23,767.45.

BUSINESS

13

Govt asked to revive State-owned urea plants

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A parliamentary panel has asked the government to explore revival of urea fertiliser plants at Durgapur, Haldia and Korba to boost domestic demand and reduce import dependency. India imported more than 100 lakh tonne of urea during 2025-26 fiscal. In the Lok Sabha on Monday, Standing Committee on Chemicals and Fertilizers presented a report on 'Self-sufficiency in production of fertilizers with a view to curb import of fertilizers - review of constraints thereof. The report pertains to Ministry of Chemicals and Fertilizers (Department of Fertilizers). The panel pointed out that the domestic urea production stood at 307 lakh tonne against consumption of 388 lakh tonne in 2024-25. The demand is projected to rise to 444 lakh tonne by 2035-36. In view of rising demand, the committee is of the view that existing idle infrastructure may merit closer consideration in the overall strategy for enhancing domestic capacity. "The committee note that the Department's reply effectively defers a decision on the revival of the

Durgapur and Haldia units of HFCL (Hindustan Fertilizer Corporation Ltd) and the Korba unit of FCIL (Fertilizer Corporation of India) to a future stage, based on the demand supply gap of urea after the operationalization of existing plants," the report said. The Korba unit of FCIL, despite its locational advantage in Chhattisgarh, has not been specifically addressed in the government's reply, the report said. The committee, therefore, recommended that the "government may consider examining the feasibility of revival of the Durgapur, Haldia and Korba units in a time bound manner, in alignment with evolving demand supply dynamics." The department should also consider commissioning techno-economic feasibility studies for these units, including assessment of appropriate technological options such as coal gasification for Korba, the panel said, while directing the department to apprise on this issue. Further, the committee asked the department to share updates on the progress regarding finalization of the Durgapur lease deed with the West Bengal government.

Rupee surges 61 paise to settle at 95.92 against US dollar

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Mumbai

The rupee appreciated sharply by 61 paise to close at 95.92 (provisional) against the US dollar on Monday, driven by a steep correction in crude oil prices after the US and Iran paused the war in West Asia, triggering hopes of easing global trade tensions. According to forex traders, the local currency also found support from a firm trend in domestic equities and weakness in the US dollar against major currencies. At the interbank foreign exchange, the rupee opened at 96.18 and touched the low of 96.27 and high of 95.78 against the greenback during the session. The local unit finally settled at 95.92 (Provisional) against the dollar, up 61 paise compared to its previous closing level. On Friday, the rupee recovered from its record low levels to settle 20 paise higher at 96.53 against the US dollar.

Company	%
ETERNAL	5.63
IndiGo	4.94
Infosys	3.66
Bajaj Finance	3.05
Asian Paints	2.87

Company	%
HDFC Bank	-0.41
Axis Bank	-0.05

The rupee's all-time low closing level of 96.86 was recorded on May 20. Anuj Choudhary, Research Analyst,

Mirae Asset ShareKhan, said the rupee strengthened to the highest levels in three weeks as the US and Iran halted strikes after two weeks of escalation. "Falling crude oil prices and softening of the US dollar also favoured the rupee. Reports of intervention by the RBI also supported the rupee," Choudhary said, adding, "USD-INR spot price is expected to trade in a range of ₹95.50 to ₹96.20". Meanwhile, the dollar index, which gauges the greenback's strength against a basket of six currencies, was trading 0.20 per cent lower at 101.09. Brent crude, the global oil benchmark, declined 8.95 per cent to USD 88.12 per barrel in futures trade as the US and Iran halted attacks and hinted at moving on to a negotiation table. US President Donald Trump is "giving talks some space", Mike Waltz, the US ambassador to the United Nations, told a news channel.

Global markets gain as oil sink nearly 7% on easing West Asia tensions

ELAINE KURTENBACH ■ Bangkok

World shares were mostly higher Monday and oil prices slipped nearly 7% as the US and Iran refrained from fighting while discussing a possible resumption of negotiations on an interim ceasefire deal. Shares in Chinese memory chip-maker CXMT soared 466 per cent as they began trading on Shanghai's technology board. The company jumped to become China's most valuable listed company with an estimated market capitalisation of 3.3 trillion yuan (nearly \$490 billion). The Pentagon did not respond to questions about the pause in attacks on Iranian coastal areas and infrastructure after nearly two weeks of escalating fighting sparked by Iran's firing at ships trying to transit the Strait of Hormuz. But markets reacted with relief. US futures surged early Monday and the price of a barrel of Brent crude, the international standard, dropped 6.8 per cent to \$85.49.

US benchmark crude dropped 7 per cent to \$ 83.06 per barrel. "Oil's sharp retreat at the Monday open did more than knock a few dollars off the barrel. It loosened the geopolitical knot that had been

tightening around equities, currencies, bonds and central banks for most of July," Stephen Innes of SPI Asset Management said in a commentary. In early European trading, Germany's DAX gained 1.6 per cent to 25,497.42 and the CAC 40 in Paris was up 0.8 per cent at 8,436.94. Britain's FTSE 100 rose 0.5 per cent to 10,784.00. The futures for the S&P 500 and Dow Jones Industrial Average were up 1 per cent. In Asian trading, Japan's benchmark Nikkei 225 rose 0.5 per cent to 64,931.19, while the Kospi in South Korea advanced 1 per cent to 6,755.75. Hong Kong's Hang Seng climbed 1 per cent to 25,207.18, while the Shanghai Composite index gained 1.2 per cent to 3,858.25. In Australia, the S&P/ASX 200

surged 1.4 per cent to 8,894.00. Taiwan's Taiex slipped 0.1 per cent and the Sensex in India added 1.1 per cent. On Friday, the S&P 500 barely budged, picking up less than 0.1 per cent and notching its second straight losing week for the first time since March. The Dow industrials rose 0.5 per cent. The Nasdaq composite index slipped 0.6 per cent, weighed down by sharp losses for heavyweights like Micron Technology, which fell 7 per cent, and Broadcom, which lost 2.7 per cent. Recent surges in energy prices and fresh tariffs announced last week by the administration of US President Donald Trump could result in hotter inflation, which has been squeezing consumers and looming over the Federal Reserve's interest rate policy.

Gujarat unveils shipbuilding policy, eyes more than ₹27,000 cr investment

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Ahmedabad

The Gujarat government on Monday launched its shipbuilding policy aimed at developing the state into India's leading maritime manufacturing hub through fiscal incentives, infrastructure development and skill creation, an official said. Chief Minister Bhupendra Patel launched the Gujarat Shipbuilding and Repair Policy 2026, which envisages setting up two Integrated Mega Shipbuilding Parks,

increasing the state's shipbuilding capacity to more than 50 lakh Deadweight Tonnage (DWT) and attracting investments worth over ₹27,000 crore, a government release stated.

DWT is the maximum weight a ship can carry safely. The policy also aims to provide skill development and capacity-building training to over five lakh people. Speaking at the launch, Patel said, "This policy will create a globally competitive shipbuilding ecosystem in Gujarat and strengthen the state's role in achieving the vision of Viksit Gujarat 2047 and Aatmanirbhar Bharat." According to the state government, the policy aligns with the Centre's Shipbuilding Financial Assistance Scheme

2025 and Maritime Vision 2047. The policy seeks to develop a future-ready shipbuilding ecosystem by promoting marine equipment manufacturing, research and development, startups, ancillary industries and capacity building. It is also aimed at promoting sustainable and green shipyards, developing smart shipyards sector.

PUBLIC NOTICE
I, Rashmi Singh D/o Shri Gandharv Singh Kapoor (R/o)-45, South City-1, Gurgaon, Haryana, 122001, I have purchased a property bearing Unit Nos. T-3/2107 and T-3/2507 Project Azalia, situated at I, Hues Sector 68, Azalia, Adlampur- Tikdi Road, Badshahpur, Gurgaon, Haryana - 122001. I've lost the original allotment letter & receipts of above properties. I have requested to M/s DSC Estate Developers Pvt Ltd, to issue the duplicate allotment letters & receipts of the said properties. If anybody or financial institutions have objection, he/she may contact to M/s DSC Estate Developers Pvt Ltd office at above mentioned address within fifteen days.

Change of Name

Kapil Rai, Son of Shri Mukund Rai residing at 02, Garh Road, Ganga Nagar, Alamgirpur, Garhmukteshwar, Hapur, Uttar Pradesh My name has been mistekly written as Kapil Ray, but my correct name is Kapil Rai and it should be read and written as such in all the documents.

NORTHERN RAILWAY	
CORRIGENDUM	
Ref: Tender Notice No. 20/2026-2027 dated 15.06.2026 S. No. 03 Tender Number: 77259051RGC Opening date 30.07.2026. In reference to above, Tender Opening date has been extended from 30.07.2026 to 13.08.2026. All other terms and conditions remain unchanged. The corrigendum has been published on website www.ireps.gov.in. Note: This is the Second Corrigendum in above referred tender. Date: 24.07.2026	2589/2026
SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE	

NORTHERN RAILWAY	
TENDER NOTICE	
Sr. Divisional Mechanical Engineer, Northern Railway, Trainset Depot, Shakurbasti; for and on behalf of President of India, invites IREPS (www.ireps.gov.in) for the under noted work.	
Tender No.	258WPT-18R
Name of Work	Development of Test Benches & Model Room at Trainset Depot, Shakurbasti.
Approximate Cost	Rs.40,34,420.00/- including GST
Earnest Money	Rs.80,700.00/-
Completion Period of the work	6 Months
Date and time for opening of tender	17.08.2026 at 15:00
Website particulars notice board location where complete details of tender can be seen	Above tender is available on IREPS site i.e. www.ireps.gov.in w.e.f. 25.07.2026, 16:23 hrs.
No. 25.8.1024.DSL.SSB Date: 25.07.2026	2580/2026
Serving Customers With A Smile	

NORTHERN RAILWAY				
Tender Notice				
Invitation of Tenders through E-Procurement System				
Principal Chief Materials Manager, Northern Railway, New Delhi-110001 for and on behalf of the President of India, invites e-tenders through e-procurement system for supply of the following items:-				
Sr. No.	Tender No.	Brief Description	Qty.	Closing Date
01	77265440	Driving Axle Set Complete	01 Nos	24.08.2026
02	19260696	Membrane For Hirth Coupling	430 Nos	24.08.2026
03	07265064	Yam Damper for VB Trainset	160 Nos	24.08.2026
04	08265350	RGC Tender for 6 Quad 0.9 MM Cable	3424.22 KM	31.08.2026
05	04250036	Servo Lube	130620 LTR	01.09.2026
06	02262514	Maintenance Free Valve Regulated Lead Acid Batteries Set For 110V	326 Set	07.09.2026
07	07262022	Lower Spring Beam for AC Coaches	200 Nos	09.09.2026
08	07261095	Guide with Closing Plate for Axle Box	3072 Nos	16.09.2026
Note: 1. Vendors may visit the IREPS website i.e. www.ireps.gov.in for details. 2. No manual offer will be entertained. Tender Notice No. 29/2026-2027 Dated: 27.07.2026				
2586/2026				
Serving Customers With A Smile				

GOVERNMENT OF HARYANA TENDER NOTICE						
SR NO	NAME OF DEPARTMENT	NAME OF WORK NOTICE TENDER	OPENING DATE CLOSING DATE	AMOUNT / EMD (APPROX.) IN RUPEES	WEBSITE OF THE DEPARTMENT	NODAL OFFICER/CONTACT DETAILS/EMAIL
1	PANCHAYATI RAJ, AMBALA	MPLAD CONST. OF BUS SHED (BUS QUE SHELTER) IN RAMINAGAR DERA VILLAGE DHEEN BLOCK BARARA DISTT AMBALA	24.07.2026 30.07.2026	3.01 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	0171-2551368 prexeeng.amb@hry.nic.in
2	PANCHAYATI RAJ, KURUKSHETRA	JALBEHRA ,CONST. / RENOV. OF POND VILLAGE - JALBEHRA BLOCK - ISMAILABAD + 2 WORKS	24.07.2026 30.07.2026	133.28 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	9896224357 prexeeng.kr@hry.nic.in
3	MOTILAL NEHRU SCHOOL OF SPORTS, RAI, SONEPAT	LANDSCAPING SERVICES	25.07.2026 14.08.2026	35 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	8708859410 mnssrai@rediffmail.com
4	SHIKH GOVT MEDICAL COLLEGE, NALHAR, NUH	TENDER FOR PROVIDING COMPREHENSIVE MAINTENANCE CONTRACT (CMC) OF HVAC SERVICES AT SHAHEED HASAN KHAN MEWATI GOVT. MEDICAL COLLEGE, NALHAR	27.08.2026 10.08.2026	120 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	0126700282 dirshkmnuh.med-hry@nic.in
5	CIVIL SURGEON NARNAUL	ARRANGEMENT OF FOOD FOR TRAINER & TRAINEE AT DISTRICT TRAINING CENTER OFFICE OF CIVIL SURGEON NARNAUL	25.07.2026 05.08.2026	EMD 10500/-	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	9355471955 dcstrg.mhn@gmail.com
6	FOREST DEPARTMENT, SIRSA	NEW PLANTATION AND MAINTENANCE OF WORKS IN SIRSA, RANIA, DABWALI & KALANWALI RANGE UNDER STATE, CAMPA AND NHAI SCHEME	24.07.2026 29.07.2026	1513.14 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	9416067122 forest_srsa@yahoo.com
7	FOREST DEPARTMENT, SIRSA	PLANTATION MAINTENANCE AND NURSERY WORKS IN SIRSA, RANIA, DABWALI & KALANWALI RANGE UNDER STATE AND CAMPA SCHEME	24.07.2026 30.07.2026	418.38 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	9416067122 forest_srsa@yahoo.com
FOR FURTHER INFORMATION KINDLY VISIT www.etenders.hry.nic.in						RO 47566-I-27-7

Canara Bank Q1 profit rises 2% to ₹4,856 cr, lender eyes USD 1.3 bn

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

State-owned Canara Bank on Monday posted a 2 per cent improvement in net profit to ₹4,856 crore during the first quarter of the current financial year, and said it aims to garner USD 1.3 billion in deposits from overseas Indians.

The Bengaluru-based bank had earned a net profit of ₹4,752 crore in the same quarter of the previous fiscal year. The total income rose to ₹39,684 crore during the June quarter of fiscal year 2026-27, from ₹38,063 crore in the same quarter of FY26, Canara Bank said in a regulatory filing.

Interest earned by the bank improved to ₹32,957 crore as compared to ₹31,003 crore in the June quarter of FY26.

Commenting on the numbers, Canara Bank MD and CEO Brajesh Kumar Singh said the bank's net interest income (NII) crossed ₹10,000 crore this quarter, registering a 13 per cent growth.

NII of the bank rose to ₹10,215 crore from ₹9,009 crore in the same quarter a year ago, he said.

During the post-earnings call, the bank revealed plans to mobilise about \$1.3 billion



through FCNR(B) deposits and another \$1 billion in overseas foreign currency borrowings.

From External Commercial Borrowings (ECBs) and Overseas Foreign Currency Borrowings (OFCBs), Singh said, the bank plans to raise USD 500 million each.

So far, he said, the bank has raised \$75 million under the Foreign Currency Non-Resident (Bank) deposit window.

In a bid to attract foreign currency deposits by Non-Resident Indians (NRIs), Overseas Citizens of India (OCIs) and Persons of Indian Origin (PIOs), the RBI last month withdrew the interest rate ceiling on fresh FCNR(B) deposits of 3-5 years' maturity. The special window is open till September 30.

For ECBs and OFCBs, banks have been given time till

December 31, 2026, by the Reserve Bank of India.

The move came after FCNR(B) deposit inflows weakened sharply, with net inflows dropping to just \$ 946 million in FY26, down from \$7.1 billion in FY25.

In 2023, the RBI had introduced similar schemes when dollar outflows were high, triggered by the taper tantrum. Speaking about recovery, Singh said the bank has done a total recovery of ₹2,500 crore during the quarter and also contained slippages.

Slippage ratio improved to 0.60 per cent, better by 20 bps, he said.

He also said that there is no plan to further dilute the bank's stake in any other subsidiaries at the moment.

During the period under review, operating profit of the bank increased to ₹8,636 crore,

as compared to ₹8,554 crore in the same quarter a year ago.

The bank's asset quality showed improvement as gross non-performing assets (NPAs) declined to 1.57 per cent of gross advances at the end of the June quarter, from 2.69 per cent a year ago.

Similarly, net NPAs, or bad loans, declined to 0.36 per cent, as against 0.63 per cent in the year-ago period.

As a result, provisions for bad loans declined to ₹1,399 crore during the first quarter as compared to ₹1,845 crore in the same period a year ago.

Provision Coverage Ratio (PCR) improved to 94.76 per cent, from 93.17 per cent at the end of the first quarter of the previous financial year.

At the same time, Return on Assets (ROA) deteriorated to 1.04 per cent in June 2026 from 1.14 per cent in June 2025. Capital adequacy ratio of the bank rose to 17.17 per cent from 16.52 per cent in the same quarter of FY26.

Global business of the bank increased by 14 per cent to ₹29,05,066 crore, while total deposits rose by 12 per cent to ₹16,11,685 crore, and total advances by 18 per cent to ₹12,93,381 crore as of June 2026.

LOHUM, CSIR-IMMT unite to strengthen rare-earth magnet manufacturing ecosystem

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Greater Noida

Rare-earth permanent magnets are essential components in electric vehicles, renewable-energy systems, advanced electronics, industrial automation, defence equipment, and several other strategically important applications, yet India remains heavily dependent on imports across this value chain. Establishing domestic capabilities in this space is vital to the country's industrial resilience, technological sovereignty, and long-term economic security.

LOHUM, India's largest diversified producer of sus-



tainable critical minerals and advanced materials, and the Council of Scientific and Industrial Research-Institute of Minerals and Materials Technology (CSIR-IMMT) have signed a Memorandum of Understanding to jointly advance indigenous technology capabilities for the production of metallised neodymium-praseodymium

materials used in high-performance permanent magnets.

Through this collaboration, LOHUM and CSIR-IMMT will combine scientific research, process-development expertise, and industrial execution capabilities to develop and validate technologies for the production of metallised neodymium-praseodymium

(NdPr), one of the core materials needed for manufacturing high-performance rare-earth permanent magnets. The technology being jointly developed is a much safer alternative to the commonly used metal removal by ladle process of Molten Salt Electrolysis.

Rajat Verma, Founder & CEO, LOHUM said: "India's rare-earth magnet ambitions cannot be realised through manufacturing capacity alone. They require indigenous control over critical technologies and materials that underpin the entire value chain. Our partnership with CSIR-IMMT is a step towards building that capability within India".

Srijan redefines education in Assam



TONY DAS
■ Guwahati

Srijan — Beyond Classrooms, a three-day experiential learning initiative by Srijanasom Trust, concluded successfully at Sarokri, Dispur, Guwahati, bringing together over 100 students from various schools across Guwahati. The programme reimagined education by combining Assam's rich cultural heritage with future-ready learning experiences.

With the belief that learning extends beyond textbooks, the programme encouraged students to stay connected to their roots while preparing for the future. A major highlight of the initiative was its focus on preserving Assam's traditional heritage through hands-on experiences in Majuli Mask Making and Mati Akhora, allowing students to engage directly with artists and practitioners and appreciate the state's cultural legacy.

The programme also featured workshops on AI and Future-Ready Skills, Mental Health and Emotional Well-

being, Basic Life Support (BLS), and Calisthenics and Movement, offering students practical life skills through interactive and experiential learning.

The grand closing ceremony was graced by distinguished guests including Hima Das, India's celebrated sprinter and Arjuna Awardee; Dr Purnima Devi Barman, Padma Shri awardee and internationally acclaimed conservationist; Padmapani Bora, IRS, Managing Director of Assam Tourism Development Corporation; and internationally renowned visual artist Santanu Hazarika. Their presence inspired participants to dream big while remaining connected to their values and culture.

The event concluded with a Majuli Mask Display, a Califit Calisthenics Demonstration, certificate distribution, and a high tea. Srijan showcased a new model of education—one that nurtures individuals who are rooted in their heritage while being equipped with skills and mindset needed for future.

EDII's Journal of Entrepreneurship achieves higher global research impact



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Journal of Entrepreneurship (JoE), a quarterly peer-reviewed publication of SAGE on behalf of the Entrepreneurship Development Institute of India (EDII), has reported a marked improvement in its global research impact indicators.

Edited by EDII Director General Dr Sunil Shukla, the journal is indexed in Scopus, the Emerging Sources Citation Index (ESCI) of Web of Science, the ABDC Journal Quality List, EconLit, ProQuest, EBSCO and ANVUR, the Italian National Agency for the Evaluation of Universities and Research Institutes. It currently has an H-Index of 37 and a Journal Impact Factor of 2.5.

Established in 1992, JoE positions itself as a multidisciplinary forum that brings

together academics, researchers, policymakers, educators and practitioners from across the world to examine emerging issues in entrepreneurship, with a particular focus on emerging and developing economies. It publishes original research, conceptual papers, perspectives, case studies and commentaries on themes such as entrepreneurship theory, entrepreneurial behaviour and strategy, ventures, family business, social and international entrepreneurship, leadership, innovation and entrepreneurial ecosystems.

The journal invites contributions from economics, psychology, sociology, anthropology, history and management, and encourages studies from diverse national and cultural contexts to generate insights relevant to both academia and practice.

PVVNL steps up power preparedness for Kanwar yatra

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Meerut/Bulandshahr

In accordance with the vision of the State Government, Paschimanchal Vidyut Vitran Nigam Ltd is working with commitment and dedication to make the Kanwar Yatra successful and safe. Managing Director Ravish Gupta (IAS) is continuously visiting various districts of the Discom, conducting field inspections of the Kanwar routes, and carrying out a detailed review of the electricity arrangements related to the Yatra. Necessary directions are being issued to the officers to ensure uninterrupted and safe power supply for the devotees.

Today, the Managing Director visited Bulandshahr district, where he carried out a field inspection of the Kanwar routes under the 33/11 kV DTM Road and Neemkheda substations. He reviewed the quality and progress of electrical works such as installation of polythene on electric poles, fencing of transformers, guarding beneath power lines, etc., and issued necessary instructions. He directed that overhead power lines on the Kanwar routes be maintained at the prescribed height as per standards, deteriorated power lines be repaired, and transformers mounted on plinths be properly bar-



ricaded.

The Managing Director also conducted a field inspection of the Kanwar route in Bulandshahr district and inspected the route leading to the famous Shri Rajrajeshwar Maharaj Ji Temple, reviewing the electricity arrangements. During the inspection, while observing the condition of electric poles, power lines, transformers, and other electrical equipment, he instructed the concerned officers to complete all required maintenance and corrective works within the stipulated timeframe.

The Managing Director held a meeting with Assistant Engineer-level officers of the urban area and conducted a detailed review of commercial, technical, and Kanwar Yatra-related works. During the meeting, discussions were held in detail regarding revenue collection, reduction

in line losses, quality of consumer services, and ensuring uninterrupted power supply during the Kanwar Yatra.

The Managing Director instructed the officers that no kind of power disruption should occur during the Kanwar Yatra. Special vigilance should be maintained at sensitive locations. Regular inspection of power lines along the Kanwar routes should be carried out, and adequate resources and technical teams should remain available 24x7 to deal with emergency situations. He said that the safety of the devotees is the highest priority, and all officers and employees should work with full coordination and responsibility to ensure uninterrupted, safe, and quality power supply.

The Managing Director directed that all electricity poles falling on the routes through which the Kanwar Yatra will pass or where programmes will be organised should be thoroughly inspected. The meeting was attended by Sanjeev Kumar, Chief Engineer (Distribution), Bulandshahr Zone, Bulandshahr; Harshit Srivastava, Superintending Engineer; Mahesh Kumar Ahirwar, Superintending Engineer; Shishir Kumar Chahi, Superintending Engineer; Sonam Singh, Staff Officer; along with Executive Engineers and Sub-Divisional Officers.

DAILY SUDOKU

63219
12649
98314
547
99287
86914
529

DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★★★★

HOW TO SOLVE IT

Sudoku is a logic puzzle where you fill a 9x9 grid so that numbers 1 to 9 appear once in every row, column, and 3x3 box, using elimination and logical deduction—no maths involved.

SOLUTION (27.7.26)

815274369
423896175
976351842
261749583
358612794
749583216
637428951
184935627
592167438

DOUBLE CROSSWORD
TUESDAY | JULY 28, 2026

12345678
1011
1213141516
171819
20212223
2425262728293031

ACROSS

1 Did it point the way in weaponry? (5)
6 Notices skin blemishes (5)
9 Ropy artist? (7)
10 Excessive water left in food (5)
11 Many wild mobs are apt to be hairy (5)
12 Upset when axed? (3,2)
13 There are jeers around the street for the old fools (7)
15 Laughing talk? (3)
17 Somewhere to get somewhat too slowly! (4)
18 Bag or vessel containing £1 (6)
19 Undertake seriously to use bad language (5)

DOWN

2 Depends once more on deception (6)
3 Where you'll see ducks around the harbour? (6)
4 A lot of money for a bun! (3)
5 He may go to Aberdeen (5)
6 Worldly way to put a wrong clause right (7)
7 It's useful in the theatre (in the pit)? (4)
8 Boast wildly about one Smollett (6)
12 Three, less companionable than two? (5)
13 He's a card! (5)
14 Vessel from Oslo, possibly, at the pierhead (5)

20 Ran away with a sweetheart and used long strides! (6)
22 Appear to check at the information centre (4)
24 Punishing sort of music? (3)
25 Staggeringly closely? (7)
26 Odile, well sozzled, prepared to lie in the sun (5)
27 Picture taken lightly? (5)
28 Yes, woman is a riddle (5)
29 To get out in it can be instructive (7)
30 They're played in threes (5)
31 What it cost to write to New York? (5)

15 A worn key in a gold case (5)
16 Sordid letters to a girl (5)
18 Acceptable number to dial, perhaps (5)
19 Earnest acknowledgements of debt for faultless service (7)
21 No need to get into one if you skip the washing up! (6)
22 Her sin is to spoil a holy place (6)
23 The second team, as it might seem? (6)
25 Bells across the meadow? (5)
26 In Tooting, he can get drunk on gin (4)
28 Thus, on the quiet, it's a peace offering (3)

SOLUTION (27.7.26)

ACROSS
3 Light
8 Years
10 Aisle
11 Eve
12 Spring
13 C-eases
15 L-h-asa
18 Kim
19 Fetter
21 Retired
22 Poor
23 Palm
24 Kai-is-ers
26 Clever
29 Too
31 C-e-r-i-e
32 Tendril
34 Op-Ted
35 Dog
36 Scale
37 Get by
38 Ar-i-e
DOWN
1 Peers
2 Breaker
4 MAPS
5 Hailed
6 Tie-h-t
7 Close
9 Axe
12 Seminar
14 Sit
16 Atlas
17 Ar-O-ma
19 Feasted
20 Space
21 R-over
23 Prodded
24 Keeper
25 Eon
27 Leach
28 Viola
30 Dip-by
32 Teas(e)
33 Rot

20 MTPD curd and lassi plant launched in Bihar

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Patna

Bihar on Monday signalled its intent to emerge as a stronger player in India's fast-growing dairy industry with the foundation stone laying of a modern 20 metric tonne per day (MTPD) curd and lassi processing plant in Nalanda by Chief Minister Samrat Choudhary. The project marks a significant expansion of COMFED's flagship brand Sudha, aimed at meeting the rising demand for value-added dairy products while preparing brand to compete in global markets as India strengthens its position as world's largest milk producer.

The new facility, coming up at BiharSharif Dairy Project, is expected to substantially enhance Sudha's production capacity for curd and lassi, expand its market footprint, and encourage further investments in dairy processing. The expansion is closely aligned with PM Narendra Modi's vision of 'Sahkar Se Samridhi' (Prosperity through Cooperation) and objectives of White Revolution 2.0, launched by Union Home Minister Amit Shah.

CM Choudhary commended COMFED and Bihar's dairy cooperatives for their contribution to the state's rural economy and expressed confidence that Sudha would evolve into a globally competitive dairy brand, creating new opportunities for employment, value addition and higher incomes for dairy farmers. Shirsat Kapil Ashok, IAS, Secretary, Dairy, Fisheries and Animal Resources Department, Government of Bihar, and Managing Director, COMFED (Bihar) State Milk Cooperative Federation Ltd., highlighted the federation's achievements during first 100 days of present government.

When machine says no: Hidden cost of AI in insurance



GOPAL KUMAR V R

Two things in the last month stayed with me. The first was a conference organised by Asia Insurance Post in Mumbai on "AI & Insurance: Transforming India's Risk Landscape," where speakers spoke glowingly about faster underwriting, sharper fraud detection, and claims settled in minutes instead of weeks. I do not doubt any of it; I have seen these efficiency gains myself in projects with insurers in India and abroad. The second was IRDAI constituting a working group to study AI, noting that these technologies "may pose challenges for regulated entities" and introduce "new dimensions of ethical, operational, and cyber security risks." The industry is euphoric; the regulator is cautious.

As an actuary closer to the regulatory and governance side, I believe the truth lies somewhere in between. Like any powerful tool, artificial intelligence comes with its own risks that customers, regulators, and even insurers themselves are still learning to manage. Here are some worth paying attention to. Bias is real. AI learns from past data, and past data often carries historical bias. A model may not be explicitly told about a person's income, religion, or com-

munity, but it can still infer patterns from indirect signals such as where a person lives, the job they do. These variables often reflect deeper social structures.

Consider a health or motor insurer using a fraud model trained on historical claims data. Without any deliberate intent, the model may begin flagging claims from certain geographies or occupational groups more frequently or even pricing them higher. This may arise from patterns embedded in the data rather than any conscious underwriting decision. No underwriter may have explicitly chosen this outcome, yet the effect can be the same.

The black box problem
When a customer asks why a premium has increased or a claim has been denied, "the model said so" is not an adequate answer. It will not satisfy a regulator, an ombudsman, or a court. Globally, regulators are increasingly requiring insurers to explain AI-driven decisions in clear terms. India is moving in the same direction. IRDAI has set up a working group on AI governance, with a focus on maintaining an inventory of AI systems, building explainability frameworks for claims and fraud decisions, conducting AI audits, and performing stress testing. At the same time, the Digital Personal Data Protection (DPDP) Act, 2023 is likely to bring large insurers under stricter data governance as Significant Data Fiduciaries. One emerging approach is the use of synthetic data—realistic but non-

identifiable datasets used to train models, particularly where real data is limited or biased. However, even synthetic data and the models built on it must be carefully validated. Fraud is changing. IRDAI's Insurance Fraud Monitoring Framework Guidelines, 2025 (effective 1 April 2026) recognise this shift by introducing a distinct category for Cyber or New Age Fraud, covering fraud enabled through digital and emerging technologies.

The writer is an actuary, economist and public policy specialist. He is a former board member of IEPFA, Government of India, and currently serves as a member of the Quality Review Board, Institute of Actuaries of India (IAI).

DOON UNIVERSITY DEHRADUN
Mothrowalla Road Kedarpur,
PO Defence Colony, Dehradun-248012
Ph.No: 0135-2533134

Tender Notice
Tender No. E-06/IDU/2026-27 Date 24.07.2026
Doon University invites e-tender for the procurement of furniture at Doon University, Dehradun, Uttarakhand. Tender documents are available in Uttarakhand Govt. e-portal www.uktenders.gov.in. Interested firms may apply through e-portal. Pre-bid meeting 29.07.2026 (11:00 am) at Doon University. Last date of bid-submission is 08.08.2026.
Store & Purchase Officer

BRIEFLY

Tejas Shirse qualifies for men's 110m hurdles final



National record holder Tejas Shirse became the first Indian to qualify for the men's 110m hurdles final at the Commonwealth Games, finishing sixth overall in the heats with a timing of 13.76 seconds here on Monday.

The 24-year-old Shirse finished third in Heat 1, which was topped by overall leader Samuel Bennett of England with a timing of 13.20sec.

First three in each heat and the next two fastest advance to the final of the competition that will held later in the day.

Shirse's season's best came last month during the Indian Athletics Series 9 in Ludhiana where he clocked 13.27sec, which is also the current national record. (PTI)

Lyles pulls up mid-race at US nationals, suffers loss at 200m



Noah Lyles pulled up halfway through the 200-meters final at US track championships Sunday, suffering a rare loss in his best race and allowing USC's Garrett Kaalund to take the title.

In the women's race at Icahn Stadium in New York – the site of Usain Bolt's first world record, back in 2008 – reigning world champion Melissa Jefferson-Wooden cruised to her second straight national title in a season-best 21.69.

Lyles, the four-time world champion at the distance, was in decent shape rounding the turn, but as he pulled into the stretch, he slowed and shut it down. He made it to the finish line to congratulate Kaalund, a 22-year-old who won NCAA indoors at the distance earlier this year. Kaalund's winning time was 20.04.

"I just felt a grabbing sensation. I was like, Yeah, this is the time to stop. There's no reason to push this," said Lyles, who stays tied with Michael Johnson with five US titles at 200 metres. "It was a somewhat of a cramp. I'm fine. I just need to get stretched out, get some electrolytes in my system, but I'll be good."

This marked only the fourth time Lyles has lost a 200 since he started dominating the distance in 2018, shortly after Usain Bolt left the sport. Two of those losses have come at the last two Olympics. (AP)

Sports Minister felicitates Jhandu Kumar for CWG bronze in Glasgow

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ New Delhi

Sports Minister Mansukh Mandaviya on Monday felicitated para-powerlifter Jhandu Kumar with a cash prize of ₹10 lakh for his bronze-winning performance that opened India's account in the Commonwealth Games in Glasgow. The felicitation took place at the minister's residence here. Jhandu won bronze in the men's heavyweight category with a best lift of 190kg.

He hails from Nalanda district in Bihar and sold vegetables and even rode an e-rickshaw to support his family in Harnaut town. He was selected by chief para coach Rajender Rahelu to train at the Sports Authority of India's National Centre of Excellence in Gandhinagar back in June 2023.

"Dr Mandaviya asked me about my experience in Scotland. It was a great feeling to



interact with him," Jhandu was quoted as saying in statement by Sports Ministry.

"I have not had much sleep since the time I have won a medal, due to the excitement and adrenaline rush. My phone has been buzzing throughout," he added.



Gurindervir misses 100m semifinals, finishes 28th overall in heats

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Glasgow

India's fastest man Gurindervir Singh failed to live up to expectations at the Commonwealth Games, crashing out of the men's 100m event after his underwhelming timing of 10.39 seconds left him 28th overall in the heats. Coming into Glasgow with ambitions of becoming the first Indian to break the 10-second barrier, the 25-year-old's effort was far from his best.

Running in Heat 4 from lane five, the Punjab sprinter made a decent start and stayed close to Jamaica's Rohan Watson before fading out in the final 30-35 metres. Watson powered away to win the heat in 10.13 seconds, with Gurindervir finishing second. Watson was overall ninth and made the semifinals on Tuesday.

Inspired by Bekauri, debutant Tokas chases India's first CWG judo gold

HARDIK SHARMA ■ New Delhi

Drawn to combat sports since childhood and inspired by two-time Olympic champion Lasha Bekauri of Georgia, Indian judoka Harsh Tokas is dreaming of creating history by winning India's first ever Commonwealth Games gold medal in judo on his debut in Glasgow.

The 23-year-old, who will compete in the men's 81kg category, discovered judo at the age of 10 after joining a free academy in Delhi's Munirka village.

More than a decade later, the Commonwealth Games represent the biggest stage of his career, and Tokas is determined to settle for

nothing less than the top step of the podium.

"I started judo about 12 years ago when I was around 10 or 11 years old. I am from Munirka village in Delhi. There is an academy in our village run by our coach, he opened it for children free of cost so that anyone could come and train. That is where my journey began," he said.

"I liked combat sports from a young age. There was a judo academy near my home and the environment attracted me. I used to enjoy competing and challenging myself, and that is how my judo career started," he added.

"The only thing on my mind is to win a gold medal. I want to win

a gold medal for my country and make everyone proud."

The Indian judoka team has, however, started on the wrong foot even before landing in Glasgow due to two doping-related suspensions, including last edition's silver-medallist Tulika Maan for whereabouts failure.

Tokas said the education he received at the Vijaya Bharat Foundation has ensured that he is well informed about clean sport and his responsibilities.

"While training at VBF (Vijaya Bharat Foundation), we attended special anti-doping awareness sessions. In those classes, we were taught how to manage our diet, what precautions to take, and

how to complete our whereabouts requirements on time," he said.

"We were educated about all these important aspects of being a professional athlete, and those lessons have stayed with us. We were taught to follow the right path and compete cleanly," he noted.

Despite Glasgow being his Commonwealth Games debut, Tokas insists he is not feeling any pressure, crediting months of intensive preparation for giving him the confidence to compete against the best. (PTI)



Jadumani wins India-Pakistan bout, Preeti one win away from CWG medal



APARAJITA UPADHYAY ■ Glasgow

Jadumani Singh outclassed Pakistan's Sumama Rehman in a high-voltage contest while Asian Games bronze medallist Preeti Pawar barely broke a sweat as the Indian duo marched into the quarterfinals of the Commonwealth Games boxing competition here on Sunday.

Amid thunderous chants of "Bharat Mata ki jai" and "India, India" ringing around the SEC centre, the atmosphere crackled with emotion long before the opening bell of Jadumani's bout.

The Army boxer responded in style, registering a unanimous 5-0 victory through superior technique, speed and ringcraft.

Jadumani, who had dedicated his victory to the heroes of the Kargil War on Kargil Vijay Diwas, reiterated his ambition after another commanding performance.

"I want to dedicate this win to Kargil heroes. I want to defeat everyone and get gold for India," he said.

After a watchful opening round, Jadumani quickly figured out his opponent's rhythm and took complete control of the contest.

He repeatedly found the target with sharp hooks and straight

punches, forcing the referee to give a standing count to Rehman in the second round after a stinging right hand.

With the outcome virtually decided, Jadumani began the final round confidently, standing his ground in the centre of the ring and even inviting Rehman to attack before countering with superior speed and movement.

He is now one win away from a medal as is Preeti (54kg), who won her pre-quarterfinals contest against Deborah Mtenje of Malawi via Referee Stop Contest (RSC) decision in the second round of the bout.

Preeti, who won a bronze in the 2022 Asian Games as well as a gold in the New Delhi World Cup last year, toyed with her opponent.

The Malawi boxer faced two standing counts, one in each round, and it was enough for the referee to stop the bout with 47 seconds left in the second round. Preeti got the unanimous nod of all the five judges in the first round.

The win puts Preeti one victory away from securing her maiden Commonwealth Games medal.

The third boxer in action Aditya Pratap, however, lost his opening round 65kg bout to Uganda's Nuhu Batte 2:3. (PTI)

India's 4x200m freestyle relay team finishes sixth; Australia win gold at CWG



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Glasgow

The Indian men's 4x200m freestyle relay team could not translate an encouraging qualification into a podium finish, ending sixth in the final at the Commonwealth Games swimming competition here on Sunday.

The quartet of Dhakshan Shashikumar, Aneesh Sunil Kumar Gowda, Aryan Nehra and Srihari Nataraj produced a much-improved performance, slashing



nearly 10 seconds off their heat timing to clock 7:29.84.

However, they were unable to match the pace of the leading

teams in a high-quality final.

Australia underlined their supremacy by storming to the gold medal in a Commonwealth Games record time of 7:01.47.

England claimed silver in 7:04.98, while Wales took bronze with 7:09.59. India finished behind fifth-placed Malaysia (7:23.72).

The result highlighted the sizeable gap separating India from the sport's traditional powerhouses despite the relay team's encouraging progress.

Delhi CM inaugurates Commonwealth TT championships

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Monday inaugurated the 22nd Commonwealth Table Tennis Championships 2026 at the Thyagaraj Stadium.

Declaring the championship open in a glittering ceremony, she said the Delhi government is dedicated to promote sports and sportspersons in the city. The championship that will run till August 2, features top players from 25 Commonwealth countries. The Chief Minister also appealed to the people of Delhi to attend the matches in large numbers and cheer for the participating athletes, making the event a grand success.

Delhi's Minister for Education & Sports, Ashish Sood, senior members



of the Organising Committee, officials and players from participating Commonwealth nations were also present on the occasion. Welcoming the players, officials and delegates from across the Commonwealth, Sood said that sports is a universal language that rises above differ-

ences of language, culture and borders to bring people together. He said that on the court, the only language that truly matters is that of discipline, respect, courage and fair play. Table tennis is among the fastest sports in the world, demanding split-second decision-making.

M Sreeshankar qualifies for CWG long jump finals

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Glasgow

Indian long jumper M Sreeshankar made the finals of the Commonwealth Games after breaching the qualifying standard in his very first attempt here on Monday.

Sreeshankar, whose season's best is 8.38m, jumped 8.01m here to earn direct qualification from Group A. The qualification standard has been set



at 8m or at least the 12 best performers. The 27-year-old is hoping to improve on the silver medal that he won in the 2022 edition of the Games.

He is on a comeback trail after recovering a career-threatening knee injury – a ruptured patellar tendon – in April 2024, for which he underwent a surgery. The breakdown had robbed him of a highly anticipated maiden appearance at the Paris Olympics.

He recorded his season's best performance only last month in the National Inter-State Senior Athletics Championships in Bhubaneswar. Lokesh Sathyanathan is the other Indian in fray in the ongoing competition and he will be in action in Group B later in the day.



ENGLAND END INDIA WOMEN'S PAIRS CAMPAIGN



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Glasgow

India endured a disappointing day at the Commonwealth Games lawn bowls as the women's pairs team was knocked out after England won a tense tie-break, while Putul Sonowal's hopes of reaching the men's singles semifinals also came to an end, here on Sunday.

Pinki Singh and Rupa Rani Tirkey's women's pairs campaign ended in heartbreak after they lost to England in a dramatic tie-break in their final Group B sectional match.

After the two sides shared the opening two sets, England held their nerve in the decisive single-end tie-break to seal a 1-1 (3-4, 10-3) victory and eliminate India from semifinal contention.

Sonowal on the other hand suffered a 0.5-1.5 defeat to Malta's Shaun James Parnis in his penultimate Group D match on Sunday.

Sonowal, currently third in the table, will conclude his campaign against bottom-placed Kenya's Anwar Hamada in his final sectional match on Monday.

Tadej Pogacar wins a record-equaling fifth Tour de France title

JEROME PUGMIRE ■ Paris

Tadej Pogacar won a record-equaling fifth Tour de France title on Sunday. The 27-year-old Slovenian dominated this year's race to join Belgian Eddy Merckx, Spaniard Miguel Indurain and Frenchmen Jacques Anquetil and Bernard Hinault as only riders to win five Tours. After finishing safely in Sunday's 21st and final stage in Paris, Pogacar finished 6 minutes, 26 seconds over Belgian rider Remco Evenepoel in the overall standings.

Pogacar's UAE Team Emirates XRG teammate Isaac Del Toro, a 22-year-old Mexican making his Tour debut, was third at 9:42



back from Pogacar, who smiled and held up his hand to signify his wins. His teammates then joined him as they stood proudly on the Champs-Elysees.

Pogacar won five stages at this year's race to take his impressive tally to 26 overall.

He tried to win on Sunday, too, but victory ultimately went

to Dutchman Mathieu van der Poel, who just held off the chasing pack on the home straight for his second stage win at this year's race and fourth overall.

Sunday's 88.7-kilometre (55-mile) stage looped around Paris and was mostly processional, although less so than in previous years, which were usually entirely flat stages for sprinters and not for the rest of the peloton. For the second straight year the stage featured the hugely popular uphill climb through the Montmartre district, a sharp 1-kilometre dash which riders tackled three times before finishing on the Champs-Elysees. (AP)

Esha strikes gold, Manu claims bronze in women's 25m pistol at ISSF World Cup



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Hangzhou

The fast-rising Esha Singh grabbed the gold by upstaging Olympic-medallist Manu Bhaker, who took the bronze to complete a double-podium finish for India in the women's 25m pistol event of ISSF World Cup (Rifle/Pistol/Shotgun) on Monday. The 21-year-old Esha produced a commanding display in the final, registering 40 hits to seal the gold medal, while Paris 2024 double Olympic-medallist Manu fought through a tense, highly-competitive field, winning a crucial shoot-off before finishing with 28 hits to secure bronze. The Indian squad set the bench-mark early in the qualification round. Manu topped the qualifying standings with an outstanding score of 586-20x, closely followed by Esha in second place with 585-18x to comfortably advance to the eight-shooter final. Former Asian Games gold-medallist Rahi Sarnobat posted 582-16x, while Simranpreet Kaur Brar (576-20x) and Abhidnya Ashok Patil (573-16x) delivered steady performances competing under Ranking Points Only (RPO) status.

Reflecting on overcoming the mental pressure following her record-setting World Cup gold in Munich earlier this season, Esha said, "This match was very pressure-riding for me because of the previous medal I had. The better you get in your event, the more you feel that weight of prestige you have to conquer. I'm happy that I was able to get past it today and grateful that I had the ability to endure it. "I really love competing here in Hangzhou. Recalling how the competition went during the Asian Games, where I won four medals, I was really excited to come back. Being familiar with the range, the lighting, and the atmosphere in the final hall definitely counted in my favour." Manu said, "This medal is very important because it acts as a stepping stone. It gives me clarity on what is working and the direction I want to head in."



Intense competition expected in Hockey India Junior Men National championship

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Coimbatore

A total of 30 teams across three divisions will take part in the 16th edition of the Hockey India Junior Men National Championship starting here from Tuesday. Promotion and relegation will add further significance to every fixture in the competition, which will culminate on August 8, as the teams placed in Division A will compete for the title, while the teams in Divisions B and C will be engaged in a battle for promotion to next division. Division A will have 12 teams divided into four pools of three teams each. Pool A comprises Hockey Haryana, Hockey Madhya Pradesh, and Hockey Unit of Tamil Nadu. Pool B consists of Hockey Association of Odisha, Manipur Hockey, Dadra & Nagar Haveli and Daman & Diu Hockey. Pool C will have Hockey Punjab, Hockey Jharkhand, and Delhi Hockey, while Pool D features Uttar Pradesh Hockey,



Hockey Karnataka, and Hockey Bengal. After the conclusion of the league stage, top two teams from each pool will compete in the quarterfinals to be held on August 5. The semifinals will be on August 6 while the playoff for the third-placed side will be on August 8. The bottom two ranked teams in Division A will be relegated to Division B.

Division B will have 10 teams divided into two pools of five teams each. Pool A features Hockey Maharashtra, Hockey Uttarakhand, Hockey Jammu & Kashmir, Hockey Himachal, and Kerala Hockey. Pool B consists of Hockey Andhra Pradesh, Hockey Chandigarh, Hockey Arunachal, Bihar (BSSA), and Chhattisgarh Hockey.

Vaibhav's maturity skyrocketed in last six months: VVS Laxman

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Harare

Impressed with Vaibhav Sooryavanshi's temperament, India's interim head coach VVS Laxman says the teenager's game awareness has "skyrocketed" in the last six months and he is becoming increasingly adept at handling pressure situations. The 15-year-old prodigal talent capped a memorable tour of Zimbabwe by winning both the Player of the Match and Player of the Series awards as India completed a 3-0 sweep with a 35-run victory in the final T20I here on Sunday. "What is really impressive is the way he's evolved as a person. The maturity level, the understanding, and the awareness over the last six months has actually skyrocketed. And that's why he's been able to handle tough situations," said Laxman, during the post-match press conference. Sooryavanshi made 151 runs in three innings at an average of



50.33, with his sparkling 81 in the series finale laying the foundation for India's victory. This came after the teenager endured a forgettable debut series against England, managing scores of 13, 14 and 15 before being dropped from the fifth and final T20I as India slumped to a 0-4 series defeat.

Pick Sooryavanshi for ODIs: Farokh Engineer

SUMAN RAY ■ New Delhi



Teen sensation Vaibhav Sooryavanshi should be drafted into the ODI side as an opener alongside Rohit Sharma ahead of the 2027 World Cup, reckoned former India cricketer Farokh Engineer. The wicketkeeper batter of yesteryears opined that Shubman Gill, the other half of the current opening pair with Rohit, can bat at No. 4, giving more meat to the middle-order. "The ideal situation is Shubman Gill and Vaibhav Sooryavanshi. Gill is a class player. Gill, I think, is the best batsman in the team now. So, Gill should come at four," Engineer told PTI. "Gill is not a guy who lifts the ball. So, a left-right combination would be ideal in ODIs. So, if Rohit is



playing, and I think he should be playing, let him open with Sooryavanshi. "A batsman like him (Sooryavanshi) is much better at opening because he finds bigger gaps in the field. Virat Kohli can come third. Gill can come fourth and then we've got a solid batting line-up," he said. Sooryavanshi bagged the Player of the Series award in the just-concluded three-match rubber against Zimbabwe, scoring 151 runs with two fifties. Engineer felt that the 15-

No sweets, fast food till LA Olympics, says Savita Punia



MONA PARTHSARATHI ■ New Delhi

No sweets, no chocolates, or fast food until the Los Angeles Olympics — this is self-imposed diet pledge taken by the Indian women's hockey team as they sharpen their focus on securing podium finishes at the FIH World Cup and the Asian Games, says the legendary goalkeeper Savita Punia. The Indian team, which scripted history with a fourth-place finish at the Tokyo Olympics, continues to follow their strict fitness regime introduced by the strength and conditioning coach Wayne Lombard, who is back with the team as scientific advisor and head of athletic performance during the Olympic cycle. "Wayne is as good as a trainer as he is strict. He has set very high standards for fitness and always says that if you want to achieve something, you must be willing to sacrifice," Savita

said. She recalled the first decision was to eliminate sugar and junk food from the team's diet before the Tokyo Olympics, and the change in the team's fitness levels is evident. "The first thing in this diet plan was (to) cut out sugar. There were no sweets, chocolates or fast food in the kitchen and that hasn't changed. Recently, after winning the FIH Nations Cup in New Zealand, a cake was ordered for the team, but we all laughed because none of us was going to eat it," she said. "Our fitness level has improved immensely, and that is very important in modern hockey," she added. The veteran custodian, who has represented India in more than 300 international matches, said the biggest difference from Tokyo Olympic campaign is that players are now self motivated to maintain fitness standards.

Agarkar to start learning centre ACE Juniors



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Mumbai

Chief selector Ajit Agarkar and his wife Fatema will launch a new-age early learning centre ACE Juniors on July 29 with a curriculum that will focus on developing creativity, emotional intelligence and communication among children, according to the former India player. The curriculum draws inspiration from Cambridge Early Years, Reggio Emilia, Steiner Education, the Alberta Curriculum and the New Zealand Curriculum Framework, while remaining "deeply rooted in Indian developmental and cultural contexts." "Children today are growing into a world that will demand adaptability, empathy, resilience and problem-solving far beyond academic knowledge. "ACE Juniors is designed to nurture these real-life capabilities from the very beginning, through inquiry, exploration and meaningful experiences," said Fatema, educationist, and founder of Agarkar Centre of Excellence.

Thank you VVS sir for inspiring us: Shreyas Iyer

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Harare

Shreyas Iyer found VVS Laxman's mentorship inspiring, while Laxman marvelled at the young batter's infectious confidence as India's T20 captain and its interim head coach applauded each other's role in the 3-0 sweep of Zimbabwe here. A relatively new-look India, which did not have several regular stars such as Sanju Samson, Axar Patel, Arshdeep Singh and Harshit Rana, hammered the home team and comfortably clinched the series, closing it with a 35-run win in the third and final T20I on Sunday. In a dressing room video released by BCCI, Laxman spoke



at length about Iyer's tough mindset. "I would like to specially congratulate Shreyas because he

Indian men enter pre-quarters in World Junior squash team championship

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ New Delhi

Indian men brushed aside Brazil and the Netherlands to advance to the pre-quarterfinals of the World Squash Junior Team Championships in Ontario, Canada. Fifth seed Indian men swept the Netherlands and Brazil by an identical 3-0 margin to top Group 5 en route to round of 16. The women's team, also seeded fifth, drubbed Chinese Taipei 3-0, and will meet Malaysia next in Group 4.



Anahat was rested for women's opening round, day after being crowned World Junior champion. Results (group stage): Men: India bt the Netherlands 3-0 (Gurveer Singh bt Freek Bonnema 11-4, 11-0, 11-2; Yusha Nafees bt Jesper Hempenius 11-1, 11-4, 11-2; Aryaveer Dewan bt Quinten van Es 11-4, 11-3, 11-5). India bt Brazil 3-0 (Purav Rambhia bt Bernardo Jorge Guimaraes 11-6, 11-5, 11-3; Yusha Nafees bt Matheus Frabetti 11-3, 11-2, 11-9; Aryaveer Dewan bt Viggo Hendricks 11-7, 11-0, 11-0).

Koivun wins 3M Open in his 3rd pro start, holding off Scheffler

DAVE CAMPBELL ■ Blaine (USA)

Jackson Koivun felt the nerves but never flinched, securing his first PGA Tour win in the face of a strong finish by the world's top-ranked player and clear fan favorite in Scottie Scheffler. Koivun won the 3M Open by three strokes Sunday in only his third start as a professional, holding off Scheffler with a closing 5-under 66 for a tournament-



record 25-under 259 total. "All throughout the crowd I kept hearing, Scottie's coming," the 21-year-old Koivun said. "I just tried to tune that out and keep playing the golf I knew I could." Scheffler, who played five groups ahead of Koivun, surged into contention with a 63 but settled for his fifth runner-up finish this season. His lone win this year was in his first start at The American Express in California. (AP)

Jenny Shin claims her first LPGA win in over a decade at Women's Scottish Open

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Troon (Scotland)

South Korean golfer Jenny Shin secured a two-shot victory at the Women's Scottish Open on Sunday to end a wait of more than 10 years for her second LPGA win. The 33-year-old Shin, who won the Texas Shootout in May 2016, carded a 3-over 75 on the Dundonald Links to finish at 9 under. "My first one didn't really feel like a win at the time," Shin said. "I didn't feel like I deserved it. It felt very acci-



dental. But this one definitely feels a lot different. This one feels like I earned it. I worked hard for it." Shin was in tears after the final putt dropped on the 18th and was doused with water and champagne by a group of friends. Leading since the first round, Shin could afford three straight bogies on Nos. 6-8 after starting the final round with a five-shot lead over Thailand's Pajaree Anannarukarn (74). Shin also bogeyed two of the last three holes but had made two birdies earlier.

TRICOLOUR IN HAIR, TEARS IN HER EYES: MIRABAI'S GOLDEN TRIBUTE TO INDIA



APARAJITA UPADHYAY ■ Glasgow

Mirabai Chanu's gold medal at the Commonwealth Games was wrapped in patriotism. As she stepped onto the weightlifting platform on Sunday, the three-time Commonwealth Games champion sported butterfly-shaped hair clips made from tricolour ribbons, a tribute to the country she was determined to make proud. "I wanted to do something for India, so I made these butterfly clips with Indian flag-coloured ribbons last night," Mirabai told PTI after winning the women's 48kg gold. The tricolour remained close to her even after the competition ended. (PTI)